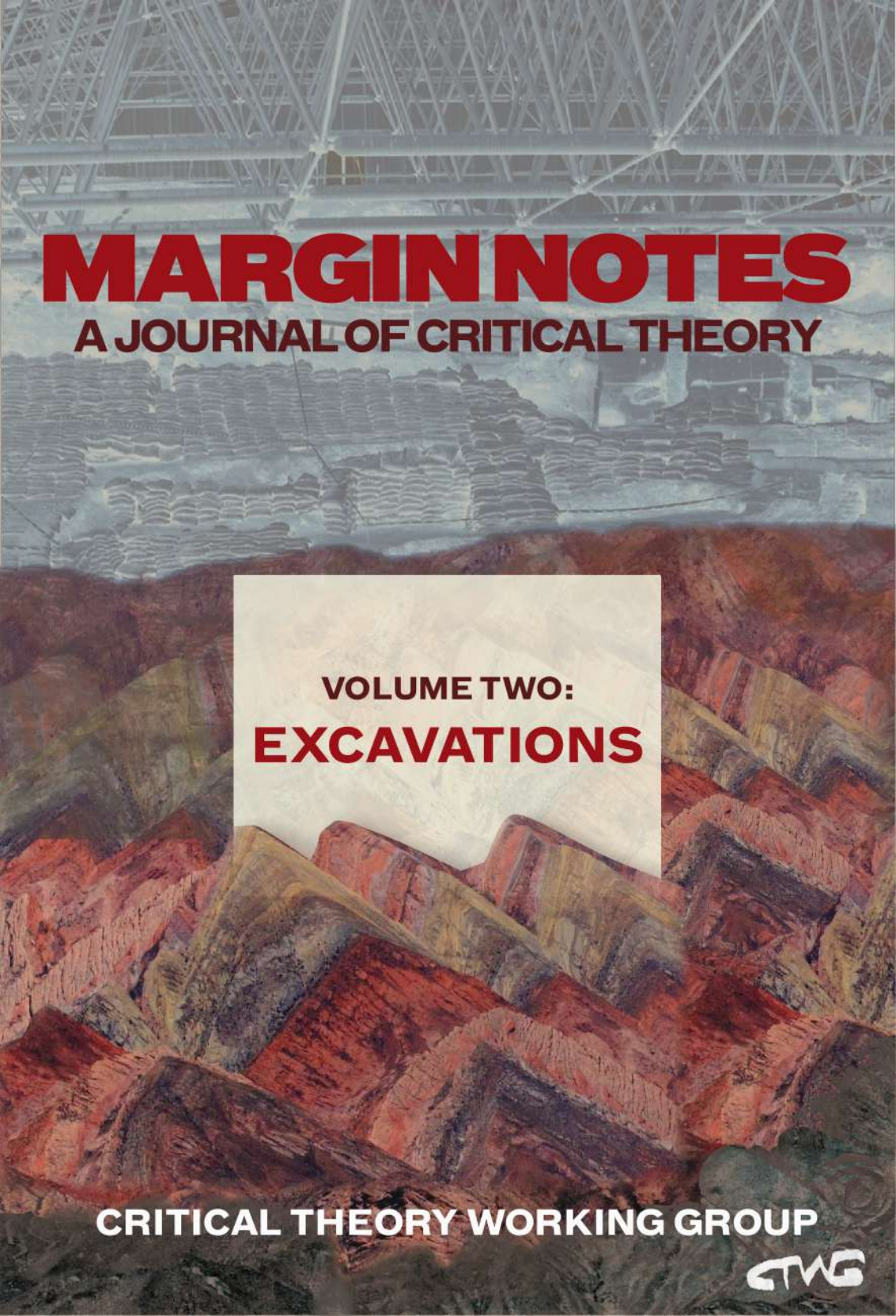

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EXCAVATIONS
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CTWG

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Volume 2: Excavations

Summer 2026

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Preface

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Editorial: Excavations

CTWG Editorial Board

Excavation evokes retrieval. The present volume does not reduce to a recovery of buried paths for the purpose of discarding the topsoil or rejecting accepted claims as confessions of bad faith. We follow instead paleontology to read back the turtle shell and find ribs enlisted as armor. A judgement should not mistake itself as a ground. A theory's failure must not harden into a simple verdict on its thinker when, in reality, a failure is always a failure before conditions unchosen or unclaimed. Both failure and judgment are grounds for excavations that are never not complicit with their yields. Soil and shovel each are subject to a history conserved even as it is disturbed. And if no body is incorruptible, as is our hypothesis, we also expect to feel wonder in these tombs. Better science than graverobbing, but better graverobbing than idle piety. A volume of *gravedigging*, on the hope that the dead still breathe and yearn to be reborn to the surface through the shovels of digger-midwives. In that sense, we are surely feeling for *a* recovery. It may be asked whether we're talking about a lost text, biography, or tradition. It might be answered that what we are searching for is a plan which others have marked out only fleetingly and dismissed as juvenilia: a project, an entire constellation of material, fragmented by the wayside. What if, when recombined and viewed from a certain vantage, the excavated throws light on a whole world of problems? Our gamble is that excavation illuminates again for us the beginnings of neglected paths.

We begin with a return to the political works of Georg Lukács from the early 1920s. In the essay "Lukács in Context: Organization, Revolution, Self-Criticism," J. E. Morain situates Lukács's "ultra-leftist" period within the broader political and discursive field formed in the wake of the revolutionary movements that immediately followed the end of the World War. This environment is obscured by the narrowly philosophical focus of prevailing Lukács reception, which prioritizes the texts published in *History and Class Consciousness* at the expense of his contemporaneous political writings and, as a result, misrepresents Lukács's relationship to the political struggles of the day. Among these more directly political writings, Lukács's rarely read "Self-Criticism," written in the aftermath of the collapse of the Hungarian Soviet Republic, is especially illuminating. It is translated here into English for

the first time as an appendix to the essay, the first of this issue's "excavations".

Morain's essay is followed by a section of fragments authored by members of our group. This volume's fragments concern themselves, roughly, with the history of philosophy, science, and religion. They investigate those disciplines that claim to concern themselves with the truth. We were particularly interested in minor figures, figures outside the 'Western Canon,' or treatments of minor aspects within more well-known figures in the history of Western thought. The texts have been placed roughly in chronological order according to their subject matter, although they are independent of one another and may be read in any sequence. Each fragment treats a specific figure, author, or moment in the global history of human thought, from the third millennium BCE in Sumeria to the 18th-century Age of Revolution. In the interest of style, we have forgone citations and a bibliography, although these are available on request to anyone interested.

In writing these fragments, we have placed no taboo on aesthetic inflection. The practice of writing, whatever form it may take, makes critical use of aesthetic reason. We deploy this practice equally against two one-sided errors: stultifyingly analytical modes of presentation and attempts to cut immediately through the work of thinking with bold images that, as Hölderlin once put it, try to see the soul face to face. The fragment merely emphasizes this aesthetic dimension.

The modern aphoristic fragment is an internally riven tradition running from Montaigne and the French moralists to Schlegel and Novalis, then to Schopenhauer, and finally on to Nietzsche, being later developed for critical theory especially by Adorno, Horkheimer, Benjamin, Bloch, and others.

Millennia before them, the form emerged from the primordial soup of language as poem, parable, proverb, anecdote, apothegm, sententia, epigraph, gnomē, and chreia. On clay and stone, parchment and papyrus, bamboo and palm leaf, antique doxographers left what seemed most emphatic as a subterranean textual patrimony for mankind. All reification is forgetting, but humanity's thingly memory is often the only key to its past. For reification, too, is a social and historical process, and the pressure exerted by society can be discerned from the stratigraphic markers, fault lines, and chemical impurities left in its products.

In the third section of this issue, we include new translations of some texts in the broad tradition of critical theory. We begin first with Hans-Jürgen Krahl's (1943-1970) unfinished essay "Ontology and Eros: On the Speculative Deduction of Homosexuality – A Lemmatical Sketch." Put into English and introduced by J. E. Morain, this brief text goes back to Ancient Greece to investigate the tortuous entanglement of sexuality and metaphysics in Western philosophy and religion. Despite the apparent historical remoteness of his

argument, Krahl's unique perspective as an openly gay Marxist philosopher and political militant suggests a covert intervention into contemporary debates on the relationship between sexuality, liberation, and political organization.

Anatarah bin AlKaf and James Crane recover the work of the original dialectical biologist Julius Schaxel (1887-1943) with a translation of his 1930 essay "The Biological Individual," accompanied here by a gentle biographical sketch and introduction to his thought. Schaxel lived in a fascinating moment in the history of biological theory, where Darwinism was not yet established, the institutions that enshrined biology as the definitive science of life were in flux, and the very status of natural science was contested. His intellectual lineage, development, and interventions as a socialist within both the political economy of knowledge and cultural politics of science are of interest to us today, particularly the project of *Urania*, a socialist science magazine co-founded by Schaxel. We hope in introducing Schaxel to a wider readership that we can help revitalize the project of Marxist science studies and dialectical biology that he started.

In this volume's concluding piece, James Crane has collected and translated a series of texts from Horkheimer and Adorno connected to the former's abortive project to create a book on dialectical logic. Ranging from 1938 to 1949, the collection includes a transcript of a verbal discussion, a book proposal, and several fragments. In his introduction to the translations, Crane argues that, contrary to the verdict of most commentators, the dialectical logic project was a real and realizable theoretical endeavor, not a speculative hobbyhorse that was doomed to come to naught.

We exhume the corpses of the past with neither consolation nor hardness as we recollect, through the fissures in our time of reaction, those still vital possibilities it shrouds in black. We seek to reassemble these fragments with an eye to the reconstruction of a greater project gathering dust but never lost. We search for these pathways so that we may then set off on them with greater resolve.

Essays

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Lukács in Context: Organization, Revolution, Self-Criticism

J. E. Morain

1. Introduction

1.1. Introduction

1920 is an important year in both Georg Lukács's biography and the history of socialism. Following the October Revolution in 1917 and the end of the First World War in 1918, popular unrest across Europe quickly developed into attempts at socialist revolution. Lukács's homeland of Hungary was one site of this revolutionary wave. Amidst an optimistic mood, the Third, Communist International was founded in early 1919 in the recently formed Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic and held its first congress, which for a variety of reasons was only sparsely attended by international delegates. By the end of the year, nearly all of the revolutions that had sprung up had been defeated, at least for the time being. Despite the defeats of so many declared followers of the Russian example, more and more socialist organizations and parties aligned themselves with the new International in Moscow. 1920 would be the year of the Communist International's Second Congress, which was its first truly international congress and, as a result, a decisive event for the future direction of the socialist movement.[1]

In a 2020 paper on Lukács and the practice of intellectual history, Richard Westerman argued that the application of modern intellectual history methods—specifically that of the Cambridge School—to the work of Georg Lukács could "help renew" his work "by drawing out implied claims and assumptions that might hitherto have been hidden—thus pointing to latent and hidden possibilities in our own theoretical toolboxes."[2] I believe that Westerman was right to argue this, and in this essay I will follow his lead, albeit with some significant modifications.

Westerman's text focused on the philosophical context and content of *History and Class Consciousness,* arguing that it is necessary to situate Lukács in

[1] For a brief overview of the context and events of the congress, see Ch. 5 in John Riddell, *Lenin's Comintern Revisited* (Brill 2026).

[2] Richard Westerman, "Lukács in the 1920s and the 2020s: The practice and praxis of intellectual history," *Thesis Eleven*, Vol. 157, No. 1 (April 2020), 1-17; 3.

the context of Neo-Kantianism to properly understand him.[3] I agree with this argument, but in this essay I would like to shine the spotlight on Lukács's political writings, in particular those from the year 1920, and analyze them in light of two crucial pieces of political context: the aftermath of the Hungarian Revolution of 1919 and the Second Congress of the Comintern in 1920. Two texts from 1920 serve as focal points in this analysis: Lukács's Hungarian-language "Self-Criticism," an English translation of which is included as an appendix to this essay, and his German-language essay "Legality and Illegality," which was later reprinted in unmodified form in *History and Class Consciousness*.

Lukács's "Self-Criticism" is rarely referenced, but it provides crucial insight into how he conceptualized the failure of the Hungarian Revolution. Published mid-August 1920 in the Hungarian communist periodical *Proletár*, the text pairs startlingly frank admissions of naïveté, inexperience, and error with a serious attempt to describe the causes of the fall of the Hungarian dictatorship of the proletariat.

"Legality and Illegality" is a similarly suggestive text. Drafted in response to the flood of texts being published in the run-up to the Comintern's Second Congress, it was the only essay reprinted without any alterations in *History and Class Consciousness*, indicating that Lukács had particular confidence in its argument for several years afterwards. Moreover, it was written in July of 1920, implying a potential overlap with the composition of the "Self-Criticism." In the essay, Lukács performs a concealed self-criticism and reinforces the conclusions made in his post-mortem of the Hungarian Revolution.

1.2. Thesis and Method

My approach in this essay is to largely bracket Lukács's pre-1919 biography and focus on his immediate political situation in 1920 instead of bracketing his immediate political situation in order to construct a biographical narrative or timeless political judgment. In this sense, I am giving precedence to the synchronic over the diachronic, or rather narrowing the scope of the synchronic to about a year. Lukács's immediately political texts—I place in this category those that are principally and explicitly concerned with questions of organization, tactics, and strategy—are given precedence over more theoretical or philosophical texts, of which he wrote little in 1920. At a certain level, I am hypothesizing that the former holds the key to the latter and making experimental interpretations under that assumption.

Thus, I will be treating Lukács mainly as a political writer and activist in the Marxist tradition and not a philosopher as such. I acknowledge that

[3] Westerman, "Lukács in the 1920s and the 2020s," 6

this is an artificial hermeneutic device, but it is at least consciously artificial. Biographical studies do not even attempt to justify the construction of the biographical object, and perennialized political evaluations generally fail to go beyond dogmatic comparison with pre-established images of Marx, Lenin, Trotsky, Stalin, or whoever else the author alternatively idolizes or despises.

Sometimes Lukács's own dishonest retrospective framing of his early Marxist writings as "ultra-leftist" and "messianist"[4] is uncritically accepted. Labels like "ultra-leftist" distort the historical picture by dogmatically articulating genuine political disagreements as erroneous deviations from a single, correct political doctrine. Moreover, the all-too-common conclusion that Lukács's embrace of a "leftist" Marxism was due to his above-it-all, bohemian intellectual background sits uncomfortably with two important facts. On one hand, the "leftist" position was extremely popular in the Comintern at the time, holding the upper hand in numerous parties during the 1920s, and, on the other hand, Lukács consistently displayed a markedly moderate stance on political tactics in Hungary.

Intellectual-biographical and philosophical accounts of Lukács's work often foreground the continuity between the pre-Marxist and Marxist periods of his biography, downplaying the importance of political context in the process. Michael Löwy's use of the theme of "romantic anti-capitalism" in his classic *Georg Lukács: From Romanticism to Bolshevism* leads him to adopt this perspective at times. Arpad Kadarkay's studies of Lukács are in general more concerned with the drama of his biography and the utility of the Magyar intellectual as novelistic figure in whom the drama of the 20th century in Central Europe is made incarnate than the content of Lukács's thought, and so Kadarkay has no qualms passing by most of Lukács's literary production and interpreting *History and Class Consciousness* as a book in which "Ideas transported out of philosophy are found [...] meddling rashly in revolutionary practice."[5] In *Lukács's Phenomenology of Capitalism: Reification Revalued*, Richard Westerman skips directly from the defeat of the Hungarian Revolution in August 1919 to the writing of *History and Class Consciousness* in 1922 in the space of a page, offhandedly claiming that "the collapse of the Hungarian Council Republic at the beginning of August 1919 brought little immediate alteration in the tone of his work."[6] While Westerman's arguments for the importance of Neo-Kantian thought for Lukács are convincing, the lack of attention given to political factors is a clear lacuna in his work.

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[4] Georg Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness: Studies in Marxist Dialectics*, tr. Rodney Livingstone (MIT Press, 1972), xiv, xv.

[5] Arpad Kadarkay, *Georg Lukács: Life, Thought, and Politics* (Basil Blackwell, 1991), 270

[6] Richard Westerman, *Lukács's Phenomenology of Capitalism: Reification Revalued* (Palgrave MacMillan 2019), 88

I demonstrate below that Lukács's political positions developed in the context of the Hungarian Revolution and its aftermath through engagement with debates ongoing within the nascent Communist International, rather than as translations of prior philosophical positions into political terms. Lukács's answers to the most important questions of the day show that he closely followed the back and forth between Paul Levi and Karl Radek, considered local particularities when evaluating tactics, and relented to superior arguments when presented with them. Far from being a zealot, Lukács often comes across as informed and reasonable. The evolution of the Magyar class-traitor's arguments shows the truth of Jörg Kammeler's judgment that the "real years of apprenticeship of Lukács's Marxism can be seen as a process of permanent self-criticism."[7]

Within the existing literature, my argument is closest to that of the aforementioned Jörg Kammeler's magisterial study *Politische Theorie von Georg Lukács*, but I have two major criticisms of his arguments. The first is that Kammeler, in correctly arguing that Lukács's political ideas drew heavily on Rosa Luxemburg, often implies that these ideas were therefore in opposition to the politics being put forward by the Comintern: Kammeler claims, for instance, that Lukács took up the directives of the Comintern's second congress "with characteristic modification."[8] This remark misses the fact that the Comintern's directives were produced precisely in order that they would be modified and that a system of norms against which Lukács's "characteristic modifications" would stand out as abnormal was still incipient and yet to be articulated as an enforceable institutional relation.

My second criticism is that Kammeler's "practical-critical" mode of presentation did not go far enough.[9] Kammeler is, again, correct in one sense to gloss Lukács's theory of class consciousness as a product of his philosophy of history, but such an interpretation neglects the substantial differences in content between the two thoughts in favor of emphasizing their rhetorical continuity and homological parallels. When Lukács's political writings are treated as equally authoritative as his theoretical writings, the points of rupture become clearer.

Lukács's "Self-Criticism" and "Legality and Illegality" are texts that strongly agree with arguments and conclusions made in the lead-up to the Second World Congress of the Comintern by authoritative figures like Grigorii Zinoviev and V. I. Lenin. Lukács's orthodoxy is, however, not the focal point of my analysis here. Rather, the question becomes how and why a statement

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[7] Jörg Kammler, *Politische Theorie von Georg Lukács: Struktur und historischer Praxisbezug bis 1929* (Luchterhand, 1974), 135.

[8] Kammeler, *Politische Theorie von Georg Lukács*, 192.

[9] Kammler, *Politische Theorie von Georg Lukács*, 137.

of like-mindedness so little resembles the documents it was written to support. This redirects the analysis to everything surrounding the core political claims of the essay: argument, rhetoric, authorial voice, genre, context, and so on. Analysis of these elements is necessary for an understanding of the discursive formation that Lukács's writings were part of.

Lars Lih's *Lenin Rediscovered* was a significant point of reference for this paper. I have, in part, imitated that book's structure: a relatively extensive review of discursive context followed by a relatively intensive analysis of a small number of texts. Quentin Skinner's writings on method provided compelling principles for historical analysis that I have, to the best of my ability, tried to heed.[10] In my textual analyses, I follow him in interpreting texts as communicative acts that depend on their context. Michel Foucault's archeological system also provided me with a number of useful concepts and guidelines for in-depth analysis of discourse as a system of relations.[11]

In my analysis of Lukács's context, I employ a concept of discursive revolution, which is to be understood as a variation on Thomas Kuhn's conception of scientific revolution.[12] In short, a discursive revolution inaugurates a new discursive formation. The discursive revolution that forms the context for Lukács's texts had clear external causes and an embryonic (but increasingly powerful) apparatus for the regulation of the discursive formation it created, Leninism. It remained an ongoing and unsettled matter because of both the undeveloped form of its corresponding institutional apparatus and the unresolved problems and questions internal to the discursive formation.

While political discourse about principles, strategy, tactics, organization, etc. became increasingly regulated in the Comintern after the Second Congress in fall 1920, the development and subsequent enforcement of a systematic orthodoxy on all intellectual matters only properly began in 1922 alongside the introduction of the New Economic Policy in Russia.[13] Censorship was therefore not an important factor because it was not yet in place. Moreover, Lukács's autobiographical reflections indicate that most of the changes in position he made throughout the 1920s were the result of genuine persuasion and reflection, not duress.

The word revolution seems appropriate to describe the advent of Leninism as a distinctive discourse and political doctrine more because of its willed

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[10] See his *Visions of Politics, Volume One: Regarding Method* (Cambridge University Press, 2002)

[11] Michel Foucault, *The Archeology of Knowledge,* tr. A. M. Sheridan Smith (Harper Colophon Books, 1976)

[12] Thomas Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (University of Chicago Press, 1996), Ch. X ff

[13] This is the periodization proposed by René Zapata, see René Zapata *Luttes Philosophiques en URSS 1922-1931* (Presses Universitaires de France, 1983)

character than the radicality of the changes involved. With regard to the latter, the groundbreaking work of Lars Lih and associated revisionists like Eric Blanc on Russian Social Democracy and the Bolsheviks has argued that there was considerable continuity between the Marxism of the Second International and that of the Bolsheviks and early Communist International.[14] The degree of rupture between the Comintern and the Second International grew with the years, and Lukács's work can help us better understand the dynamics of debate, continuity, and discontinuity in the discursive revolution birthed by the socialist revolutions of 1917-1923.

In summary, I argue that Lukács's political stances were primarily influenced by his political context, not his philosophical background. Below, I analyze two texts ("Self-Criticism" and "Legality and Illegality") and two major pieces of context (the Hungarian Revolution and the Second World Congress of the Comintern), arguing that these two texts, when placed in context, are key for understanding his political development. My analysis draws attention to questions of rhetoric, textual genre, and the texts' places within the discursive formation of the Comintern. Inter alia, effort is made to demonstrate that the depiction of Lukács as a philosophically deluded "ultra-leftist" unmoored from practical considerations is mistaken.

Section 2 begins (2.1) with a brief review of the Hungarian Revolution, its aftermath, and Lukács's activity during both. Following this, two major pieces of context are analyzed: the publication in which many of Lukács's political writings appeared, *Kommunismus*, and the debate within the Hungarian communist movement about tactics. In the final subsection (2.4), I survey the various evaluations of the Hungarian Revolution made by participants and observers, closing out with an analysis of Lukács's own contribution to this discussion, his 1920 "Self-Criticism."

Section 3 is dedicated to the analysis of "Legality and Illegality" as a discursive act. In the first subsection, I provide some important context for the Second World Congress of the Comintern. Following this, I analyze the illocutionary dimension of "Legality and Illegality" and how the text serves as a performance of communicative acts. Finally, in Section 3.3 I analyze the content of "Legality and Illegality," focusing on the multivalent meaning of the term "consciousness" in the text and its relation to the archive of Marxist discourse.

In the Conclusion (**Section 4**), I turn to consider the institutional and discursive relations emerging in the Comintern and how they affected Lukács's literary production.

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[14] See Lars Lih, *Lenin Rediscovered: What Is to Be Done in Context* (Haymarket Books, 2008) and Eric Blanc, *Revolutionary Social Democracy: Working Class Politics Across the Russian Empire (1882-1917)* (Brill, 2021)

The bibliography of Lukács compiled by Maruyama Keiichi[15] was of tremendous use for determining and tracking of dates of publication and related facts, as were the other online resources afforded by the Lukács Archive, which is thankfully set to reopen following the much-anticipated fall of the Órban government earlier this year.[16] All quotations from German sources were translated by the author unless otherwise noted.

1.3. Proleptic Remarks on Language

Before 1919, Lukács was a career bohemian who published essays and the occasional book while primarily subsisting on allowances drawn from his father's considerable fortune. His work and outlook was greatly influenced by the contemporary titans of the Central European intelligentsia, some of whom he had become personally acquainted with, and the classical German philosophers of the 19th century.[17] Lukács explained in what would be his final interview that he had only a rough knowledge of Marxism, listing Karl Kautsky, Franz Mehring, and Georges Sorel as the authors he was most familiar with.[18] He was ignorant of Lenin and the revolutionary anti-war minority in the socialist movement until, in his words, "very late." As a result, his very first writings as a Marxist activist are chocked full of language drawn from Kant, Fichte, Hegel, and more recent Neo-Kantian scholars. The imprint of Neo-Kantianism is visible in almost all of Lukács's philosophical work, but only in the years 1919 and 1920 can one find defenses of Marxism accompanied by emphatic references to the categorical imperative and other concepts drawn from the idealist tradition.

This would not, however, have necessarily been a sign of pernicious idealism to Marxists of the time. The leading intellectuals of Austrian Social Democracy unabashedly cited Kant and the Neo-Kantians on topics from ethics to epistemology, as did members of the various factions within the Russian socialist movement. As one of the leaders of the Austrian Social Democrats, Max Adler, argued in a review of Russian Marxist Georgi Plekhanov's *Fundamental*

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[15] `https://www.lana.info.hu/en/lukacs/bibliography-of-georg-lukacs/`

[16] Justin Weinberg, "Authoritarianism & Philosophy: After Orbán's Ouster, an Effort to Reopen the Lukács Archive," *Daily Nous*, 06/15/2026 `https://dailynous.com/2026/06/15/authoritarianism-philosophy-after-orbans-ouster-an-effort-to-reopen-the-lukacs-archive/`

[17] Michael Löwy argues that the seeds of Lukács's socialism are visible in the romantic anti-capitalism of the *fin de siécle* Central European intelligentsia, see the first two chapters of his *Georg Lukács: From Romanticism to Bolshevism*, tr. Patrick Camiller (New Left Books, 1979). More recent studies have focused on the Neo-Kantian context of his work.

[18] Georg Lukács and András Kovács, "Georg Lukács: the final interview," tr. David Fernbach, *Verso Blog* (25 March 2022) `https://www.versobooks.com/blogs/news/5309-georg-lukacs-the-final-interview`

Problems of Marxism, it was not at all clear that the content of Marxist theory and politics had anything to do with ontological "Weltanschauungsfragen."[19] Max Adler was somewhat unique in his outright rejection of conceiving Marxism as a *Weltanschauung*, but Plekhanov was also unique in his absolute intransigence on what he considered to be the foundations of the Marxist *Weltanschauung*—an intransigence that was largely passed on to his Bolshevik successors.

Adler's stance—Nikolai Bukharin's could be adduced as another example—shows that terms and concepts that would be crucial to Lukács's work such as consciousness and dialectic were up for debate in the early 20th century. It was not inconceivable that a Marxist could use language reminiscent of philosophical idealism while still being committed to revolutionary socialist politics. Nor was it inconceivable that someone committed body and soul to Marxism as a *Weltanschauung* could be against revolution: Plekhanov himself died in 1918 as a staunch opponent of the ascendant Bolsheviks. Marxism was undergoing a discursive revolution, and it would be fallacious to project the dogmatic enforcement of later Soviet dialectical materialism backwards onto the year 1920.

Within the communist movement, different figures had wildly different ideas about the future of philosophy and related theoretical endeavors. Some Russian Marxists argued that philosophy should cease to exist as an independently recognizable discourse. The followers of Plekhanov's ideas in the USSR wanted to maintain philosophy as a discipline, but ultimately reduced to an auxiliary support of politics over the next several decades. Lukács's texts, meanwhile, sometimes suggested a fusion of philosophy and politics. The relation between political and philosophical language, even within the oeuvre of a single author, was much more discursively problematic at this time than the future official discourse of Marxism-Leninism would suggest in retrospect.

2. The Hungarian Revolution and its Aftermath

2.1. The Revolution

Before joining the Party of Communists in Hungary in December 1918, Lukács had never been a member of any political party or movement.[20] The time,

[19] Max Adler, "Marxismus und Materialismus," *Der Kampf*, Jg. 3, No. 12, 1 September 1910, 564-571. Accessed online at `https://www.marxists.org/deutsch/archiv/adler-max/1910/09/marx-mater.htm`

[20] Lukács and Kovács, "Georg Lukács: the final interview," `https://www.versobooks.com/blogs/news/5309-georg-lukacs-the-final-interview`

however, was ripe for politicization. Unrest had been brewing throughout the war, and in the last days of October 1918 this boiled over into a political revolution. The National Council, a body recently assembled from leaders of the Independence Party, the National Radical Bourgeois Party, and the Social-Democratic Party, had won the allegiance of the police and most of the army. A spontaneous occupation of Budapest's municipal centers of power by revolutionary soldiers on the night of October 30th led the king/emperor to form a coalition government headed by Count Mihály Károlyi, the leader of the National Council, the following day.[21] Within the space of another day the king, under heavy pressure, released this new government from its oath of loyalty. A little over two weeks later the Republic of Hungary was proclaimed before parliament.

This new republic was immediately imperiled by the military incursions made by the Little Entente—Czechoslovakia, Romania, and Yugoslavia—and the ongoing social and political turmoil. The Károlyi government had concluded an Armistice with the Entente that kept Hungarian troops out of much of the southern portion of the old Kingdom's territory, undermining its legitimacy. Amidst this tumult, the Károlyi government resigned and was replaced by a Social Democratic government on January 8. With the Little Entente's armies continuously advancing and the big Entente proposing further contraction of Hungary's borders, the Social Democrats ultimately decided to form a joint government with the surging Communist Party on the 21st of March. The two organizations, which had been at each other's throats just days ago, merged to become the Socialist Party of Hungary (renamed in June to the Hungarian Socialist-Communist Workers' Party). Hungary was declared a council republic—it would eventually be officially named the Hungarian Socialist Federative Council Republic—and the new dictatorship of the proletariat began frantically attempting to reorganize society while simultaneously repelling a three-pronged military assault.

After acceding to power in March 1919, the Hungarian communists sent one of their own, Ernst Bettelheim, to Vienna under orders to organize a revolution. Bettelheim quickly usurped the leadership of the recently founded Communist Party of German Austria (KPDÖ) and then attempted to organize an insurrection in the summer, provoking the arrest of the party's entire leadership and the violent quelling of the uprising in Vienna on June 15. The fallout of this debacle would birth years of factional infighting in the Austrian party, and no doubt contributed to the strife that would develop in the Hungarian one, too.[22]

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[21] Gábor Vermes, "The October Revolution in Hungary: from Károlyi to Kun" in *Hungary in Revolution 1918-1919: Nine Essays*, ed. Iván Völges (University of Nebraska Press, 1971), 31-60; 36

[22] For more about the relevance of this event to Lukács see Rudolf Schlesinger, "Historical

The day following the failed insurrection in Vienna, another Hungarian-backed attempt at revolution foundered in Slovakia.[23] The exhausted revolutionary government in Budapest found itself besieged on all sides: the Entente's diplomatic pressure had forced them to withdraw from Czechoslovakian territory; the peasants they had alienated with their out of touch land reform policy were increasingly in open revolt; the Red Army's attempt to push into Romanian-held territory provoked a decisive counter-attack; and the government itself was collapsing under factional conflict between the Social Democrats and communists. Thus the Trade Union Council, acting in concert with the social democrats, demanded on July 31 that the Governing Council resign. After some resistance the communists acquiesced. A few days later the Romanian army entered Budapest, and within months a counterrevolutionary reign of terror would begin.

Lukács briefly served as (Deputy) People's Commissar for Public Education for the Council Republic and then, even more briefly, as the political commissar for a battalion belonging to the Fifth Division of the Hungarian Red Army and later the entire Fifth Division.[24] In other words, he was not a mere paper member of or intellectual appendage to the revolutionary movement. Lukács had risked his own life and showed himself willing to take those of others for the revolution.[25] In return, he would be exiled from his homeland, which, having been a regular author for left-wing nationalist publications before 1918, he loved dearly.

Set to flee to Austria on a sealed train protected under diplomatic immunity, Béla Kun, the informal leader of the Council Republic, rashly ordered Lukács and his comrade Ottó Korvin to stay in Hungary and organize the party—or at least what was left of it—in clandestinity.[26] While Lukács was able to escape the white terror and make it to Austria, Korvin was quickly captured and sentenced to death alongside the so-called Lenin Boys, the primary agents of Hungary's brief and relatively insignificant episode of red terror. Lukács wrote a tribute to Korvin in the November 28, 1919 issue of the Austrian *Rote Fahne* that was later translated into Hungarian and reprinted with slight

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setting of Lukács's *History and Class Consciousness*" in *Aspects of History and Class Consciousness*, ed. István Mészáros (Routledge, 1971)

[23] Bennett Kovrig, *Communism in Hungary: From Kun to Kádár* (Hoover Institution Press, 1979), 60.

[24] Georg Lukács, *Record of a Life: An Autobiographical Sketch*, ed. István Eörsi, tr. Rodney Livingstone (Verso, 1983), 60ff.

[25] In his capacity as political commissar he had eight men court-martialed and summarily executed for cowardice after their battalion fled from battle; see Lukács, *Record of a Life*, 65.

[26] Lukács later claimed that he believed at the time that he and Korvin were "being prepared for martyrdom" by Kun due to their disagreements with him. Lukács, *Record of a Life*, 68.

changes in the August 19, 1920 issue of *Proletár*.[27]

The communist émigrés who had fled Hungary for Austria, many initially detained by the authorities and threatened with deportation, would regroup in Vienna over the course of a few months. Over time, the party in exile tended to split into two factions: one based in Moscow centered around the former paramount revolutionary leader, Kun, and one based in Vienna centered around Jenő (Eugen) Landler, the former People's Commissar of Internal Affairs, Commander-in-Chief of the Red Army, and presently a member of the toothless Provisional Central Committee alongside Lukács, Kun, and a few others.[28] What little remained of the party in Hungary was, meanwhile, in complete disarray, and the question of what to do about this situation would be the primary concern of the Hungarian communists for the next several years.

2.2. *Kommunismus* and the Communist International

"Legality and Illegality" was written in July and published in September of 1920 in the weekly periodical *Kommunismus*, which proclaimed its status as the *Zeitschrift der kommunistischen Internationale für die Länder Südosteuropas* (periodical of the Communist International for the countries of South-East Europe) on its front page. *Kommunismus* was officially an organ of the Vienna bureau of the Comintern, but it was published and managed by the Communist Party of German Austria (KPDÖ). Lukács and other Hungarian émigrés were members of its editorial circle, serving under the editor-in-chief Gerhart Eisler (brother to both the composer Hanns Eisler and the infamous KPD leader Ruth Fischer).[29] Even though it was *de jure* managed by the Austrian party, the pages of the journal were often dominated by the writings of the Hungarian émigrés: László Rudas, Eugen Varga, Béla Kun, Jenő Landler, and of course Lukács himself, and in spite of its official affiliation with the Comintern, the journal tended towards the left due to the political position of the Austrian editors and their Hungarian émigré comrades.

The first issue of *Kommunismus* is unremarkable: the editorial introduction to the publication as a whole announces that "with the victories of the Russian Revolution, the workers movement of the whole world has entered a new epoch" and that "we are in the middle of the world revolution."[30] The issue included articles by the Hungarians E. V. (Eugen Varga) and B. K. (Béla Kun)

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[27] A transcription of the German version is available at `https://www.lana.info.hu/de/otto-korvin/`

[28] See the biographical note in Lukács, *Record of a Life*, 192.

[29] Károly Kókai, "The Communist International and the Contribution of Georg Lukács in the 1920s" in *Social Scientist*, Vol. 45, No. 11/12 (November–December 2017), 63-72; 65.

[30] Unsigned, "Zur Einführung" in *Kommunismus*, 1 Jg., no. 1/2 (February 1, 1920), 1, 2.

and featured an advertisement in the back for pamphlets by Bukharin, Lenin, Radek, Zinoviev, Trotsky, and Kun. *Kommunismus* had a consciously international(ist) scope, including alongside diverse articles by authors from all over Europe a section titled "International Review" that dealt "with countries such as Germany, Austria, Hungary, the Balkans, England, France, Italy and 'America.' "[31]

Kommunismus sometimes flaunted its Comintern affiliation and published articles by authors who were on the outs with the Moscow-based Executive Committee of the Communist International (ECCI) such as Anton Pannekoek (Vol. 1, No. 28/29, August 1, 1920) and Henriette Roland Holst (Vol. 2, Nos. 1-8, January-March 1921.)[32] Both were members of the problematic Dutch section of the Comintern who would soon depart to form their own party in large part due to the resolutions of the Comintern's Second Congress, but even before their exit the activities of the Dutch communists had already provoked the dissolution of the Amsterdam Sub-Bureau of the Comintern in May 1920, with Karl Radek explicitly citing their "sectarian politics" as the reason.[33]

The minority position of *Kommunismus*, exhibited in its apparent alignment with the Dutch communists, led to criticism from Moscow at a very early stage: Grigorii Zinoviev, the Chairman of the ECCI, threatened Lukács in particular with disciplinary measures because of his April 1920 article "Class Consciousness."[34]

Beginning in the fifth issue, published on the 22nd of February 1920, *Kommunismus* ran a series of articles responding to and criticizing the tactical directives disseminated by the West European Secretariat of the Comintern, directives which originated as excerpts from Karl Radek's pamphlet *Die Entwicklung der Weltrevolution und die Taktik der Kommunistischen Partei im Kampf um die Diktatur des Proletariats*.[35] Radek was the most important representative of the Comintern in Europe at the time, so criticism of his directives was a rather serious matter.

The first article in the series, written by László Rudas, criticized Radek's argument that the intellectuals of Europe could be universally "won over" (*gewonnen*) to the side of the proletariat, as well as the "pathetisch-journalistisch" tone of the document and its lack of attention to several pressing issues. This was followed next week by Lukács's article "Zur Frage des Parliamentarismus," which further piled on Radek's tactical proposals by criti-

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[31] Kókai, "The Communist International…" 65-66.

[32] See also the list of authors in Michael Löwy, *Georg Lukács: From Romanticism to Bolshevism*, tr. Patrick Camiller (New Left Books, 1979), 156.

[33] Radek quoted in Jörg Kammler, *Politische Theorie von Georg Lukács*, 162.

[34] Kadarkay, *Georg Lukács: Life, Thought, and Politics*, 260.

[35] See L. R. [László Rudas], "Fragen der kommunistischen Taktik" in *Kommunismus*, 1 Jg., no. 5 (February 22, 1920), 130ff.

cizing the validity of participation in parliament during the offensive stage of the revolutionary process. This could scarcely have been well received by the Comintern leadership, and indeed Lenin himself would single out Lukács's essay for criticism in June (see Section 3.1 below).

Immediately following this series of anti-Radek articles appeared Lukács's essay "Organisationsfrage der dritten Internationale" in the March 15 issue of *Kommunismus*. The text illustrated a rather unique picture of the International, which at this time was still in its infancy and was yet to have its first genuinely *international* (and not merely *Russian*) congress. Jörg Kammeler ties the essay to the proposals made at a conference held on February 3, 1920 by the Amsterdam Bureau of the Comintern where support for a decentralized organizational model was first expressed.[36]

In the essay, Lukács uses the language of idealism to argue that "the Second International viewed itself *as reality*, while the Third International is a regulative idea for the action of the proletariat, its unavoidable goal."[37] The "regulative idea" that governed the new International was that of the unity of the entire proletariat regardless of national boundaries, which capitalism was itself abolishing day-by-day.[38] Lukács clarifies a few pages later that this description of the International as a "mere" idea is realism, not philosophizing. The plain and simple truth for him was that at the moment—March 1920—the Third International existed only as an idea which had not yet "penetrated into immediate reality."[39] Given the dysfunction of the Comintern in that moment, Lukács's diagnosis is far from absurd.

Furthermore, the difficulties of coordination and communication between geographically dispersed parties—let alone underground ones—indicated the impracticality of lending strong authority to a central office or even the congresses of the new International, meaning that a decentralized structure was necessary. Thus, Lukács argued that "The [organizational] chaos can only be vanquished by *solid principles and dynamic and elastic tactics,*" which would construct proletarian unity "from below."[40] An ensemble of "tactical centers" would assist in the coordination of individual parties without, however, imposing any limitations on the "immediate relations of the parties between themselves." The intimacy of relations between these parties, which would no longer be organized around strictly national lines, would be so great that

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[36] Kammeler, *Politische Theorie von Georg Lukács*, 200ff

[37] Georg Lukács, "Organisationsfragen der Dritten Internationale," *Kommunismus*, 1 Jg., No. 8/9 (March 15, 1922), 238-250, 238.

[38] One can detect hints of barely-sublimated Magyar *revanche* in Lukács's claim that "The 'national states' that formed after the war are incapable of life."

[39] Lukács, "Organisationsfragen der Dritten Internationale," 244-245.

[40] Lukács, "Organisationsfragen der Dritten Internationale," 247

"the same party must be represented on multiple central committees."[41] This system, Lukács maintained, would surpass that of "general congresses with their often much too general resolutions."[42]

The international's destiny was, moreover, to be an illegal body, as for communists legality could only ever be a "transitory phase." This was a relatively realistic evaluation at the time: The parties of Germany, Hungary, Finland, Estonia, Lithuania, and Poland were illegal at the time of writing; the IWW and the two nascent communist parties in the United States were still reeling from the First Red Scare; and numerous other parties (Bulgaria, Yugoslavia, Latvia, etc.) would be banned in the coming months and years. In this political moment, it was universally agreed that communist parties, whatever their structure, must be prepared to cope with repression and illegality.

The use of idealist jargon in "Organisationsfrage der dritten Internationale" should not distract from the practical concerns that occasioned the essay and Lukács's attempt to solve the problems generated by them.

2.3. Debates in the Hungarian Party

The chaos of the revolution left wounds in the party, wounds that developed into ever-more open factional strife in the years following 1919. After his brief imprisonment, Béla Kun left Vienna for Moscow in July 1920, leaving behind a few allies that would have to contend with Landler, the leader of the faction that would come to include everyone in the party who disagreed with Kun. Lukács, despite his seemingly Kun-esque leftism on many questions, quickly found himself aligned with Landler when confronted with Kun's bureaucratic trickery and irresponsible politics.[43]

Looking back decades later, Lukács attributed his support for Landler to the fact that Landler "had no programme which he could have used to appear before the world as the leader of the Communists. He simply concerned himself with the practical possibilities of reviving the Hungarian movement."[44] Whereas Kun conspired with Zinoviev in attempts to conjure a mass party in Hungary out of thin air by means of ridiculous schemes, Landler was fundamentally a *Realpolitiker*. Lukács's politics for the next several years would be defined by the stark difference between the low-tempo policies he promoted for the Hungarian party and the high-tempo ones he promoted for the rest of the Comintern, in particular the German party. While he disagreed strongly with Kun and Zinoviev on Hungarian matters, he repeatedly found himself

41 Lukács, "Organisationsfragen der Dritten Internationale," 248
42 Lukács, "Organisationsfragen der Dritten Internationale," 249
43 Lukács, *Record of a Life*, 74.
44 Lukács, *Record of a Life*, 75.

aligned with the pair on international matters, especially those concerning Germany, over the next few years.

Before getting into the debates, it is worth briefly mentioning what was not in contention, at least openly. All European communists, even the notoriously cautious Paul Levi, agreed that the continent's political situation necessitated an offensive strategic stance.[45] The disagreement between the left and right factions within the Third International principally concerned the tempo and tactics of the offensive. After repeated setbacks in 1920 and 1921, the "theory of the offensive," as the position promoted by Zinoviev, Kun, and Radek came to be known, would be officially condemned at the Third Congress of the Comintern, but even this did not abolish the distinction made between the fundamentally offensive stance of communists and the fundamentally conformist stance of social democrats.

Amongst the Hungarians, a debate about legality, illegality, and tactics was brewing, but it had different reference points than the one in, for instance, Germany. The communist party was completely illegal in Hungary, and former members of the Council Republic's government were fugitives who risked death sentences if arrested. Completely abstaining from illegal activity was out of the question, as it would amount to total liquidation of the party. Moreover, both factions of the party agreed that revolution and proletarian dictatorship, not bourgeois democracy, remained their goal and differentiated themselves from the Social Democrats on this count.[46] Rather than the fundamental question of legality and illegality in general, the debate in Hungary revolved around the specific tactical programs of the two factions.

The factions quarreled about whether or not it was desirable for émigrés to attempt illegal crossings back into rump Hungary and the successor states to join in the clandestine work and build the party. An initial effort to this effect had been organized in Slovakia circa August 1920 to little result, and in December of the same year a large cohort of communists embedded in a returning group of prisoners of war crossed into the realm of Admiral Horthy only to be immediately arrested. Communist émigrés would continue to make risky ventures back into Hungary in the following years, but these were increasingly restricted to temporary incursions by experienced cadres for specific purposes, rather than harebrained attempts to import a party wholesale.

The question of how communists should work in the Social Democrat

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[45] Paul Levi, "The Beginning of the Crisis in the Communist Party and the International" (1921), in *In The Steps of Rosa Luxemburg: Selected Writings of Paul Levi*, ed. David Fernbach (Brill, 2011) 92-112; 95.

[46] Miklós Molnár, *From Béla Kun to János Kádár: Seventy Years of Hungarian Communism*, tr. Arnold J. Pomerans (Berg, 1990), 32.

controlled trade unions, which represented the only real avenue for party work within the bounds of legality, was another bone of contention.[47] The Landlerites, Lukács among them, were opposed to recklessly sending émigrés home and Kun's proposal that communists refuse to pay the dues to the Social Democratic Party required of all trade union members, a gesture that would simultaneously isolate and expose them.[48] This matter was a clear point of differentiation between Lukács's politics and that of the Dutch-German communist left, who argued for complete abstention from social democratic trade unions.

By August 1920, real factional lines of battle were already forming, and sectarian strife would only intensify over the next several years.

2.4. Looking Back on the Revolution

Another crucial piece of context for Lukács's writings from 1920 are the debates and discussions produced by the fall of the Hungarian Council Republic and failure of the Hungarian revolution. These controversies began almost immediately after the fall of the Council Republic at the beginning of August 1919. In what is probably the first summation written on the experiences of the Hungarian Council Republic, published on November 1, 1919 in the KPD organ *Die Internationale*, an anonymous "member of the Hungarian council government" listed ten facts that formed the "quintessence" of the causes of the Republic's defeat:

1. Unprepared seizure of power
2. Too few politically reliable comrades
3. Merger with the Social Democrats
4. Sabotage by the former Social Democrats
5. Mistakes by the People's Commissariats of the Interior by indiscriminate appointment of former Russian prisoners of war to office
6. Corruption
7. Hostility of the peasants
8. Dilettantish financial politics
9. Replacement of the old [military] officers

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[47] Bennett Kovrig, *Communism in Hungary: From Kun to Kádár* (Hoover Institution Press, 1979), 79, 83.

[48] Georg Lukács, *Record of a Life*, 75. The chronology of when the debate about dues began is somewhat unclear in Lukács's account. I infer from context that it took place simultaneously with the debate about sending émigrés back to Hungary, i.e. in mid to late 1920 after Kun went to Moscow.

10. Military superiority of imperialist mercenary troops[49]

This list encompasses most if not all of the causes that would be subsequently described in longer pamphlets from leading members of the government such as Béla Kun and Eugen Varga. The criticism of the "Russian prisoners of war," by which the author surely meant Hungarians like Béla Kun and Mátyas Rakosi who had been captured by the Imperial Russian Army in the war and then converted to the Bolshevik cause, apparently proved too controversial, as the accusation does not appear in any subsequent retrospectives.

One factor is curiously absent from the above summary: internal reactionary forces. The primary villains conjured by the anonymous author are the Social Democrats within and the "imperialist mercenaries" without. Local counterrevolutionary forces had, in fact, organized themselves in the town of Szeged, which lay to the south of Budapest in the part of Hungary then occupied by France and Yugoslavia, but this counterrevolutionary movement refrained from undertaking any military actions until after the Council Republic had been overthrown by the Little Entente.[50]

The anonymous article in *Die Internationale* was soon followed by Béla Kun's pamphlet *Von Revolution zu Revolution* (From Revolution to Revolution)—the afterword says the manuscript was finished on November 7, 1919—which Kun wrote during his confinement in Austria and published under the pseudonym Blasius Kolozsváry in early 1920. As the title suggests, Kun argues for an immediate resumption of the offensive and generally avoids any extended analysis of the actual revolutionary process that had just unfolded in Hungary, explicitly stating that "this is not the place to unveil the history of the origin of the dictatorship of the proletariat in Hungary."[51] What, then, caused the failure in his opinion? Kun tends to focus on the betrayal and sabotage by the Social Democrats, arguing that "The cause of all errors that began during the dictatorship and finally lead to its downfall were—if not exclusively, then [at least], from the standpoint of tactics, primarily—hidden within the structure of the workers movement,"[52] by which he meant the bureaucratic, reformist character of the Social Democratic Party and the trade unions. This historical background kneecapped the Hungarian communists. Kun's pamphlet was quickly joined by tracts penned by Béla Szánto (former

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[49] Quoted in Jörg Kammler, *Politische Theorie von Georg Lukács: Struktur und historischer Praxisbezug bis 1929* (Luchterhand, 1974), 146. Full text: `https://archive.org/details/die-internationale-jahrg-1-2-1915-1920_202504/page/304/mode/2up`

[50] Nicholas M. Nagy-Talavera, *The Green Shirts and Others: A History of Fascism in Hungary and Romania* (Center for Romanian Studies, 2001), 76-77, 80.

[51] Blasius Kolozsváry [Béla Kun], *Von Revolution zu Revolution* (Genossenschaftsverlag der "Neuen Erde" 1920) 13. `https://archive.org/details/vonrevolutionzur00kolo/`

[52] Kun, *Von Revolution zu Revolution*, 21.

People's Commissar of National Defense), Eugen Varga (former People's Commissar for Finance), and László Rudas (former member of the Foreign Affairs Subcommittee). I will not explain in detail their arguments here, but suffice to say they all pointed to the way that the government was established as a key factor in its eventual downfall.[53] The proletariat did not have to fight for power and so lacked a combative spirit, class consciousness, and adequate organization (party, councils, etc.). This was the principal "birth defect," as Szánto put it, that afflicted the dictatorship.

The Comintern's top man in Europe, Radek, wrote the foreword to Szántó's pamphlet. In it, he strongly argued against the apparently widespread prejudice that the republic was "a simple result of a compromise between party leaders," insisting that it was instead "*the result of the revolutionary class struggle of the proletariat*"[54] and Szántó's work proved this. Radek claimed this even though Szántó concluded his study by saying the exact opposite: "On one hand the Social Democrats did not make the communist program their own out of principled theoretical conviction; on the other hand—and this was the real error—the proletariat came into power without a decisive battle against the bourgeoisie."[55] The "Lessons of the Hungarian Revolution" (the title of Radek's preface) were that Social Democrats could never be trusted. Indeed, Radek opined that "The coalition with the Social Democrats was necessary, but the communists needed to erect gallows next to the house of government, upon which they could eventually demonstrate to their beloved allies what the proletarian dictatorship meant in concrete terms."[56]

Radek's endorsement, if that is the right word, of the Hungarian Revolution was in many ways a barely concealed criticism of Paul Levi, who had written a critical article about the foundation of the council government just two days after its birth. The following passage from that text is key:

> As far as we are concerned, the possibility for the dictatorship of the proletariat exists not when the bourgeoisie collapses but when the proletariat rises—when, in other words, it has acquired in the process of a constant revolutionary struggle the intellectual maturity, the determination and the insight to realise that salvation lies in its dictatorship alone; it will become possible when the last proletarian is filled with the belief in socialism.[57]

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[53] Most of these are briefly summarized in Kammler, *Politische Theorie von Georg Lukács*, 147-150. Digitized versions of the pamphlets can be found online.

[54] Béla Szántó, *Klassenkämpfe und Diktatur des Proletariats in Ungarn* (Western European Secretariat of the Communist International, 1920), iv. My translation. Available online: `https://archive.org/details/klassenkmpfeun00szuoft/`

[55] Op. cit, 109.

[56] Op. cit., viii. Paul Levi would later criticize Radek for this rather bloodthirsty remark.

[57] Paul Levi quoted in Paul Levi, "The Lessons of the Hungarian Revolution" (1920) in *In The Steps of Rosa Luxemburg: Selected Writings of Paul Levi*, ed. David Fernbach (Brill, 2011) 70-78; 71-72.

Paul Levi quoted the above sentence in his own "Lessons of the Hungarian Revolution," which he wrote in June 1920 for *Die Internationale*, where Radek's preface to Szántó's pamphlet had also been reprinted. Levi had been courting the base of the Independent Social Democratic Party of Germany (USPD) since Fall 1919 when he expelled the left-wing majority of the nascent KPD over the issue of parliamentarism, and the KPD had been forced to organize inside the USPD during periods when the party was banned. The upcoming Second Congress of the Comintern would prove to be an important step in his eventually victorious campaign to absorb the USPD left into the KPD. Radek's extreme hostility to the very idea of working with Social Democrats and passion for red terror therefore represented a threat to his own political program, and so the debate about the Hungarian Revolution became an arena for leaders of the German communist movement to advance positions on their local politics. In this back-and-forth, the reality of the events that had transpired in the Carpathian Basin was increasingly lost.

Lukács finally offered his own views on the fall of the republic in an "Önkritika" (Self-Criticism) for *Proletár*, the Hungarian-language mouthpiece of the Landler faction, in August 1920.[58] The reference to Levi in the essay indicates that it was occasioned by Levi's article, which had been reprinted in *Kommunismus* in July.

Lukács's contribution to the debate about the failure of the Hungarian Council Republic uniquely emphasizes not the compromise with the Social Democrats, but the substitution of the party by the "proletarian state." He wanted to ask what the "*roots of the failure*" were instead of "*what [they] would have needed to do* in the moment."[59] Self-criticism is not about how clever one's ideas were at the time. Indeed, Lukács questions how his erroneous argument that the communist party was unnecessary was able to appear as official party literature without provoking any objections. What sort of conditions obtained in the Hungarian movement that this could happen?

Lukács begins his argument proper by clearing some ground. One should not ask, as Paul Levi did, whether the communists were right to seize power, but rather if they were right to give up their organizational independence and merge with the Social Democrats. Even this question, however, leads him back to a more basic problem, namely that "In the moment of unification, there was *organizationally* no communist party."[60] Agitation and propaganda had won over many workers as sympathizers, but these workers largely remained

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[58] Georg Lukács, "Selbstkritik" (1920), in *Revolution und Gegenrevolution: Politische Aufsätze II 1920-1921*, eds. Jörg Kammeler and Frank Benseler, tr. Janos Györkös et al (Leuchterhand, 1976), 42-46.

[59] Georg Lukács, "Selbstkritik," 42. Emphasis in original.

[60] Lukács, "Selbstkritik," 43

outside the party, which also suffered from catastrophic member turnover and the arrest of much of its leadership in February.

In fact, "the party and the leadership were not really aware how indispensable the party is for leading a revolution."[61] Lukács further claims that "many," including himself, "believed that [they] could fulfill this function [i.e., that of the party's leadership] with the organ of the proletarian state."

As Béla Kun and others had already pointed out, the Hungarian movement prior to 1919 was only familiar with the "corrupt and compromise-happy"[62] party of social democracy. Their ignorance led them, and many others outside of Hungary, to conclude that "the party organization is in essence a child of bourgeois society, which must be replaced by new, specifically proletarian organizations (workers councils, factory councils, industrial unions, etc.) for the proletarian class struggle."[63]

The Hungarians only began to truly understand the importance of the party as their revolutionary government was already collapsing, and so just as in Russia after 1905, the emergence of a revolutionary party was only possible "after a failed revolution." This conclusion leads Lukács to ask how, and indeed *if*, the other parties of the Comintern (particularly those of Western Europe) will solve this problem. He freely admits his own ignorance as to how they can move past the "stage of mere agitation and propaganda" and form a "closed mass party" before the revolution's victory.[64] This is, in Lukács's estimation, the "greatest crisis of the revolution." His only consolation is that this crisis, which first showed itself in the Hungarian dictatorship of the proletariat, is now known world-wide, even if no solution has been found.

The argument of Lukács's self-criticism gives the party a central role in the revolutionary process. It is the only organ capable of mediating the seizure of power and directing it towards radical social transformation. The experience of the Hungarian Revolution demonstrated that the "organ of the proletarian state" will become compromised if it is not led by a revolutionary party. Cadres capable of taking on the responsibility of leadership could only be forged through a drawn-out process that includes defeats. Where Levi asserted that the communists should not have entered government and Radek proclaimed that they should rather have hanged the Social Democrats after doing so, Lukács sought the true "*roots of failure*" and found them in the lack of a real party.

These debates show that the Hungarian Revolution quickly became a literary topos on which different authors attempted to define correct political

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61 Lukács, "Selbstkritik," 44
62 Lukács, "Selbstkritik," 45
63 Lukács, "Selbstkritik," 45
64 Lukács, "Selbstkritik," 46

doctrine and draw up "lessons." The Hungarian authors variously defended and criticized themselves and their compatriots, and their summations became ammunition for non-Hungarian authors attempting to draw universally applicable lessons that could be communicated to the whole International. Lukács's contribution to the literature more closely resembles that of the non-Hungarian authors in its eschewal of extended analysis in favor of generalized lessons, but it is distinctly humble and uncertain in a way that strongly contrasts with the texts of Radek and Levi as well as Lukács's other political writings. I believe this uncertain tone was kept confined to this Hungarian-language text to save face and avoid looking like a pessimist, as pessimism and uncertainty were held in suspicion.

3. Beyond Legality and Illegality

3.1. In the Shadow of the Second Congress

In June 1920, the eleventh issue of *Die Kommunistische Internationale* announced that the Second Congress of the Communist International was set to take place from July to August. It also contained an article by Lenin criticizing three *Kommunismus* articles—one by Lukács and two by Kun—on account of their anti-parliamentarism and lack of concrete analysis.[65] For what it's worth, the controversy over abstentionism was seen as a lesser tactical dispute in terms of its actual content: Lenin once expressed some sympathy for the hardline abstentionism of Amadeo Bordiga's faction in the Italian Socialist Party given the conduct of the party's "opportunist parliamentarians."[66] There was near universal consensus that parliament was exclusively an instrument of bourgeois domination in the Third International.[67] Lukács refrained from embracing the more controversial stance of strict abstention from "reactionary" social-democratic trade unions and made efforts to distinguish himself from the Dutch-German communist left, calling the KAPD "putschist" in an article from September 1920.[68]

Lenin's brief review was accompanied by a trove of texts for the Congress, among them the theses of the ECCI—that is, of Zinoviev—for the upcom-

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[65] V. I. Lenin, "Kommunismus: Journal of the Communist International" (June 12, 1920), in V. I. Lenin, *Collected Works*, Vol. 31, 165-167. Accessed at `https://www.marxists.org/archive/lenin/works/1920/jun/12.htm`

[66] V. I. Lenin, '*Left-Wing' Communism: An Infantile Disorder* (1920) in V. I. Lenin, *Selected Works in Three Volumes, Vol. 3* (Progress Publishers, 1971), 345-430; 385n

[67] Kammler, *Politische Theorie von Georg Lukács*, 167.

[68] Georg Lukács, "Massenstreik und Arbeiterräte in Deutschland" (1920), in *Revolution und Gegenrevolution: Politische Aufsätze II 1920-1921*, eds. Jörg Kammeler and Frank Benseler, tr. Janos Györkös et al (Leuchterhand, 1976), 82-89; 84.

ing Second Congress on "the role of the communist party in the proletarian revolution" and "the communist party and the question of parliamentarism," which warned against sectarianism and encouraged the "revolutionary" use of parliament. The subsequent July issue of *Die Kommunistische Internationale* contained more theses from the ECCI and Lenin's "Theses on Fundamental Tasks of The Second Congress of The Communist International," which generally agreed with the positions of the ECCI.[69] Finally, Lenin provided the *coup de grâce* with his pamphlet *Left-Wing Communism: An Infantile Disorder*, a more elaborate intervention into the ongoing debates that would later be distributed to all who attended the congress. It should go without saying that this text was also critical of many positions that Lukács held despite not being explicitly targeted at him. Positions closely hewing to those proposed by the Bolshevik leadership would be officially adopted at the Second Congress in late July. The aforementioned theses drafted by Zinoviev and Lenin would be adopted without any significant alterations.

"Legality and Illegality" and Lukács's "Self-Criticism" were thus written under the influence of Lenin's criticism and the theses first proposed in *Die Kommunistische Internationale* and then adopted at the Second Congress with regard to legality, sectarianism, parliamentarism, and so on. Both texts indicate that Lukács took the opinions of the Bolshevik leadership—particularly Lenin—seriously and quickly discarded many of the proposals set forth in "Organization Questions of the Third International."

Although the actual events of the Second Congress cannot have influenced "Legality and Illegality" or Lukács's "Self-Criticism," it is worth briefly describing the profile of the Hungarians and their predicament at the congress. The exiles in Vienna, Lukács among them, were unable to attend, so the Hungarians were represented by two Moscow-based followers of Kun: Endre Rudnyánsky, who would abscond to Romania after pilfering Comintern funds the following year, and Matyas Rákosi, the future leader of post-war socialist Hungary.[70] The events of the Hungarian Revolution were not hotly debated, as there was already broad agreement amongst communists Hungarian and otherwise about the causes of the revolution's failure. The impact of the events in Hungary is, however, felt in the reference made in the preamble of the "Theses on the Conditions for Admission:" "No Communist may forget the lessons of the Hungarian soviet republic."[71] Overall, the Hungarian repre-

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[69] V. I. Lenin, "Theses on Fundamental Tasks of The Second Congress of The Communist International" (1920), in V. I. Lenin, *Collected Works*, Vol. 31, 184-201. Accessed at `https://www.marxists.org/archive/lenin/works/1920/jul/04.htm`

[70] Kovrig, *Communism in Hungary,* 78, 87

[71] John Riddell (ed), "Theses on the Conditions for Admission" in *Workers of the World and Oppressed Peoples, Unite! Proceedings and Documents of the Second Congress, 1920* (Pathfinder

sentatives seem to have played little role despite the considerable impression that the events of the Hungarian Revolution had made on the Comintern.

3.2. The Illocutionary Dimension

"Legality and Illegality" is a text that aimed to accomplish several goals. Following Skinner, I distinguish between the locutionary and illocutionary aspects of communication.[72] The former refers to the content, while the latter refers to the question of what genre of communicative act the text falls under and how the text realizes a performance of said act. This pragmatic analysis of Lukács's writings presents some challenges due to his style and the circumstances of publication. I will treat these challenges as they come up.

What did Lukács accomplish *in* publishing this essay, i.e., what illocutionary acts does he perform by way of language? I find two distinct acts worth noting: warning and self-criticism. These two acts are closely connected. Lukács is able to issue a warning because he has engaged in (and/or is presently doing) self-criticism about his—and the entire Hungarian leadership's—failures in 1919. The self-criticism in "Legality and Illegality" is largely implicit. Because Lukács was writing semi-anonymously as "G L," only someone who was already somewhat familiar with the major figures of the Hungarian communist movement would be able to immediately identify him as the author.[73] Despite this figleaf of semi-anonymity, Lukács strongly implies that he is one of the Hungarian émigrés through his references to the history of the Hungarian Council Republic.[74]

Even though this attempt at anonymity is half-hearted and easily seen through, it has consequences for the essay's style. In the "Self-Criticism," the first person plural pronoun identifies the author, who signed the text with his full name, as a member of the revolutionary government and the first person singular identifies the author as a particular member of that government, namely Georg Lukács. In "Legality and Illegality," the first person plural is used as the *pluralis modestiae* ("We have made it a requirement…") . The only singular first person pronouns used are also used in a purely stylistic manner: the phrase "von mir gesperrt" in a footnote and a use of *ich* ("Ich denke hierbei…") that is, in principle, interchangeable with *wir*, although in context it strongly implies that the author is a Hungarian revolutionary.

Press, 1991), 765-770; 766.

[72] See Chapter 7 of *Visions of Politics*, Vol. 1

[73] As I described above, all the Hungarian émigrés used abbreviated, semi-anonymized signatures for their articles in *Kommunismus*, but several other contributing writers also followed this convention.

[74] See Georg Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness: Studies in Marxist Dialectics*, tr. Rodney Livingstone (MIT Press, 1972), 266, 268, 270.

Lukács (in the persona of the authorial entity "G L") is also engaged in an act of self-criticism for his previous illegalist and anti-parliamentary articles in *Kommunismus*. Again, no explicit references are made to the fact that Lukács himself was once guilty of the "romanticism" he criticizes in the essay, but a reader who had been following his writings in *Kommunismus* over the past half-year and/or could identity "G L" as Georg Lukács would understand that this text was an implicit self-criticism. In relation to this, we can see Lukács's denouncement of Narodnik-cum-White Army general Boris Savinkov as part of this self-criticism given that he had previously positively cited Savinkov vis-a-vis illegality in his 1919 Hungarian-language essay "Tactics and Ethics."[75]

In this way Lukács identifies himself as a veteran of the Hungarian revolution, who, taking account of his errors, offers a warning to the rest of the Comintern. Anonymity and generality are complementary here: Lukács assumes anonymity because he is a particular kind of person, a Hungarian communist, but because he is anonymous he cannot specify the particulars and must therefore remain at the level of generality.

The key rhetorical device of Lukács's warning is the metaphor of *disease*, expressed on the very first page of the essay with Lenin's keyword *Kinderkrankheit* (childhood disease, growing pain) and then with the word *Übel* (malady, illness) in Section 2 of the essay. Lukács distinguishes two major symptoms—reformism and putschism—and argues that both result from the "disease" [Übel] of "the inability to see the state as nothing more than a power factor."[76] This line of criticism echoes what he said in his "Self-Criticism" about the mistaken belief that the state could fulfill the functions of the party, lending further credence to my argument that the essay as a whole has the character of a warning informed by self-criticism.

The mere use of the word *Kinderkrankheit* specifies who is afflicted by the disease (the Comintern) and what causes it (immaturity). Thus, even communists with a storied history in the old Second International, or even genuine Bolsheviks like Béla Kun, may now be mere children in comparison with the norm of the Third International sketched in Lenin's pamphlet and mandated by the resolutions of the Second Congress.

The text's displacement of the self of self-criticism safeguards it from falling into either the retrospective grandstanding that Lukács condemned in his *Proletár* "Self-Criticism" or the ritual of reconciliation under duress that self-criticism would become in later years. The acts performed through the text—warning and self-criticism—are connected to the enunciative modality

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[75] Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness*, 264. For the positive reference to Savinkov, see "Tactics and Ethics" in Georg Lukács, *Tactics and Ethics 1919-1929*, tr. Michael McColgan (Verso, 2014).

[76] Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness*, 263.

employed by Lukács. Instead of claiming the delegated authority of a party leader, Lukács authorizes his warning by implying that he is a veteran of the Hungarian Revolution who is doubly qualified as both an immediate witness to the events and a reflexively aware commentator capable of criticizing himself.

3.3. The Locutionary Dimension

At this point, I turn to the analysis of the locutionary dimension of "Legality and Illegality." What was Lukács doing *by* writing this essay? What positions was he staking out? What did he want to convince his audience of? If, as I am arguing, Lukács is playing doctor in this essay, then what does he prescribe as the cure for the *Kinderkrankheit* that has been diagnosed? In a word, the cure is a certain kind of consciousness, *Bewusstsein*, but this word can be misleading.[77] Commentators tend to immediately assimilate any use of the word to the philosophical articulation of class consciousness detailed in the core essays of *History and Class Consciousness*. Jörg Kammeler, who otherwise does an incredible job laying out in detail what is redundant and what is emphatic in Lukács's early political writings, underplays the continuity between the sense of consciousness in Lukács's political writings and its sense in mainstream Marxist discourse.

The sense(s) given by Lukács to the word "consciousness" were conditioned by the archive of statements carried over from other discursive formations (Austrian, German, Hungarian, and Russian Social Democracy) and the functions assumed by the concept of consciousness in these statements. At the most fundamental level, the translation and reproduction of such statements across time and languages inevitably produces semantic drifts. This drift is accompanied by the proliferation of morphologically distinct concepts: *zielbewusst*, *falsches Bewusstsein, Klassenbewusstsein*, *tred-yunionistskoye soznanie*, *politisches Bewusstsein*, *sozialistisches Bewusstsein*, etc. The circulation and reproduction of the statements including these concepts crystallized into patterns of usage that entailed specific relations between the concepts, specified their relation to the objects of discourse, and implied the assumption of certain enunciative modalities in those who deployed the concepts.

The concepts could be sorted into a graded hierarchy—Lars Lih has reconstructed what this hierarchy looked like for Kautskyan "orthodox Marxism."[78] Rosa Luxemburg produced two different matrices of consciousness in the

[77] Lars Lih resolved the problem posed by consciousness vocabulary in his study of Lenin by quibbling about the Russian language and choosing new English equivalents with which to translate the relevant words. I am not convinced that such an approach is appropriate with German-language material.

[78] Lih, *Lenin Rediscovered*, 75ff

pamphlets "Organizational Questions of Russian Social Democracy" and "The Mass Strike." In the former, she divided "das Unbewusste" from "das Bewusste" on grounds of chronological and logical priority, arguing that the "experimental" and "elemental" class struggle drove the cause of socialism forward, while the social-democratic leadership merely reinforced these advances. "The logic of the objective historical process," she claimed, preceded the "subjective logic of its bearers."[79] In "The Mass Strike," Luxemburg contrasted "theoretical and latent" class consciousness with its "practical and active counterpart."[80] The degree, as it were, of class consciousness was irrelevant to this classification, which was based on activity conditioned by the political situation. A single concept thus became an important point of dispersion from which concepts multiplied and were connected to various objects, most of which were political in nature and hence far afield from the traditional psychological or philosophical objects attached to the concept of consciousness.

With this background in mind, I think it is a mistake to throw Lukács into the flattened problematic of a philosophy of consciousness so hastily. *Bewusstsein* must always be read as a polyvalent term. I find three operative senses of consciousness in Lukács's text, which I will call the metonymic sense, the political-theoretical sense, and the psychological sense.

The first of these is the most abstract. In the discourse of the Second International, talk about consciousness often functioned as metonymic talk about the organizational situation of the proletariat. One frequently finds words related to (*Klassen-*) *Bewusstsein* and *Organisation* placed side by side. The Hainfelder Programm of the Austrian Social Democrats states that "The bearer of [the] evolution [from capitalism to socialism] can only be the class-conscious and politically organized proletariat."[81] In his famous commentary on the Erfurt Program of the German Social Democrats, Kautsky claimed that "Social Democracy [...] is in essence simply the part of the fighting proletariat that is conscious of its goal [zielbewusste]" and that this conscious, fighting proletariat tended "to become ever more synonymous with Social Democracy," finally making his point crystal-clear with the statement that "In Germany and Austria the two have in reality become one."[82] Luxemburg repeated this statement in "The Mass Strike," a text which Lukács studied thoroughly in

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[79] Rosa Luxemburg, "Organisationsfragen der russischen Sozialdemokratie" (1904), in *Gesammelte Werke*, Band 1, 2. Halbband (Dietz 1979), 422–446. Accessed at `https://www.marxists.org/deutsch/archiv/luxemburg/1904/orgfrage/text.htm`

[80] Rosa Luxemburg, *The Essential Rosa Luxemburg: Reform or Revolution & The Mass Strike*, ed. Helen Scott (Haymarket 2007), 160.

[81] The text of the original is reproduced at `https://rotbewegt.at/lexikon/das-programm-von-hainfeld-1888-1889/`

[82] Karl Kautsky, *Das Erfurter Programm: in seinem grundsätzlichen Teil erläutert* (J. H. W. Dietz, 1892), 216. Accessed at `https://library.fes.de/prodok/fa87-01370a.htm`

the early 1920s. Quoth: "Social Democracy is the most enlightened, most class-conscious vanguard of the proletariat."[83] These are all repetitions of a key governing statement operative within the discourse of classical social democracy.

By and large, then, Marxists saw the political party as the logical embodiment of the class-conscious proletariat, and an authority as important as Kautsky was not afraid to assert that under certain conditions they were literally identical. The splits in Marxism provoked by the first World War and the subsequent foundation of the Third International complicated this picture, but the basic argument that the most conscious layer of the proletariat was coextensive with the party continued to be recited. The Second Congress of the Comintern unanimously accepted Zinoviev's "Theses on the Role of the Communist Party in the Proletarian Revolution," which stated that "The Communist Party is a part of the working class, and moreover its most advanced, most class-conscious and therefore its most revolutionary part."[84]

And so, when Lukács writes that "the reform of consciousness is the revolutionary process itself,"[85] one must recall his argument in the "Self-Criticism" that the party is the indispensable organ of revolution and infer that "the reform of consciousness" that occurs within the "revolutionary process" is intimately connected to the activity and development of the party. Whatever else it means, consciousness is a metonymic designation of organizational strength. The concept is anchored to a particular kind of object, namely organization. This interpretation clarifies the political position Lukács occupied in 1920 and harmonizes the focus on consciousness found in his essays for *Kommunismus* with the import given to the party in his "Self-Criticism" and subsequent essays.

The political and theoretical sense of consciousness is multifaceted and difficult to pin down. The most deflationary approach would be to define it simply as assent to a set of propositions that define the revolutionary and Marxist outlook, with the lynchpin (at least for Lukács) being the doctrine of the abolition of classes at the hands of the proletariat and the philosophy of history that goes with it. The most inflationary approach would be to define it in the way that Lukács did in the essay "Tactics and Ethics." He argued there that knowledge incorporating both the scientific sociology of class struggle and the Marxist philosophy of history is necessary to determine correct tactics—so far so good—but, leaning heavily on the language of German idealism, he further specified that a "self-consciousness" of "the given historico-

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[83] Rosa Luxemburg, *The Essential Rosa Luxemburg: Reform or Revolution & The Mass Strike*, ed. Helen Scott (Haymarket 2007), 161.

[84] Riddel, ed. *Workers and Oppressed Peoples, Unite!*, 191.

[85] Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness*, 259.

philosophical situation"[86] beyond mere discursive scientific and philosophical knowledge was also necessary. This conclusion is in line with the overarching concern with, as Westerman calls it, "Dostoevskyan" heroism in Lukács's work from the mid 1910s to the early 1920s.[87] (I disagree with Westerman's diagnosis that the Dostoevskyan elements are anti-Hegelian; in my opinion this description accords very well with Hegel's conception of heroism as "the absolute unity of character and the universal" in the passion of the world-historical person.[88]) In the limited scope of "Legality and Illegality," the scale tips towards a more modest focus on correct discursive knowledge that is, however, still accompanied by an internalized, quasi-intuitive sense of the historical situation. Lukács avoids the error he made in "Tactics and Ethics" and does not make heroic theoretical consciousness into the singular keystone of revolutionary practice. Moreover, this sense of consciousness is clearly linked to a different object than the political-organizational sense.

The third and final sense of consciousness in Lukács's formulations is the psychological. It is perhaps the most fugitive element in his thought given his repeated denial that (class) consciousness is a psychological phenomenon.[89] Nonetheless, Lukács clearly appeals to psychological consciousness when he writes that "the revolution itself can only be accomplished by people [...] who have become intellectually and emotionally emancipated from the existing system."[90] This intellectual and emotional emancipation is necessary for organizational strength and discursive knowledge to not fall back into political cretinism—another medical term of abuse dear to both Lenin and Luxemberg—and academic *Kathedersozialismus*. It fuels the drive to organize and study social reality in the interest of changing it, but, unlike with Hegel or the Buddha, no one can be completely psychologically emancipated prior to revolutionary social emancipation: "They need the evidence of their own eyes to tell them which society really conforms to their interests before they can

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[86] Georg Lukács, "Tactics and Ethics" in *Tactics and Ethics, 1919-1929: The Questions of Parliamentarianism and Other Essays,* ed. Rodney Livingstone, tr. Michael McColgan (London: Verso, 2014).

[87] Richard Westerman, "From Myshkin to Marxism: The Role of Dostoevsky Reception in Lukács's Revolutionary Ethics," *Modern Intellectual History*, Volume 16, Issue 3 (November 2017), 927 - 960; 22 et passim.

[88] Georg Friedrich Wilhelm Hegel, *Lectures on the Philosophy of World History,* Vol. 1 *Manuscripts of the Introduction and the Lectures of 1822-3*, eds. and trs. Robert F. Brown, Peter C. Hodgson, et al (Oxford University Press 2011), 176

[89] Lukács inadvertently contradicted himself in the original version of "Klassenbewusststein" by claiming that "the real motor forces of history are independent of man's consciousness of them," only to correct this by changing the phrasing to "independent of man's (psychological) consciousness" in the version that appears in *History and Class Consciousness.*

[90] Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness,* 257.

free themselves inwardly from the old order."[91] Psychologically emancipated consciousness is both an impetus towards practice and the projected fruit of victory, albeit in different forms. Despite this internal differentiation, this concept is again linked to a different order of objects than the other two.

These three dimensions of consciousness shed light on the sometimes enigmatic nature of consciousness in Lukács's early Marxist work on two levels. On the political level, each dimension is insufficient by itself, but together they cohere into something greater than the sum of its parts. Metonymic consciousness in the form of organizational strength is illusory if the organization is not committed to revolutionary theory and staffed by partisans. Theoretical consciousness that loses sight of the real, external basis of its content—the power of the proletariat organized into a party—and the psychological motivation that drives it becomes merely scientific. Psychological consciousness divorced from an organizational context and correct theory results in romanticism. The political form of the first deficit is reformism; that of the third is putschism. Between them is the wavering stance of intellectuals who dally with Marxism like Lukács himself before 1919.

On the discursive level, the diversity concealed underneath the signifier "consciousness" is connected to both prior social democratic discourse and ongoing political concerns as articulated in the debates conducted in publications like *Kommunismus*, *Die Internationale*, and *Proletár*.

4. Conclusions

Beyond the interpretations I have made of Lukács's "Self-Criticism," "Legality and Illegality," and related texts as interventions into specific debates, many of Lukács's others essays from the early 1920s can be seen as attempts to close gaps in the emerging discursive formation that would come to be known as Leninism.[92] Throughout this essay, I have described various ways by which the content of Lukács's literary production was conditioned by political events and debates. Now I want to discuss the relation of his literary production to the fundamental governing rules of the institutional-discursive system emerging in the Comintern.

In the early years of the Comintern, the process by which governing statements were produced, reproduced, and transformed was relatively transparent. Assertoric and/or imperative resolutions were drafted individually or collectively and then approved by committees made up of representatives from

[91] Lukács, *History and Class Consciousness*, 258.

[92] Lukács says something along these lines in the introductory remarks to his unpublished 1926 manuscript *Tailism and the Dialectic*, see *A Defence of History and Class Consciousness: Tailism and the Dialectic*, tr. Esther Leslie (Verso, 2000), 47

member parties. These resolutions were the primary, although not necessarily the first, enunciation of the governing statements that provided the rules for the discourse of the Comintern. During the approval process and subsequent dissemination through institutional organs, the content of these resolutions was subject to various transformations: treated as a general law and applied to a particular case; explained as a conclusion drawn from historical experience; justified as the extension of established principles; inverted into a corresponding defect; shifted from its original modality, whatever that may have been, into oughts, ises, musts, woulds, and ifs; and so on. As statements, resolutions occupied the ambivalent space between knowledge and tactics that characterizes political discourse. From one angle, political resolutions appear as the governing statements, but from another they appear to depend on and be derived from the archive of scientific and theoretical knowledge. While this relation was held in suspension during the time of the Second International, it would be resolved in favor of one side by the Third.

With the growing power of the ECCI following the adoption of the first set of binding resolutions at the Second Congress, both the production of statements and the rules for their transformation became increasingly regulated at every level, but especially at the primary level of institutional power. The ECCI was given the power to act with the authority reserved for congresses between congresses, which allowed its leaders to exert considerable influence on the direction of the congresses. The processes of Bolshevization and Stalinization would make the process of discursive production both less and less transparent and more and more restrictive as they matured.

The different enunciative modalities that Lukács adopts—and, in the case of his "Self Criticism," does not adopt—in his texts testify to a different vision of discursive authority than the one that would crystallize in the Comintern. The heart of this vision is self-criticism, which was to be the difficult but necessary work of freely admitting errors, striving to correct them, and producing knowledge through this process. The unique perspective on international organization articulated in "Organisationsfrage der dritten Internationale" registers a similar line of thought in its protest against bureaucratic unity: if unity cannot be established by fiat, then how can knowledge? Self-criticism is a process that recognizes, defines, and solves problems in a manner fundamentally different from the circulatory pyramid of congressional centralism. Extrapolating from Lukács's sketch, it can be inferred that the interpenetration of parties—having discarded their national affiliations—would transform the lonely subject of self-criticism into a collective, polyphonic subject for whom the task of self-criticism would be more than a punishment for the disobedient. The authority to produce, reject, and transform statements would be distributed throughout the field of action, rather than concentrated in

representative central bodies (and the executive bodies that inevitably exert their power in between congresses). The relation between the general and the particular would be formed anew.

Lukács's tendency to write within what his student István Mészáros called an "unhappy correlation" of subjective, particular historical processes and a singular, objective, and universal process was just as much a product of his political situation—including its institutional and discursive aspects—as of his intellectual background.[93] The hegemonic conception of Marxism as theory and science, which the Comintern carried over from the Second International, implied a totalizing intellectual and political project that, because of the institutional situation emerging in the Comintern, lent itself easily to such "unhappy correlations." At the discursive level, the model of Marxism as science had considerable parallels with the institutional system of congressional centralism: Both ordered statements into general and particular, law and case, and instituted hierarchical rules of enunciation based on this order. Lukács's own formulation of what made Marxism scientific, in centering the question of method, militated against the received idea of science, but his agreement with the content of the Comintern's resolutions won out over his criticism of the institutional form that produced them. His attempt to reproduce the content in a form that rebuked the primary institutional relations standing behind its own production and implied a different system of discursive relations lacked the political and institutional force to seriously contest the Comintern's totalizing project.

For better or worse, Marxists have long known that political writing is a kind of political speech, which is a kind of political act. Lukács was evidently aware of this as well: in both his early, principled self-criticism and his later, resigned attempts at it, he recognizes the political center of even his most philosophical arguments in a way that academic philosophical commentators, in the interest of warding off the spectre of totalitarian contamination, have not. A genuine historical engagement with Lukács's work must patiently untangle these threads where appropriate and recognize the load-bearing structures woven amongst them where not.

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[93] István Mészáros, *Lukács' Concept of Dialectic* (Merlin Press, 1972), 37.

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Appendix: Self-Criticism (1920)

Georg Lukács

Translation[1]

Self-criticism is without a doubt a paramount duty of every revolutionary and every revolutionary party. In self-criticism, however, the method of Marxism may not be disregarded, and so [it must be understood that] everything that happened in the past is a *manifestation of history* and, as such, necessary. Insofar as we criticize it, we must return to the *real grounds* of the events and criticize these. This criticism can only be self-criticism. For if we claim that we acted falsely, then we find the ground in ourselves (in our own person, in the condition of the party and the class), and we endeavor to alter this ground so that we act rightly in the future—under different circumstances. The true question of self-criticism is therefore: where were the *roots of failure*; and not: *what would we have had* to do then. This latter way of posing the question carries the risk that I blame others instead of myself, that I declare, on account of present experiences that I have only lived through as a result of failure, what I would have done then—no worthwhile lesson for the perspective of future practice results from this declaration. (Because the claim that I was "more clever," "more perspicuous," etc. than the others, that I merely failed to bring my wisdom into currency, carries no worthwhile lesson either.)

I have therefore written down these little remarks to serve as the introduction to a self-criticism. I understand self-criticism literally: I take my article, which I published in "Documents of Unity" immediately after the unification,[2] to be a characteristic symptom of the uncorrected stance that dominated amongst us Hungarian communists with regard to the revolutionary role of the party, such that one can thus throw some light on the facts of the unification [by examining it]. The particular claims of the article are not important. What is important is that an article could be written and appear *as official opinion* (and even without any serious opposition being expressed), which wanted to conclude the victory of the proletarian revolution without a party, instead opting for expansion beyond the bounds of the party. I repeat:

[1] Georg Lukács, "Selbstkritik," *Revolution und Gegenrevolution: Politische Aufsätze II* trs. Janos Györkös, et al. (Darmstadt und Neuwied: Luchterhand, 1976), 42–46.

[2] [Translator's note:] Of the Communist Party and the Social-Democratic Party

if it were merely the case that I had written an incorrect, bad article, then it would not be worth expending a word on the topic. However the appearance of the article, the fact that it came up against no objection, etc. are interesting *symptoms* of the situation of March 21st [1919], and, setting out from these symptoms, it will be profitable to deal with *the matter itself*.

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In my opinion, the question is not whether or not the Communist Party acted correctly when it seized power (this is what Comrade [Paul] Levi, the intellectual father of the "loyal opposition," asks in the Berlin *Internationale*[3]). That was unavoidable. Question: did they act correctly when they gave up their organizational independence and merged with the Socialist (shortly thereafter, Socialist-Communist) Party?

Before anything, we must answer this question with a declaration. In the moment of unification there was, *organizationally*, no communist party. There were many workers agitated for communism (= won over through agitation), those who sympathized and acted with it. But these [workers] were only organized in the Communist Party to a very limited extent. This had many internal and external reasons, above all else the brevity of the time. The Communist Party was formed in the middle of November. Work in the first months consisted of agitation and the relatively expansive propagation of communist doctrine. (Even the most biased critics will corroborate that a great deal occurred in this area.) In the first half of February, the movement arrived at the stage where serious organizational work *could begin*. Then came the demonstration at the *Nepszava* office[4] and the arrest of Béla Kun, and organizational work became stuck. This was, however, only for a short time. Already in the first half of March organizing was powerfully underway, but time was again short: After hardly three weeks the question of seizing power became current; to organize a party inside of three weeks is an impossibility. Thus, the fact is that there was really no organized communist party on March 21st. There were individual organizations, groups, members, etc., but a functionally capable organized party there was not. (With regard to the former situation of the movement it is very telling that those members who joined the party in March were mostly *completely new*; most of the members who joined the party in February left it, and in their place it gained new ones—an indication that the communist movement was still hardly consolidated then.)

[3] [Translator's note:] Lukács's reference to the "loyal opposition" refers to Paul Levi's attempt to organize a united opposition that included the centrist social-democrats and trade unions.

[4] [Translator's note:] *Nepszava* was the paper of the Hungarian Social Democrats.

However, we cannot remain stuck at this fact. Not only was there no party, but the party and its leadership were also not really conscious of how indispensable the party is for the conduct of a revolution. Many, including myself, believed that we could fulfill this function with the organs of the proletarian state. This error was not exclusively an error of the Hungarian communists. Anyone who examines the whole world-revolutionary movement (the split in the German party,[5] the theses of the Amsterdam Bureau [of the Comintern.],[6] the movement of the American workers, the IWW) sees this conception everywhere, though in many variations: the belief that the party organization is in essence a child of bourgeois society, which the proletarian class struggle must replace with new, specifically proletarian organizations (workers councils, factory councils, industrial unions, etc.). The underestimation of the revolutionary role of the party stems from this: the only form of party that the non-Russian workers knew from *immediate experience* was the corrupt and compromise-happy party of social democracy. It is understandable that the organ that emerged in opposition to it seemed like a rejection of the *party-form itself.* All the more because the newly formed communist parties, amongst ourselves and in other countries, did not *organizationally* distinguish themselves from the old parties in a fundamental way so that the organizational difference (and thus the change in function) could be visible to everyone. Because one can only form a closed party that is genuinely a mass party and not a sect in the advanced stage of revolution. As long as the revolution has not reached this [point], fluctuation between two equally one-sided extremes is inevitable. That is one part [of the matter]: that the communist party did not organizationally distinguish itself from the old workers parties sharply enough. The other is that the revolutionary section of the communist workers did not see the *revolutionary* significance of organizing in the party with sufficient clarity. The German Communist Party finds itself in this crisis today. The Hungarian communists had not yet arrived at this crisis when they stood at the precipice of seizing power. That the unification provoked general *dissatisfaction* in the circle of communists is still not proof that they had really and clearly perceived the question and its significance. On the contrary. In the discussions held around this question the theories of both Lenin and Erwin Szabó[7] were tolerated peacefully, and so it is wholly obvious that they had not yet arrived at *posing the question.* (I must admit that this criticism is not principally directed at myself.)

Already in the final phase of the dictatorship an awareness of this developed.

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[5] [Translator's note:] Presumably referring to the split between the KPD and the KAPD

[6] [Translator's note:] The Amsterdam Bureau was dominated by left-wing communists, leading to its dissolution in May 1920.

[7] [Translator's note:] A leading Hungarian social democrat

Then an attempt was made to reorganize the party in a communist fashion. There was no time for this, and so the establishment of the Hungarian party, like the Russian, first became possible after a failed revolution. How the Western parties will resolve this question we do not know.

Fortunately—and the fall of the Hungarian dictatorship also contributed to this—they see the question clearly, [even] if they also cannot resolve it in the present phase of revolution. The revolution must already be very advanced, should a closed mass party be established; it must have already gone beyond the stage of mere agitation and propaganda—which can hardly be achieved in the West *before* the victorious revolution. This is the greatest crisis of the revolution at present. The crisis first showed itself in the Hungarian dictatorship. Today it has been recognized across the world, even if no solution has been found.

Fragments

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Shards of Spirit

CTWG

Modes of Production Debate

When the narrator, speaking omnisciently with insight into the proceedings of the gods, lists the accomplishments of Sheep and Grain, he—for this was undoubtedly a man—talks of how they gave sustenance to the land, filled the granaries and barns, brought wealth to the poor, and carried splendor and beauty with them wherever they went. Sheep and Grain themselves, having gotten drunk on sweet wine and sweet beer, take things in a different direction.

Grain boasts of how she bestows her "power" onto warriors, making them forget fear and go into battle "as if to the playing field." This could refer to some kind of religious rite, or it could mean that Sumerian warriors were in the habit of getting soused before combat. She also mentions her ability to mediate feuds and give freedom to prisoners.

Sheep responds in kind, describing how Šakkan, king of the mountain and god of wild animals, "twists a giant rope against the great peaks of the rebel land" and manufactures the sling, the quiver, and the longbows. Clearly she is no slouch in martial prowess either.

It goes on like this. Grain charges that shepherds, those fearful plains-dwellers, covet the farmers' fields and must be chased away with a cudgel in hand. "I am Grain, I am born for the warrior…" Incensed, Sheep takes things too far and vividly describes how "a banished enemy, a slave from the mountains, or a laborer with a poor wife" comes to the threshing floor, bound in rope, and violently pounds Grain into flour. Her face is mutilated by the wretch's club and she is tossed around by the winds.

Grain is hurt and retaliates in the same fashion, mocking how Sheep's innards are butchered and packed for the marketplace. At this point Enki, one of the leaders in the gods' cosmic council, intervenes and declares that "Sheep and Grain should be sisters […] But of the two, Grain shall be greater." Everyone "should submit to the yoke of Grain."

Thus a dispute between the two axial organic technologies of the day—meaning the third millennium BC—became a contest in violence. The two life-bringers of Sumeria boast of their ability to wreak death. First they mustered

their arguments about who was best for war, and hence the state. When this proved insufficient, they turned nasty and conjured grotesque metaphorical images of mauling and humiliating women. Pastoralism and agriculture meet as rival modes of production, daughters of the neolithic, but their debate in Sumeria elides any precise references to the relations of production. The systems appear as divine forces rather than arrangements between human beings and domesticated organisms. While the poem's narrator portrays them as universally beneficent, the stock and measure of wealth itself, they portray themselves as power, indeed as antagonistic power. Both stories contain bits of mangled truth.

Much of recent scholarship, even if unintentionally, depicts the transition to class society as an unrelenting, millennia-spanning horrorshow. Fire and axe felled the great cedar forests, and plows broke the plains, subjecting them to the yoke of Grain. As it became ecologically impossible for the unfree workers, whether they were slaves, serfs, or something in between, to flee into the wild countryside, so too did the cities become the hosts of world-historical zoonotic diseases, nemeses of humanity that would put a cap on endogenous urban growth for millennia. The marshes were drained and irrigated, but the canals turned the land into a salted waste. The peoples of the "rebel peaks" and "high plains" were taken in captivity to the cities, the workhouses, the fields. Amidst such apocalyptic upheavals, it's no wonder that the tension between the epoch's two defining modes of life became the stuff of myth.

It Will Truly Be Known, So It Is.

What does it mean for enlightenment to return to myth? And, coevally, what does it mean to live in a violent world? These are the dual questions posed by the form and function of the prophetic poem *nin me šara*, more commonly known as The Exaltation to Inanna, written in exile by the Akkadian high-priestess Enheduanna in the midst of a civil war.

The Sumerian city-state of Ur, under the rebel king Lugal-Ane, along with a number of other city-states, had risen up against the authority of the Akkadian Empire, ruled then by Narām-Sîn, blood relative of Enheduanna, both of whom were direct descendents of Sargon, the first king of the empire. Lugal-Ane beseeched Enheduanna, as priestess of the city, to inaugurate him as the rightful king of Ur, but she refused, and under threat of execution fled the city. The ritual for which the *nin me šara* was written took place in this moment of acute turmoil, where the power and authority of the goddess Inanna, patron deity of the Sargonic kings and cultic spouse of Narām-Sîn, had been cast into the utmost doubt, and through which Enheduanna sought to empower Inanna and call upon her to open up "the gateway of tears" and to rain down

her righteous and bloody justice upon the city-state of Ur.

Enheduanna tells the story of how Inanna gathers her strength, acquiring the "countless numinous instruments of power" (of which, however, there are said to only be seven necessary instruments) from the other deities of the pantheon, through various demonstrations of her own cunning, power and aggression, such that she usurps her father, An, as the most powerful of the gods and the highest authority on Earth. It is, then, from this apex that Inanna is prophesized, by Enheduanna, to pass judgment upon her enemies and for this judgment to be executed on the city of Ur and every rebellious city, in an unceasing storm of destruction: on Inanna's authority the patron goddess of Ur, NANNA, lays waste to the city, "overwhelming all places of joy in the city", depriving the city of food and all means of either defense or offense, burning the city gates, conquering its troops, killing its people, filling the the canals of the city with blood such that those who are left have only the blood of their fallen to drink, and ensuring that no love, sex, or new life of any kind, may come to the wombs of the city. The rebellious cities are subdued, Ur submits, and becomes part of Inanna's territory. Inanna will have proven her dominion over all the lands. She will have proven herself the most powerful among the gods. And so it is that the gods, in turn, will have been made to submit to her authority in heaven. Inanna will have become sovereign in Heaven and on Earth.

Enheduanna's ritual in exaltation of Inanna's power and authority functions as a narrative battle ground for political conflict and by all accounts *did* act as a turning point in the war that favoured Akkad. Hylistic analysis of the poem—breaking the text down into hylemes, the smallest action-bearing unit—reveals a sophisticated structure wherein common, abstract myths are interwoven with a concrete prophetic retelling of the same stories. The core abstract myth: An lets Inanna execute his judgment on her enemies and Sumer is made to function as the vessel, or empty form for the narration of political conflict and construction of a mythic right to rule. Meanwhile, the concrete myth: Inanna Lets Nanna execute her judgement on Ur and every rebellious city state becomes the arrogation of authority for the Sargonic king and the Akkadian Empire to quell the uprising in Ur by the most violent means necessary, and impels them to emerge from the civil war victorious. The myth in the abstract sanctions violence as a mode of law-making; the myth in the concrete sanctions a specific act of divine violence that will have been to inaugurate Akkad, Narām-Sîn, and Enheduanna as sovereign, monarch, and high-priestess, respectively, over the city of Ur and all of Sumer.

The chronology of the myth is rearranged in the text—beginning with a statement of Inanna's authority over the land and ending with Inanna having proved herself the greatest of the gods by an elliptical return to the phrase

"Queen, who would dare take away your territories from you?" Inanna, then, becomes the protagonist of both the abstract myth, wherein she executes AN's judgment to conquer Sumer, *and* in the concrete myth, wherein she devastates Ur – to emphasise this final outcome, the judgement of Inanna. Inanna becoming sovereign in Heaven and on Earth is made homologous with the actual sacking of Ur. By this the poem functions as both a revision of and a return to the myth of Inanna's absolute sovereignty, yielding the practical meaning that the Akkadian Empire must be, or rather will have been, victorious by whatever means necessary.

The climax of the poem and, so too, the ritual involves a heavy repetition of the phrase "ḫe-zu-am"—It will truly be known, so it is. And by this mantra Inanna's judgement, power, victory, and wrath are all in turn asserted to be, equally and at once, the true and the actual. It will truly be known, so it is—that Ur will fall and the Empire will rule.

In the Beginning Was the Scribe

Mesopotamian polysemy contrasts with the Greek search for *etyma* and Abrahamic inquiries into *gematria* and *hurufiyyah* because it largely shuns appeals to roots and numerological hypotheses. For example, the sign designated as MUL—made up of three AN signs, which in turn mean "the heavens"—ordinarily means "star," but it can conceivably mean, following various relations of homophony, synonymy, and homography, "planet," "writing," "shoes," and "man." The last possibility is illustrative: In Emesal, an obscure form of Sumerian used by goddesses in certain literary texts, the word for man is pronounced *mulu*, which is almost a homophone of the standard Sumerian *mul*.

Would anyone ever actually write MUL and mean "man?" Probably not, but knowledge of such complex semiotic connections was nonetheless important. Lexicography gave the scholar, who was always also a scribe, crucial insight into the esoteric structures of reality, which were often linguistic in nature. The liver studied by a *baru* was a "tablet of the gods," gods who wrote omens in the stars for the *tupšar Enuma Anu Enlil*—*tupšar* being a Sumerian loanword literally meaning "tablet writer," and *Enuma Anu Enlil* the title of a mammoth list of over 6,000 astronomical omens—to decipher. Incantation tablets used semiotically charged spellings to enhance their potency, and less esoteric lists gave scribes who worked in accounting the knowledge required to make fine-grained distinctions: During the reign of the Third Dynasty of Ur, sheep and goats were categorized based on their age, sex, quality of wool (five grades), and what they had for fodder.

In the past scholars were wont to ascribe to the Mesopotamians a desire to

create a *Listenwissenchaft*, a science of and in the form of lists that reflected their belief in cosmic order and social control. Cuneiform had, after all, originated as a form of bookkeeping, and almost as soon as it became a full-fledged system for representing language there began to appear troves of tablets listing different signs in innumerable arrangements based on all conceivable criteria. The idea of Mesopotamian *Listenwissenschaft* has fallen out of favor, but cuneiform lists of all types demonstrate an interest in knowledge for its own sake, not least because numerous entries were impossible or absurd: a solar eclipse that proceeds from north to south, a jar of donkey, grammatical formulations like "he is going away from us with us," or a lion with the face of an ass born of a ewe. Late Babylonian astronomers kept a continuous list of astronomical observations for 600 years, the data from which laid the basis for their famous mathematical astronomy. Before any of that, however, the scholars had more practical concerns.

In the proto-historic and early historic periods of Sumeria, scribes had a crucial role in constructing two of the eternal pillars of class society: the distinctions between hand and head and town and country. The cities, and in particular their temples and palaces, became the agents of exchange, organizers of infrastructure, and owners of vast tracts of land as well as, with time, human beings. The scribes were the city's administrative bureaucracy, and hence central to all of these roles: They were the ones who wrote contracts, tabulated the outlays for construction projects, and recorded land ownership.

After centuries of this arrangement, things became dire. The junior members of the ruling class had preyed too fiercely on the commoners, extracting exorbitant fees and forcing them into debt penury. The status of the free citizens that the Lugal—the Great Man, the one today called king—relied on was jeopardized, prompting these Great Men to periodically issue jubilee edicts that canceled debts, freed slaves, and scolded the bureaucrats for their rapacity. An ideology of justice emerged, with Hammurabi of Babylon—or rather his scribes—as its most famous mouthpiece.

In the more chaotic scene of the Babylonian and later Assyrian periods, neither the gods nor economic performance could guarantee the legitimacy of the ruling class and the prestige of the scribes. How could the people sleep soundly after their enemies sacked the city and carried off the holy statue of Marduk, which was both the actual body of Babylon's divine protector and the center of the world?

It was in this era that divination took on increasing importance and penetrated every sphere of life: commoners and kings alike consulted the *baru* haruspices and *ašipu* exorcists. Babylonian divination used the semiological principles of writing and interpreting cuneiform to manipulate the logic and categories common to the population. The application of these semiologi-

cal principles, mixed with some empirical and historical elements, to events celestial and terrestrial generated the omen lists; from the omen lists diviners could find an entry that was appropriate for their mark's quandary; and with logic and a fitting omen in hand the diviner could reduce the whole edifice to the binary of favorable and unfavorable, typically telling the client that everything would be OK after all.

Divination thus served as a guarantor in an increasingly chaotic world. When the scribes were a bureaucratic quasi-class joined at the hip with the state, writing was an immediate performance of power. Discursive ideology did not concern them. As the secretions of the original state-class nexus took on their own relative autonomy through the grand dance of differentiation and integration, so the scribes ceased to be a uniform bloc of privileged administrators attached to the great institutions. They became subject to the same precarity their predecessors had usuriously inflicted upon the tillers of the soil. The majority of first-millennium BC scribes known to history worked in the private sphere and freely sold their services as a commodity; some were even able to turn their knowledge to pecuniary ends and become wealthy merchants. Science, philosophy, and magic, scarcely distinct from one another, were all alternative forms of authority that scribes could claim. These were repetitions of the power they once enjoyed, which was now only available in a diminished form. Knowledge had become decoupled from the state.

What Does Heaven Ever Say?

For Confucius, Heaven was forever mute. However much he idolized the rites of Zhou, the numinous, spirit-packed world of the Shang would have been alien to him. The sage himself once disclaimed his power of speech and voiced his preference for quiet.

The most powerful forces, whether human or divine, were silent. Godlike meant something that just worked, as it were, with no outward hint of transcendence. Divine efficacy is as effortless as the North Star standing in the sky, and this is what made it so painful to be a teacher of students and advisor of lords—how could any man measure up to the example of Heaven? Rhetorical trickery and logical games could never achieve the immanent sublimity of the true way.

Thus the teacher must endlessly grapple with the fact that the same divine and human history that furnishes him with examples of just and sagelike conduct is to blame for his present predicament. Conversely, the success of learning would put an end to it. Learning and teaching are practices characteristic of an unhappy age, and only through indirection can they

become more than trickery and brutishness.

Indirection that shuns trickery can therefore be forceful at times. When asked about serving the gods and the spirits of those passed on, Confucius replied with his own question: "You are not able to serve men, how can you serve their spirits?" How indeed.

Getting from A to A

There may be no greater vindication of speculative thought than the final movements of Zeno of Elea. His infamous paradox demonstrates the situation of action and desire in space and time. To get to where we want to be, we first must move part of the way there. And to reach partway, we had to first move towards it in part as well. Getting to where we want to go may be broken down into infinitely small steps of getting only part of the way there. The result of this analysis is that we cannot, in theory, ever get to where we want to be. We cannot close the gap. We are left, emphatically, where we always already are. Arrival becomes impossible. And yet, it is a brutal fact of history that to have arrived at where we are now, we must have moved from where we used to be. Arrival must, therefore, at some point in time, have been possible. Logically, we cannot get anywhere. Yet, empirically, we have gotten to where we are. To pass the impasse, must one limb give way?.

Consider the following:

The horse, by the procession of its hoofs – front left, hind right, front right, hind left – moves from A to B, maintaining, at any moment, at least one hoof suspended in the air. This quadpartite example is the dialectical demonstration par excellence of the antinomy of historical movement. The bike, by contrast, displays a different modality. Beginning at the base of a slope, the flow of pedals, the constant flux of feet – both of which being indefinitely suspended – proceed by infinitesimal increments and generate a real force within the wheels which, in relation to the ground, exert a false, or derivative, force upon it and by this the bike arrives atop the hill. In neither case, on Zeno's analysis, should movement have occurred. But in both cases, movement does. Whether one emphasises the concrete progression of each historical hoof or the constant flow of force across a concrete surface one remains incapable of explaining how history happens and, therefore, how we might possibly move from here to where we want to be.

Now, Zeno, outside the academy, was certainly a mover and shaker. Becoming embroiled in a plot to overthrow a tyrant ruler. For this he was apprehended and impelled to divulge the names of his co-conspirators. Being, too, a good comrade, Zeno refused. Enduring torture and, eventually, forfeiting his life. However, in his final moments before death, cast at the feet of the

tyrant, Zeno appeared to relent and begged that the tyrant come close, saying that he would, at last, disclose the identities of his fellow revolutionaries. But then, as the tyrant leaned in – and here the sources differ – Zeno bit off the organ by which his history would be inscribed. On one account he bites down upon the tyrant's ear, holding fast until he is stabbed to death; on another he bites off the tyrant's nose; and on another still, he bites off his own tongue, but only after crying out "You are the curse of this city!" and turning to the bystanders, "I marvel at your cowardice, that, for fear of any of those things which I am now enduring, you should be the tyrant's slaves." By this the crowd was moved and promptly stoned the tyrant to death.

The immediate significance of such movement is clear. The contradiction between the ruler and the ruled, the eternal curse of the city, is resolved and the people set free. But, on the grander tableau of history, Zeno's death, and his last gasp attempt to prove the truth of Parmenidian ontology, left barely a mark. The city-state of Elis, after the synoecism Zeno would have witnessed in his youth, oscillated between modes of governance. At times approximating Athenian democracy and at others shifting into an oligarchic gear, the latter often set in motion by military defeat. History continued to move, its direction set neither by the inertia of Being that Zeno adduced nor by the activity his sacrifice elicited.

What then maybe said of history? That it does not move by increments, but by the catastrophic, violent defiance of the rational authority: the horse's hind hoof lands ahead of where its front hoof began and by this it begins again; not anew, not partly moved, but literally *on different grounds*: the bike outputs, upon the concrete, the full force of all those thousands of feet, all that labour congealed within it, to effect an upward climb. Only from this higher vantage may we look back and assess how far we have come, and begin to recoup the cost.

The problem, though, with these representations, is that in them movement is presupposed. They do not address what is to be done when we are in the saddle. What would make the difference can only be viewed, so it appears, from the top of the hill that we may never reach. At the same time, every martyr may be the one for whom the masses move. The rational and the empirical must be equally denied and construed. What belies the two is that the movement of history can, at any point in time, change directions—and we are the moment of inflection—real actuality manifests itself through what it produces. Such is the weapon of nature and the nature of the weapon by which we get to where we are going. All prevarications of so-called paradox are but the reins and chains of prehistory.

All Your Life You Were a Dog

The work of Antisthenes survives only in quotations, testimonia, and brief summaries. One fragment, transmitted by a certain Athenaeus, stands out. It simply says "to be fed like a suckling pig." This is a rich image, then as now. The good life for the Cynic can be defined, *via negativa*, as not being "fed like a suckling pig." Positively, the strong association between Antisthenes and dogs leads us to the position that the good life must also be canine in character. Thus it seems to us that the entire Cynic outlook is contained within the opposition of the dog and the pig. The dog and the pig are both creatures of human settlement. (It seems that wild dogs were not prominent in Greece, for Aristotle specifies that only in India are dogs sorted into wild and tame.) Both beasts are dirty, violent, chthonian, and rough, but while the dog can retain its sense of nobility in abjection, the pig is a cultured being through and through: It cares little for what it consumes as it is fattened for slaughter. Thus, we can see two differing styles of abjection in the lives of these animals: the porcine and the canine.

Juvenile pigs were an impure beast used often for minor purification ceremonies; perhaps their tendency to consume waste suggested apotropaic potency. Piglets were also the least expensive votive animal in Greece, and this is another reason they were used in such diverse rites: burnt in the *holocaust* to Zeus; butchered and buried for the sake of Demeter in the autumn *thesmophoria*, only to be dug up a few days later and cast into the fields as magical fertilizer; and used in some manner for initiation into the famous Eleunisian mysteries. Citizens would ritually cleanse public spaces in Athens by slitting the throats of piglets and sprinkling their blood around (the victims' bodies were burnt afterwards to dissipate the impurity they carried). Mature pigs were also sacrificed, as one can already see in Homer, but they, too, represent a special case. Unlike with other livestock, the procedure seems to have focused on the meat of the pig, as opposed to the fat and bones traditionally offered in the *thysia*. The pig symbolized lack of taste and distinction just as much as it did an excess in appetite not just for food, but also for sex and even violence (thus Aristotle: "A pig will give battle even to a wolf").

The dog, too, was an impure animal banned from entering most sacred spaces—notably the Acropolis of Athens—but paradoxically they were permitted to stand guard outside them. Despite their impurity, or at least in part because of it, they were also sacrificed. Like the piglet, they were an inferior sort of offering. Their bones and teeth could become protective amulets. A puppy could be used as a magical cure: rubbed on the body of a sufferer to absorb their affliction and then killed. In Athens dogs were mainly used in apotropaic rituals dedicated to Hecate, the chthonian witch queen of death

whose presence was heralded by howling dogs. Even though they were not strictly taboo, dogs were rarely eaten. Odysseus's dog Argos shows loyalty, but Homer's goddesses are called bitches on numerous occasions. There is a certain roughness even in the supernatural roles played by dogs.

Dogs are a laboring companion, raggedy but strong. A scholium on Aristotle's *Rhetoric* tells that both dogs and Cynics are "good guards," much in contrast to the incontinent violence of swine and servility of the unlearned *hoi polloi*. Further, it says that both are capable of discrimination, being loyal to friends and barking at foes. Consumed by indiscriminate lust and rage, the pig does not and cannot know friendship. Incapable of prudence in the world of everyday action, how could the pig's life have anything in common with that of the sage?

An awesome magical potency is contained within the dog. Its voice omens disaster, and its body has the power to ward it off. The Cynic similarly dispenses the truth without regard for convention and turns their body and soul into an unbreakable fortress. Foreign, poor, woman, slave: the Cynics will learn to be hardy. The pig, meanwhile, is the least valued sacrifice. Everywhere slaughtered, even dismembered and thrown into the soil. The symbols of the dog's physical strength, its bones and teeth, are magical, but to the gods is left the fatty meat of the pig. What little remains from Antisthenes on the topic of religion is not positive. He mocked priests and dismissed the worship of many gods as an erroneous custom that obfuscated the singular god of nature: "The god resembles nothing, and therefore no one can know him from an image." One can hardly imagine him finding inspiration in the votive fungibility of *Sus domesticus*, a property which reflects its undignified abjection.

The Cynic critique of Athenian society is, like that of Socrates, a hierarchical one, and the dog reflects the perilous nature of such a critique: it must be loyal without being servile in the same way that the Socratic ironist must follow the law (even when unjust) without inwardly submitting to it. One must acquire either a mind or a noose. The ideal for Antisthenes is radically Socratic in a way that contrasts strongly with, for example, Aristotle's *megalopsychos*. He has dispelled arrogance, yet is still "hard to bear" and his "kingly" behavior earns him a bad reputation. The most widely reproduced apothegm of Antisthenes is some variation on him saying that he would rather go mad than experience pleasure. The Cynic's abasement justifies their condescension, just as the dog is imbued with magic by its own tenuous social status. This cynical gesture of condescension from below, rather than the high-handedness of Plato and Aristotle, is the true prototype of all philosophical critique.

Food for Thought

Dionysius of Heraclea was, for much of his life, a stoic. A student of Zeno. A man of surety. Of strong constitution. He put his name to a number of works, all of which now lost, save for their titles: On Apathy, On Training, On Pleasure, On Riches and Favours and Revenge (and a few more, though we need not list them all). But what can be said about a title alone? Perhaps very little. Each of these titles could easily be found sitting in the 'smart thinking' section of a chain store, adorning some more-or-less helpful self-help text written by some more-or-less sincere pop-psychologist. Dionysius' concerns are of a timeless appeal and stoicism itself is never seemingly out of fashion, but, knowing nothing of their content, we will learn nothing from the texts themselves. We may, however, learn something from the title that Dionysius earned for himself.

Some time, later in life, Dionysus became afflicted with chronic pain, localized at the back of one of his eyes. This prompted the once healthy and steadfast man into a radical change of perspective. He disavowed his earlier commitments to stoicism and turned, instead, to the hedonism of the Cyreniacs, acquiring, by virtue of this, the title of Renegade. Now, it would be easy to paint this as a typical picture of how stoic attempts to discipline the mind will ultimately flounder in the face of any sufficiently intensive or extensive physical pain. The body keeps the score and at some point the mind cannot keep count, or something like that. But that would be lazy and reductive. It would fail to comprehend the meaning of Dionysius' change of heart, and impose upon it only the content of his hedonistic turn, telling his history from its victory.

The stoics were not ignorant of pain. Many were, on account of their social standing, relatively insulated from toil, though this was far from a universal truth. Indeed, Epictetus, a favourite of both the French Enlightenment and the contemporary self-improvement guru, was a slave. The stoic ethic was not a simple assertion of Mind over Matter. But what we can glean from the Renegade is that this was, perhaps, *his* understanding. Dionysius' biography does not speak to the triumph of this or that ethical outlook but rather to the failure of his self-relation as both mind *and* body.

Dionysius' initial stoicism was a satisfying reduction. It felt good for him to think that he had mastery over the appetites of his soul, as man of surety, of strong constitution. But this felt *less good* than the pain of failure felt bad. The body is not so easily satisfied and the mind not so easily dominated. Learning the weakness of his mind he concedes to it and substitutes for the stoic life a new simplification. His turn to hedonism, though prompted by chronic pain, was not in satisfaction of his body: it soothed his mind. His

mind had failed, ultimately, to dominate *itself* and this new ethics absolved him of that difficulty. Whereas the old reduction had appeared to satisfy his body, this new reduction appeared to satisfy his mind. But both were, at base, satisfactions of a voracious mentality; a body in denial of itself.

The truth of this is made by the manner of his death. Dionysius, at the age of eighty, having spent many years first as stoic, then later a hedonist, in an act of asceticism seemingly at odds with them both, starved himself to death. Had he, then, at last, won the battle? Suppressing his bodily instincts through so total a mastery of his mind that they could no longer fight back against him? No. Dionysius' death represents the total victory of the body, for it had convinced the mind this victory was its own. In his attempt to infinitely suspend the tension of having a body he had shown himself utterly incapable of facing the struggle of being one, exposing both his stoicism and his hedonism as so much repression thereof.

Dionysius was neither, really, a stoic nor hedonist; he simply shovelled these teachings down into his belly/stomach to quiet whatever discomfort he was, at the time, unable or unwilling to confront. It was perhaps this disposition that Zeno identified when, upon Dionysius asking why he never corrected him in class, Zeno replied, "It is because I do not trust you." He treated all teaching as mere food for thought. To satisfy the appetite of his inner resentment. Rather than comprehending either ethic as an engagement with the tension between body and mind he understood them each as domination and disavowed the fight he was afraid he could not win.

Avoiding Distress

Our truth is the intersection of many independent lies. Thus, every body of knowledge is built on a structure of cultured ignorance; the lie within truth is one of omission. This is self-evident in the history of pestilence. The Antonine Plague, the first pandemic to rupture ancient civil society, has been transmitted to us via various textual sources, but primarily from Galen's *De indolentia* (περὶ ἀλυπίας—"on avoiding distress"). The exact etiology or what caused the pandemic remains a matter of controversy; initially, historians unanimously agreed that it was smallpox, but recent genomic and phylodynamic work has cast doubt on that conclusion. *De indolentia* is a curious text, Galen wrote it as an exercise of equanimity to demonstrate his mastery over the vicissitudes of misfortune. The text catalogues his personal losses during the plague years—a library destroyed by fire, manuscripts lost in transit—and rehearses the mental disciplines required to maintain *ataraxia* amid catastrophe. What the text does not catalog, except as occasion for demonstrating indifference, are the material conditions genomic analysis now reveals: livestock decimation disrupting

grain supply, urban mortality concentrating in *insulae* tenements where the non-citizen poor lived at lethal densities, mass graves (and sometimes there were no graves!) where the bodies of slaves were deposited without record or ritual. The plague appears in Galen's writing as *physis*—nature, fortune, the unavoidable—never as *politeia*, never as a product of social organization.

This is not a mistake or a matter of nescience; Galen is *the* physician of antiquity after all. In his work, e.g. *On the Method of Healing*, you find acute clinical observations: pneumonic symptoms, bubo formation, mortality patterns, and detailed taxonomy of diseases. But we know better today, don't we? Ancient medicine was an individualizing profession, a determinate concept of population has yet to emerge. Galen was concerned with the patient's specific constitution, their healthy base-line, their humors, in order to understand both what is wrong and how best to treat it, to return the sick person to their previous state of health. Genomic sequencing of *Yersinia pestis* from Roman-era dental pulp has allowed bioinformaticians to reconstruct what Galen of Pergamon could not say.

What genomic analysis and computational reconstruction reveal is not the correction of ancient error but the exposure of necessary erasure, the independent lie. Galen's silence about the political economy of differential death was ideological labor essential to imperial subjectivity, not a fault of knowledge. Roman civil society required that slave mortality remain unthinkable as social murder—otherwise, the entire edifice of *humanitas* collapses into its actual foundation: normalized mass violence. Philosophy provided the conceptual apparatus for this unthinkability. Stoicism's universalizing gesture—"all men die, the sage accepts this"—performs the same function as our contemporary epidemiological models when they describe plague transmission via "population density" and "R-naught values" without naming that density as a function of land-rent, or that certain populations were rendered expendable by law. To sequence ancient DNA is to read biological evidence of what written sources suppressed, but the reading itself occurs within institutions (genomic research facilities, university presses, grant-giving bodies) that reproduce contemporary versions of the same exclusions. Whose deaths are we counting now? Whose remains, in Galen's phrase, matter for "avoiding distress?"

Where Galen required Stoic discipline to render mass death philosophically tolerable, we require statistical models, machine learning optimizations, the entire apparatus of data science. The content changes: genomic markers replace humoral imbalances, neural networks replace syllogistic reasoning. But the form persists. Catastrophe appears as an object of contemplation, of reconstruction, of knowledge production; never as an indictment of the social order that organizes who lives and who dies. Technical reason, in making the past legible, reads its own prehistory. The algorithm that translates

περὶ ἀλυπίας does not transcend the text's ideology; it extends it. We have developed new instruments for the same refusal. This is what development means: barbarism becoming more sophisticated in its forms, more total in its reach, more capable of naming itself while remaining unchanged. The plague killed; Galen philosophized; we sequence and model and publish. The self-scarring continues, now with better tools for describing the wound we continue to inflict.

Wisdom Died Twice

The apocalypse is the most productive time to acquaint yourself with the signs of God. The dark night of the soul materialized twice: first as Athens, representing eternity; second as Baghdad, representing history. Said another way, wisdom died twice.

In 9th-century Iraq, after a bloody civil war, the Caliph al-Ma'mun ascended the throne. A lover of the intellect, he established *Bayt al-Hikmah* (the house of wisdom) and generously financed it. Aristotle, it is said, came to him in a dream, urging the union of Greek wisdom and Islamic knowledge. However, al-Ma'mun's belief in the *Bayt* was more a wager than a gift: he believed that the Day of Judgment was near and wanted to meet Allah having built the architecture that unified Greek, Indian, Persian, and Arabic knowledge—the ideal soul for the Round City of Baghdad. It is within this milieu that the black Mutakallim read the signs.

At the end of the Mutakallim's life, Abu Uthman Amr ibn Bahr al-Kinani al-Basri, better known as al-Jāḥiẓ, attempted to document totality. He endeavored to make an encyclopedia of animals, documenting over 350 species, from the housefly to the lion, outlining their habitats, food chains, and taxonomy. Unfinished at seven volumes, the *Kitāb al-Hayawān* (book of animals) was something fundamentally different from Aristotle's *Historia Animalium*: an allegory for creation that, by way of its reading, assimilates other semiotic systems to its own cosmological biosemiotics. What emerges from al-Jāḥiẓ's prose is 9th century Baghdad and Basra via text—cities and creatures, Bedouins and mosques, markets and salt marshes, rendered as a single interconnected whole. Ecology before the word existed.

Scholars gloss al-Jāḥiẓ's method as "accretive intercategory," nowhere better demonstrated than the Dog-Rooster debate. The Proponent of the Rooster claims that the Dog is a cursed creature: neither predator (sabuʿ) nor prey (bahīma,) wild nor domesticated, clean nor unclean. It guards a household it cannot fully enter, hunts beside a master it does not fully serve, and reveals its essence by eating its own excrement and defiling corpses. The Proponent of the Dog retorts in kind. Loves its abusers? So does the Sheep. Eats corpses?

So do Lions. Worried about excrement—have you seen Camels, Chickens, Fish, Pigs, Eels? For every neither-nor, a both-and. Poetry, proverb, ḥadīth, Islamic law—all marshaled toward one animal's honor. Then the Proponent of the Dog brings the Pigeon: not filth this time, but breeding, varieties multiplied by hand until no fancier can say what a Pigeon is. The Dog was cursed by what it touched; the Pigeon is cursed by what it has become. The Rooster's side had asked what the Dog truly is; the Pigeon asks what anything is, once you start asking. If you cannot think the Dog, you cannot think the Pigeon—and *a fortiori*, you cannot think the Rooster. Every animal lives at the threshold of every category. The debate was supposed to establish which animal was superior; what it established was that superiority requires a ladder, and the ladder requires rungs that hold. The *Scala Naturae* cannot stand. From this education the ideal reader learns to interpret the signs, restoring a precarious social harmony.

If an animal within its environment is a sign of god, then the same holds for the human animal. Al-Jāḥiẓ knew this with urgency. A Black man—a Zanj—in a society where attributes were weapons, he turned the intercategory method directly on Blackness itself. If the Dog is neither predator nor prey but the product of its relations, then Blackness carries no force internal to itself. It is a complexion produced by sun and geography, not a substance with inherent meaning. It is a testament to the power of this method that, even today, who and what constitutes the Zanj remains a live historiographical controversy. The *Kitāb Fakhr al-Sudān ʿalā al-Bīḍān* (Book of the Boast of the Blacks over the Whites) was a philosophical weapon, its blade the same one sharpened on the Pigeon and the Mule. And yet, al-Jāḥiẓ's household contained a concubine, a eunuch, a slave; each a sign he refused to read. The method had dissolved the foundation of the institution in which he lived, and he did not follow it home. The ideal readers, unlike the ideal writer, must follow the signs from home to city.

Every sign bears the mark of its conditions, as the animals demonstrated, as Blackness confirmed, as the water beneath the cities made undeniable. A famous Arabic proverb: where the water ends, the land ends. Abbasid Iraq was an empire of flow—water, goods, bodies—and the Tigris and Euphrates were its defining terms. Baghdad sat at the rivers' confluence, the Round City's geometric ideal presiding over everything the water carried toward it: grain from the north, bodies from the south, spices and ceramics from the Indian Ocean. The caliphs built riverside palaces with sweeping vistas, audience chambers raised above a series of courts. For the masters, water was a vista; the Round City's geometry as the soul's ideal form, indifferent to the network beneath it. At the bottom of the same river system lay Basra: the delta, the confluence, the blood of the empire's commercial exchange. Here

al-Jāḥiẓ assembled his method in the Mirbad marketplace, among madmen and Bedouin brigands and Jewish poets, not in the *Bayt*. Further south the water descended into salt marshes, below the city, below the market, below the vista—the Tigris and Euphrates losing definition, braided into channels and reed beds that shifted with the seasons, the boundary between water and land dissolving exactly as the proverb said it would. This was the empire's agricultural foundation and its most illegible sign: the labor that drained the marshes, worked the salt flats, maintained the irrigation network that fed the cities that housed the palaces that produced the vistas. The soul, at this scale, was the earth, and the people most acquainted with it were the Zanj. But were they even able to read the signs?

The Zanj did. They rebelled. Rayhan ibn Salih, Rafiq, Sulayman ibn Jami—the black vanguard history tried to read away—and behind them a coalition of enslaved and manumitted, peasant and craftsman, Arab Bedouin and Bahraini, every body the ladder sorted beneath politics assembling into a force—at that moment they were all Zanj—that held the strongest administrative system in the Muslim world at bay for 15 years. They read the signs from the salt marsh and the reed channels imperial troops could not navigate, ambushing canal forces from concealed side channels, fighting from inside the water rather than above it. Ali ibn Muhammad declared that the most qualified man should reign, even if an Abyssinian slave, which is to say: the attribute has no force internal to itself, the niche produces the qualification, the salt marsh co-generated the sign-reader that Wisdom could not. South of Basra, intersected by canals and protected by an iron chain across the main waterway, the Zanj built al-Mukhtara, the Elect City—palaces of baked clay, houses of brick and palm leaf, its own currency minted as early as 871. The Round City claimed to embody the divine plan: soul and city corresponding, signs resolving into the Creator's wisdom. Al-Mukhtara was built on natural history—the water that moves, the boundary that shifts, the category that will not hold. Its unlocatability is its philosophical statement: the divine plan requires a fixed point; natural history has only conditions, and conditions change. When the rebellion was crushed in 883, plantation slavery was never again practiced in the Arab world. The method, once loose, did not stop even in defeat. The Bayt al-Hikmah's books entered the Tigris in 1258, the water running black with ink, wisdom returned to the element it had refused to think. It died because it would not go where the Zanj already were. Wisdom died twice—once in Athens, once in Baghdad—and both times it built a city to last forever. The Round City has vanished without a trace. Al-Mukhtara never asked to be found. The false is an index of itself and the true. The signs are still here.

What if Nature Wasn't What You Thought?

It is said that John Scotus Eriugena's students stabbed him to death with their stylii. Whatever the provenance of this story it provides us with a telling counterpoint to this early Medieval philosopher's christianized Neoplatonism. More than that, it gives us a useful opportunity to reflect on the practice of philosophy in general—on what it hides, what it reveals, and where its truth really lies.

In his most important work, the Periphyseon, Eriugena develops a physiologia, a Science of Nature, in which the latter is understood as a totality that encompasses both those things that are and those that are not. He sets it up so that *what is not* is to be understood as equivalent to what cannot be grasped by the senses or by the intellect, while *what is* corresponds to what can be so grasped. Among the things which cannot be grasped we find: God, the primordial causes and the higher orders of beings like angels. These are the hidden and unknowable essences of all that is manifest, the causes which lie behind the spatio-temporal world of becoming, those truths which remain concealed within "the most secret folds of nature."

In other words, for Eriugena, power, creation and ultimate explanation for everything we take to be real in our everyday lives rests in a supersensible beyond that is both so high above and so deep within the things of our world as to be permanently hidden to us. Even human nature, which is unique among created things insofar as it is cast in God's image, can only know of itself *that* it is, but never *what* it is, and this is so precisely because its lack of self-comprehension is what secures its infinity and likeness to God. God, the creative power from which everything emanates, through which it exists, and to which it returns, Nature, the totality of what is and is not, and Man himself are all knowable only negatively, analogously, and dialectically, but never concretely or truly—neither in nor for themselves, if you'll allow me to use such anachronistic terminology.

This physiologia is presented in the form of a dialogue between a master and his suitably deferential pupil. In contrast to this idealized pedagogical relation, the real relation between Eriugena and his actual pupils in the story of his death allows us to see the doctrines just discussed in a new light. Whether the events of the story actually took place or not, they contain a truth hidden by the philosophical idealization of the Periphyseon.

In putting their pens to use not as weapons of criticism but as instruments of criticism with weapons, Eriugena's pupils show that while it may be true that what is beyond comprehension constitutes the hidden cause of the world of appearance, it is more likely only what is beyond the comprehension of the philosopher and his idealizing abstractions. Rather than looking to the

supersensible beyond or some unknowable transcendence as the ground of what comes to be and passes away, Eriugena would have been better off if he had turned his attention to what would become the source of his own passing away, and what is the source of coming to be for all of us: the manifest and sensible world of social relations.

They also give us a hint as to how the idealized relations of philosophical form can actually ground the philosophical content they enform. Just as the engaged acceptance and respectful posture of the idealized pupil of the Periphyseon allows the enlightened master to unfold an account in which the hidden, benevolent origins of power are recognizable through their visible manifestations without a hitch, so form always does its share of the work in providing the conditions for a specific content to take shape. This is a hint that applies just as much to the modern philosophical essay or monograph, with their assumptions of transparent communicability and indifferent address, as it does to the more visibly constructed and more obviously contrived—at least to our modern eyes—form of the dialogue.

What a non-idealized philosophical form looks like, one that does not turn away from the real social relations within which it is embedded, remains to be seen; unless it is simply the collective practice of self-emancipation through the weapon of criticism and criticism by weapons—a practice carried out for the most part by people who are not typically seen as philosophers, but one into which putative philosophers must subsume themselves if they are to have any chance of finding truth.

Weak, Indigent, and Rootless

Aggression is natural. All animals have a limb for defense, but God gave man alone a brain for thinking and hands for working. These two powers combine to enable labor and the crafts. Man's most primal tools, the ones that put him on even ground with the dumb beasts of the Earth, are lances, swords, and shields.

These arms, however, are insufficient for man to defend himself against his fellow man: "If you are not a wolf, the wolves shall eat you," as the saying goes. The only way out of this impasse is through the emergence of a human restrainer, *wāzi'*, that stands above the people and dominates them, but even this is a natural and necessary process—that is, if it can be called a process at all. By Ibn Khaldun's own claim that it is impossible for human society to reach a true state of anarchy, it must be concluded that the pattern of restraint emerged outside of historical time. Even the maximal freedom of the desert-dwelling Bedouins and Berbers is conditioned by the natural restraints of political animality.

Still, kings and rulers do emerge. Dynasties are carried to the throne by the group feeling of their tribe, house, or faction, then lose their group feeling and rule through clients and followers, laws and punishments. The ruler's personal restraining force is supplanted by that of the law, and the noble vegetate in luxury as their subjects languish under draconian harshness, becoming cowardly and unfit for militia service. To be punished by the law when one cannot defend oneself is humiliating and leads to the destruction of fortitude. Similarly, a child that grows up in the bosom of the city and receives education is deprived of its fortitude, being habituated to authority and incapable of self-reliance. Such craven beings make poor men.

Seeing the pitfalls of punishment and education, the Prophet applied a different restraint. Religious principles, unlike the law of the state, function without external sanction. The believers carry them within themselves, for they received the precepts of faith from the Lawgiver in a way that transcended technical instruction and scientific education. How could the Prophet have scientifically educated his companions when both he and so many of them were illiterate? With foresight, Muhammad stipulated that a ruler should not be too shrewd, for the shrewd are wont to be tyrants, and even predicted that the caliphate to succeed him would last only thirty years before descending into tyranny and injustice. Those who are too clever are all "would-be *shayatin*."

In time, the leaders of the state came to exclusively concern themselves with governmental affairs, and by the end of the ʿAbbasid Caliphate scholarship had become a profession for the timid and resentful. Once worthy of being likened to prophets by God's final messenger, the erstwhile class of scholars, *ʿulama*, degenerated to the status of mere teachers for hire, *mu'allimun*, representing little more than a pack of "weak, indigent, and rootless" ingrates despised by those who enjoy the power of the state, perhaps because the rulers understood that these weaklings can only sap the fortitude of their subjects. Learning is further restraint, knowledge of the crafts and sciences a noxious tonic brewed in the luxury of civilization.

The scholars, for their part, are unable to grasp why they are hated. Political matters slip through the sieve of their analogical intellect just as the true contents of the sciences slip through the frivolous abridgements and handbooks they produce. Though scholars are mere "urban weaklings," rulers still find themselves obliged to keep some scholars, particularly jurists, on hand for the maintenance of religious order. Lesser intellectuals found work teaching. Those in Ifriqiyah and the Maghrib used the Qur'an as the basis of their curriculum to the disbenefit of their students, for the Qur'an is inimitable and its study cannot provide students with the habits of knowledge.

And yet, children must be taught religion before they have "shaken off the

yoke of authority," and the power of custom dictates that the Qur'an comes first. Education is caught in a blind alley. Religion stands alone as the sole restraining force and form of knowledge that can sustain a dynasty, but it is impossible to teach religion without degrading both religion and teaching. Ibn Khaldun had served every post imaginable for a man of his rank: chancellery secretary, judge, professor, privy councilor, military commander, diplomat, prime minister—and his verdict was dim. When the father of social science takes on the role of a teacher and directly addresses his reader as a student in the sixth chapter of his *Muqaddimah*, it can only be interpreted as an act of desperation.

Humanity is not merely held in suspension between its natural and supernatural destinies, between the promise and the threat, by the circle of civilization; It is hanged. Prophetic ecstasy is the only thing that can put a spoke in the wheel and briefly establish an interregnum in the cycle of the lower world, where life is no more than the enjoyment of delusion.

On Becoming a Woman

The bivalent attitude which Christine de Pizan displays to her own gender is a result of the fortune and misfortune associated therewith. If, at the beginning of *The Book of the City of Ladies*, she laments her femininity, in the first book of *On the Mutability of Fortune* she laments the fact that Fortune saw fit to transform her into a man. Nature endowed Christine with a crown containing the precious stones of Discretion, Consideration, and Retention, but her female assignment at birth prevented her from inheriting her father's earthly possessions.

What prompts male chauvinism? In *The Book of the City of Ladies*, Christine's interlocutor Lady Reason provides a taxonomy of misogynists: those who defame women out of ignorance, those who do so out of vice and impotence, those who do so from jealousy, those who take pleasure in slander, and those who wish to demonstrate their erudition. None of these types are blameless - Reason even compares the ignorant misogynist to someone who has committed manslaughter - and yet each species of misogynist has its own particular venom. The misogynist who attacks women out of ignorance is harmful because he cannot be trusted to reason properly; he who attacks women out of vice and impotence is harmful because he has turned into a shriveled, misanthropic husk after a lifetime of pleasure-seeking, the vanity of vanities. Those who attack women out of jealousy recognize that they are intellectually mediocre and have boundless passion for attacking those whom they recognize as their rightful superiors; those who attack women from a desire for slander need no explanation for the harm they cause.

The recalcitrant dismissal of women opens up a philosophical puzzle: its origin. De Pizan, much like de Gouges centuries later, decries both the epistemic injustices that men commit against women *as well as* the property relations which forbid women from forming an independent bloc of economic power with which to rectify the situation. Yet unlike de Gouges, de Pizan does not attempt to connect the two causally. De Gouges insightfully sees nature as licensing egalitarian, pro-social relations between genders, yet de Pizan reverts to the chauvinist dogmas of her time on occasion. When de Pizan asks Reason why women do not hold legal offices, Reason responds by claiming that the different genders have different functions and serve different ends, a clear nod to the Aristotelian chauvinism that predominated in her time. From such a justification was the Salic Law upheld. And yet de Pizan's personal role in helping France's diplomatic aims during the Hundred Years' War points to a performative contradiction; she condones a gendered division of labor in her writings yet shows their historical decadence in her actions *in piazza*.

Fortuna Audentes Iuvat

The philosopher, like the prince, must avoid flatterers. If, in *The Prince*, Machiavelli counsels that Fortune has its due, but that a sagacious ruler can temper it by working alongside it, then in the *Discourses* we see the inanity of the princely form of government itself. Be he under the rule of law or unshackled, a prince is less wise and constant than the people. Unjust people can be spoken to or dispersed, while the unjust prince can only be tempered by steel; the misdeeds of the common people are done in the name of the common good, while the prince's misdeeds are done only for his own sake. Moreover, as maintaining the good graces of Fortune requires new provisions, a free republic will ever be able to supply a fresh crop of virtuous citizens, able to stand alongside history, weathering its tumults through skillful navigation instead of obstinate opposition. Fortune, then, is not a woman to be beaten, but a companion to be respected.

In the final chapters of Book I of the *Discourses*, the Polybian taxonomy of the anacyclosis is swept away, as is any classical liberal concern for artificially balancing the state against itself. There is only the free state, full of the people, wishing to keep itself free through its own *virtù* rather than grovel at the feet of their putative superiors. Yet this is no utopia: we are in a world of real people, subject to real political forces, which can drive a republic into servitude if not taken care of. A free people must beat down the ambition of its elites, lest their ceaseless lust for dominance subjugate the entire society. Consequently, the people need not respect aristocratic titles or the norms of noble civility. Fortune has no need for efflorescent reverence - like Hamlet,

she knows not *seems*. All that matters is that the people carry out their most praiseworthy of duties - ensuring the maintenance of liberty through licentiousness

This task need not grant eternal reward - some societies *will* still decay despite the best efforts of its people to prevent the corruption of the nobility from undermining it. Yet a valiant defeat is still valiant. The Gracchi failed, yet their failure still prevented the accrual of yet more economic and political power in the hands of vicious and incompetent oligarchs. Struggle necessarily closes off the possibility of apodictic victory; it is still necessary to undertake regardless, for the alternative is a consolidation of tyrannical power in the hands of a self-interested few.

Those who do not respect Fortune should not expect her good graces. She takes great offense at the accumulation of power into the hands of an oligarchy or tyrant, for such people are ungrateful owing to greed and wish to oppress others. Consequently, their endeavors are done poorly and without sufficient care for the people, as was the case of the French invasion of 1494. On the other hand, she smiles on those who trust the people as the foundation of all free rule, since their desires "are rarely harmful to liberty, because they are born from being oppressed, or from suspicion of having been oppressed." She also demands that the common people see to their own defense in both the domestic and foreign spheres, and be given good motive to take up arms. There is no motive greater than one's own freedom from domination, and thus class struggle is the basis of stable society.

Fortune despises indolence, and for this reason she has no need for the so-called "gentlemen" who "idly live on the incomes of their possessions abundantly, without having any care for cultivation or of other necessary undertakings for living." These so-called gentlemen of yesteryear, like capital today, are "dead labour, which, vampire-like, lives only by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks." Closing oneself off from the world, idly indulging in ephemera reserved only for an aristocratic elite, is the negation of the dynamism of the free republic. Its indulgence comes at the price of the ruination of the rational society, for it undermines the restraints on the powerful that enable society to flourish. Such people are pernicious and ossify vice and corruption. The Florentine counsels the free republic to treat them like the sons of Brutus. Centuries before Robespierre, the sclerotic rule of the Italian city-states was proof that virtue without terror is impotence, and terror without virtue is destruction manifest.

Cogito Ergo Sum Extensus

Few know that René Descartes was not a dualist but a pseudo-dialectician, and a clever one at that. What is evident in the Sixth Mediation is downright clear and distinct in the 1643 letters to Princess Elisabeth of Bohemia, that the mind and body must be conceived as both two and one. So much for an open and shut case of dualism. The cleverness of his response to Princess Elisabeth's question—how can the mind move the body when such movement necessitates the extension the mind lacks?—lies in the fact that it is spurious as much as it is true. Descartes tells the Princess that she already possesses a concept for understanding how (1) the mind and body are really distinct, meaning I am extensionless mind that can outlive my extended body, and (2) these really distinct substances simultaneously comprise a whole human being. It is the concept at the heart of an apparently accepted but false theory of gravity. Descartes says that while one abuses the concept in question by applying it to weight and the body to which it is imagined to be joined, since they are not really distinct, it is precisely the "primitive notion" through which the apparent contradiction of the relationship between the mind and body together can be grasped. For the purportedly distinct quality of weight is falsely believed to inhere in bodies and move them toward the center of the Earth without pushing them and thus without requiring extension. Gravity may remain obscurely conceived but the contradiction motivating Princess Elisabeth's problem has thus been resolved. That is to say, an accepted framework has been supplied for conceiving how a mind that is really distinct from body (and therefore lacks extension) can move the extended body with which it is intimately united.

Clever Descartes does not deserve most of the calumny inflicted upon him. And yet Elisabeth is right to want what this pseudo-dialectician cannot give: dialectical mediation, for him to say that I *as a thinking thing* am empirical body, beast of burden, rotting flesh.

Love is a Bourgeois Construct

Bourgeois revolutionaries are ever stuck in their own antinomies. On the one hand, their program of universal freedom and equality points to a world beyond class divisions, yet on the other, their program also valorizes the present state of things, be they extant socioeconomic forms or political symbols. No figure better exemplified this antinomy than Olympe de Gouges. Qua proto-feminist, she rightfully decried the racial and gender inequality of her time, and even correctly identified economic relations as a source of women's disempowerment. At the same time, de Gouges' appraisal of Marie

Antoinette reveals that the former valorized a moribund feudal nobility, a penchant which ultimately led her to the guillotine.

While de Gouges notes that economic inequality is a wellspring from which gender inequality draws its strength, she meditates this source by way of the family. The Salic Law forbade female inheritance, and so she sought to remedy this injustice by proposing marital and inheritance reform, wherein a couple would pool all assets upon marriage and divide them equally to all children upon the couple's death. Such an arrangement would be enforced through a contract to which both parties would agree. Here the irony of landing Marie Antoinette becomes apparent; while the French Revolution was the precondition for the possibility of martial and inheritance reform, as it rid the country of the nobility which relied on the Salic Law, de Gouges herself implicitly legitimized the Salic Law by exhorting one of the few women who materially benefited from its enforcement.

Another limitation of de Gouges' proposal is that it can only help those who already have material wealth to inherit in the first place. The nascent bourgeoisie would find de Gouges' proposal beneficial as they could pass on their wealth to their progeny. However, the Third Estate lumped together all lay people regardless of wealth, and those sans-culottes who would later form the proletariat would have little to pass onto their children regardless of gender. This lack of inheritance reproduces the very gendered relations that de Gouges sought to remedy; while she correctly identified economic dependence as a source of feminine unfreedom, by trying to solve this problem purely at the level of private contract, she prevents the women of the sans-culottes from benefitting from her reforms unless they supplicate themselves in front of a rich man.

While de Gouges was a bourgeois revolutionary *par excellence*, she nonetheless remained a bourgeois revolutionary insofar as she sought to remedy inequality through the formal mechanism of the contract. The dramaturgist de Gouges has a proletarian counterpart in the thespian Claire Lacombe, who vociferously argued for the execution of the nobility but also the restriction of capital accumulation to better provide for the women of the sans-culottes.

Despite the half-heartedness of her proposals, de Gouges' oeuvre points to a world beyond class relations, though she herself does not know it. By correctly identifying the *social and material* sources of inequality, she deserves commendation for rising above the *purely private* domain in which other bourgeois thinkers of her time languished. *At the same time*, by restricting her solutions to the private sphere, her thought retains a bourgeois streak that prevents her proposal from forming the basis of universal liberation. The liberation of women, like the liberation of humanity as a whole, is not to be sought in private contract, but in the rectification of the social totality.

Translations

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Ontology and Eros: On the Speculative Deduction of Homosexuality - A Lemmatical Sketch

Hans-Jürgen Krahl

Translator's Introduction[1]

"Ontology and Eros: On the Speculative Deduction of Homosexuality - A Lemmatical Sketch" is a short, obscure, and fragmentary text written by German militant and philosopher Hans-Jürgen Krahl in 1966. Despite the subtitle, it does not really contain a "speculative deduction of homosexuality." Rather, it is a critical engagement with the intertwinement of sexuality and ontology throughout the history of European philosophy and thought, and it is in this sense that the text is a "lemmatical sketch." The investigation into the historical connection between sexuality and metaphysics sketched out by Krahl is an incomplete segment of a larger argument—that is, a lemma—which would perhaps comprise the true "speculative deduction of homosexuality." Tragically, Krahl died in a car accident in 1970 at age 27, leaving this project and countless others unfinished.

As a gay man in a country where homosexuality was illegal—the Federal Republic of Germany maintained a law from 1871 banning male homosexuality until 1994—and a Marxist to boot, Krahl was closely attuned to issues of feminism and sexual politics, though they were not the primary focus of his political activity. He was harangued for this lapse at the 1968 conference of the *Sozialistische Deutsche Studentenbund* (Socialist German Students Union, SDS) by comrades from a small group called the *Aktionsrat zur Befreiung der Frauen* (Action Committee for Women's Liberation). One member, Sigrid Rüger, denounced him for being "objectively a counter-revolutionary and an agent of the class enemy as well" before pelting him with tomatoes.[2] While it is true that Krahl largely acted out the role of an archetypical masculine leader in his public political life, he was so upset by the *Tomatenwurf*, as the event has come to be known, that Rüger had to visit him later that evening in order to apologize and comfort him: He would not get out of the bathtub

[1] Translated by J. E. Morain

[2] The reality of the denunciation is disputed, but it is referenced in the account given by Norbert Saßmannshausen in the 2008 edition of *Konstution und Klassenkampf*, see 434.

and stop crying otherwise.[3] In general, he broadly agreed with the feminist contingent of SDS but avoided publicly intervening in the debates between the feminists and the more backwards male comrades.[4]

"Ontology and Eros" bears the stamp of the so-called first generation of the Frankfurt School very strongly. In a certain sense this is notable because, despite their attention to issues of sexual relations, homosexuality only came up tangentially in the writings of Adorno, Horkheimer, and the rest—Marcuse being somewhat of an exception.[5] Although Adorno lobbied for the decriminalization of homosexuality in Germany, Marcuse openly defended the so-called perversions in a much more direct and emphatic way. While Adorno wrote that "homosexuals [...] are *perceived* as the *portent* of a sexuality alienated from its proper purpose,"[6] Marcuse brashly stated a few years prior in *Eros and Civilization* that "the perversions," homosexuality among them, "express rebellion against the subjugation of sexuality under the order of procreation,"[7] and then went on to argue at length that this was basically a good thing. Still, the imprint of *Dialectic of Enlightenment*'s critical narrative of Western history and Adorno's subsequent critique of identity thinking in *Negative Dialectics* is plainly visible in Krahl's thought. His arguments build on the foundations established by Marcuse in *Eros and Civilization* and Horkheimer and Adorno in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*. Beyond taking these cues, however, he also implicitly criticizes them by focusing on homosexuality and thereby drawing attention to the lacuna it represents in their work.

Upon first reading the text, some may be disturbed by the ironic misogyny and homophobia that Krahl lets loose as he ventriloquizes the likes of Plato, Aristotle, and Saint Paul, but beneath the surface-level mock-homophobia of Krahl's argument, we can detect a purpose only hinted at: to save (homo-) sexuality from identity, domination, and patriarchy.[8] Plato confined pleasure

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[3] *Die Tageszeitung*, "Die Frau, die die Tomate warf," 12 January 1996. The *Tomatenwurf* is often seen as the public announcement of the arrival of the Second Wave of feminism in Germany.

[4] See Julian Volz, "Das "historisch neue Vernunftprinzip der Emanzipation" - Über Krahl, Marcuse und die neue Frauenbewegung" in *Für Hans-Jürgen Krahl - Beiträge zu seinem antiautoritären Marxismus*, ed. Gerber et al (Mandelbaum Verlag, 2022), 198-225.

[5] Erich Fromm is also an exception, but in a negative way because of the explicit homophobia he sometimes displayed, notably in *The Art of Loving*.

[6] Theodor W. Adorno, *Critical Models: Interventions and Catchwords*, tr. Henry Pickford (Columbia University Press, 2005), 80. My emphasis. The sentence quoted referenced "pre-genital sexuality" in the first printed version, see Note 15 on 338.

[7] Herbert Marcuse, *Eros and Civilization: A Philosophical Inquiry into Freud.* Beacon Press (1974), 49.

[8] Mario Mieli, evidently not aware that Krahl was gay, seems to have interpreted Krahl as a homophobe and opined that if only he "had taken it in the rear" Krahl would have better understood that Plato was fundamentally straight, not gay—if only! See his *Towards a Gay Communism: Elements of Homosexual Critique*, trs. David Fernbach and Evan Calder Williams (Pluto Press, 2018), 143.

to homosexuality, and then confined homosexuality to pederasty, only for Saint Paul to respond a few centuries later by banishing pleasure from sexuality altogether because it was now too gay—God alone could be the object of (desensualized) homosexual desire. Why was it that "All dialectical thinkers of mediation have a sympathetic attitude towards heterosexuality," while homosexuality was associated with identity thinking? What did this queer revision of Horkheimer and Adorno's account of the relation between sexuality and philosophy tell us about contemporary sexual politics? Krahl's analysis of Ancient Greek philosophy offers some answers to the first question, but largely leaves the second unspoken and unanswered.

The German critical theorist Marcel Stoetzler has tried to provide an answer. His gloss on Krahl (and Adorno) is that "The crucial contribution of homosexuality to human civilisation lies in its unequivocal assertion of the purposelessness of sexuality."[9] However, Stoetzler's exegesis of "Ontology and Eros" bypasses any reference to Marcuse, whose thought was just as if not more influential for the essay than that of Adorno. If, as Krahl argues, sensuous enjoyment is invariably mediated through labor, the purposive act *par excellence*, then the relation between a liberated sexuality and purposiveness must be more complex than what Stoetzler's interpretation suggests. Rather than the purposeless freedom of sexuality, I believe that the conclusion to which Krahl's argument points vis-a-vis sexuality is more in line with Marcuse's critical reappraisal of Charles Fourier's sensual utopianism. Given that Krahl always strove to connect theory back to concrete political and organizational issues, I will try to briefly sketch out what I take to be the *Krahl'sche* position on sexual politics. If "scientific socialism" must "supply the formula for concrete utopia" in order to "produce fantasies of social revolution and actualize potential class consciousness," then queer liberation is important for it as both a goal and a means.[10]

Contra Stoetzler, Krahl's argument is precisely that striving for purposeless "pure pleasure" will inevitably fall back into practical asceticism and identity thinking; he repeats verbatim the sentence "pure pleasure is askesis" twice in this text of less than fifteen hundred words. Elsewhere, in a set of notes written between 1966 and 1968 on Marcuse's oeuvre, Krahl echoes Marcuse in proclaiming that "Sexuality has become repressively desensualized, a civilized beastiality."[11] And again in a footnote to a 1969 draft on the "Ideology

[9] Marcel Stoetzler, "Adorno, Non-Identity, Sexuality" in *Negativity and Revolution: Adorno and Political Activism*, eds. John Holloway et al. (Pluto Press, 2009), 151-188; 158.

[10] Hans-Jürgen Krahl, *Konstitution und Klassenkampf: Zur historischen Dialektik von bürgerlichen Emanzipation und proletarischer Revolution. Schriften, Reden und Entwürfe aus den Jahren 1966-1970*, 5th expanded edition (Verlag Neue Kritik, 2008), 316

[11] Krahl, *Konstitution und Klassenkampf*, 133.

Critique of Anti-Authoritarian Consciousness" he counterposes the genuine "politicization of private life" with "psychoanalytically and sexual-politically rationalized collective privatization of political practice," an unavoidable process characteristic of the early stages of the New Left that was, however, doomed to "subculturally degenerate."[12]

We can conclude from these pregnant remarks that the sexual politics operating in Krahl's work does not turn around an idea of extracting a utopian moment from sexuality in general and thereby becoming caught in the blind alley of utopianism, nor does it attempt an immediate, forced politicization of the private that would inevitably transform into its opposite. Eros does not just mean purposeless pleasure; it must also mean the disalienation of labor and the institution of new principles that transcend dichotomies like purposeful/purposeless. Instead of mistakenly privatizing the political, freedom from the repression of homosexual desire liberates friendship and comradeship, suggesting a form of organization immanently connected to its goals. As Krahl says, "The anticipation of the liberated society in the organizational forms of the political struggle is always a historically determined mediation of freedom and compulsion."[13] Political action demands the recognition of a political reality principle, but the liberation of sexuality in the present tense constitutes a crucial political moment insofar as it actualizes liberatory needs and the anticipated transcendence of alienation in the practice of solidarity. More simply, sexual liberation is, besides its historical and utopian aspects, one of the key concrete manifestations of the overall struggle against sexual repression, male chauvinism, queerphobia, etc. within a revolutionary movement. Through this struggle, the revolutionary movement can be cured of its "growing pains" (*Kinderkrankheiten*, a favorite word of Krahl's) and develop effective organizational forms and styles of work: "Liberation without materiality is an inhuman possibility but a human impossibility."[14]

[12] Krahl, *Konstitution und Klassenkampf*, 288.
[13] Krahl, *Konstitution und Klassenkampf*, 312.
[14] Krahl, *Konstitution und Klassenkampf*, 335.

Ontology and Eros: On the Speculative Deduction of Homosexuality – A Lemmatical Sketch

Metaphysical ontology has at its center the Eleatic doctrine of the identity of thought and being, which idealistically leads into thought's identity with itself. With the emergence of European philosophy as self-enlightening myth, metaphysical ontology lends to the attempt an initial rational expression, in light of the still insecure appropriation of hostile nature and the tentative emancipation of humans from their compulsion to safeguard this precarious identity both internally and externally. Plato's philosophy designated the consistent—just as thing-like as it is autonomous—in such a way as Idea. The very first Idea is pure unity, free from the multiplicity of the fluid life of nature and safeguarded from the danger of pathologically losing itself in it—thus, pure being. The initial Idea as pure (i.e. identical) Being is the true,[15] the beautiful,[16] and the good. It is the divine. However, this hostile nature, from which humans must win their life, is of the Ill [Übel], non-identical matter, which constantly puts the reproduction of life in question—a reality principle threatening it. Identity, in the ontological early phase of European philosophy, meant, in opposition to its purchase in the bourgeois society of the 19th century, life (Nietzsche: illusion [Schein]); thus early ontology designated the identity of thought and being as truth and [designated] the reality-compulsion of nature, matter that binds just as it is bound, as untrue and non-existent [nichtseiend], as *me on* [non-being]. The pure Idea, the spirit that posits itself as the autonomously determining form that has everything heteronomously material outside itself, flees from nature that has been reduced to *me on*, [nature] whose mediation is to thank the for existence and articulation of human life—on the other hand, [the Idea flees,] in a utopian manner, into a state of absolute domination over nature realized without compulsion, without active confrontation with nature, as the sublation of the reality principle into the pleasure principle. Plato's philosophy formulates this ambivalent relation of humans to nature as the unbridgeable *chorismos* of form and matter. (But this overlooks, in the realm of the ideal, what pleasure-oriented, materialistic hedonism likewise ignores and what only Marx, who begins his early writing with a restitution of sensuality, apprehends. The decisive difference from

[15] That which is designated as the True in this manner is, as such, oriented toward just relations of humans amongst one another as well as the Beautiful and the Good.

[16] Kant: Aesthetics is the theoretical medium [Medium] of the mediation of the *mundus sensibilis* [sensible world] and *mundus intelligibilis* [intelligible world], and [is] in fact Platonic in the sphere of the intelligible; Hegel: the aesthetic becomes existential and living immediacy; Attempt to mediate the both in the sphere of the sensible, the non-identical. Schelling's philosophy of art. Mediation as masochism; nothing more [of?] pure play, ascetic, disinterested intuition in Schiller; the play-drive (Eros); drive as spirit, the idealistic concept of Eros.

philosophical materialism is that it [Marx's philosophy] defines, by means of the epistemological concept of the sensuality of critical reason by way of Feuerbach, sensuality also as subjective practice—labor—and recognizes sensuous enjoyment only as mediated through labor—the frustration of drive. Hedonism, however, [merely] abstracts; it wants pure pleasure. Detached from consumption-mediating labor, pure enjoyment is contemplative meditation. Pure pleasure is *askesis*, monastic life (Epicureanism – Stoicism).[17])

The dualism of form and matter presents the philosophical expression of the domination of nature necessary for life, and it is explained by the *chorismos*, which ascribes ontological and moral dignity to pure form alone, the wish to escape from nature, from which one yet lives, in order to thereby attain the true life—identity; the will to power; dominion over nature; economically, the mode of production—[one can derive] the domination of humans by one another from the relations of production, which receive a partly necessary, partly apparent, but always evident justification from natural law. Social domination is anchored in quasi-natural [naturwüchsig] human relations for this purpose, that each and every appears as unsublatable as these: the quasi-natural sexual division of labor serves this purpose; matriarchy and patriarchy just as well appear primarily as given orders, bound to the sexual division of labor itself.

The Platonic *chorismos* between form and matter expresses the reproductive status of the domination of nature corresponding to the patriarchal organization of the sexual division of labor.

Form, the purest unity, is the determining, masculine moment; this violence of domination is the autonomous Good. Matter is the undetermined and therefore to-be-determined moment, the non-existent plain and simple and thus feminine and dependent. It is of the Ill. Because its chaotic multiplicity once misled the pre-existing soul to let itself be dragged down into the marshy terrain of the *me on.* This fall from grace banished it into the prison of the body and split its unity into the rational, spirited, and appetitive soul. The first sits in the head, the second in the breast, and the third in the abdomen. The Platonic theory of society corresponds with this. The craftsmen are forged from the base appetitive soul, which has relinquished its freedom; the guardians keep their spirited soul in struggle; only the philosophers are predestined

[17] This has been most explicitly indicated by that philosophically apt critic of ontology, Nietzsche; and in fact his ontology-critique of the *primum absolutum* [first absolute] as pure identity, which is supposed to be truth—and that means freedom—that this has outgrown the compulsion imposed by nature on humans—that is to say, to give these and those different things the same name in order to orient itself ego-identically, to subsume the individual in the universal, to be able to survive. (Money has this function. Exchange value (nomen) results from a relation to nature, identification…)

to domination, and so they alone have the true Eros, the spiritual drive, at their command to anamnestically ascertain the Ideas. This anamnestic Eros sparks—like a spurred-on steed under the leadership of *nous*—*enthusiasmos*, the love of the Ideas.

Women, however, are soulless; they are just as bad [übel] as non-existent matter. It is a disgrace to love them. The act of sex is just a compulsion to procreate. True love is that of the same for the same, the homosexual love of pederasts, which, inspired by Eros, is animated in the sphere of pure identity. Through the unbridgeable *chorismos*—to which, following Nietzsche, a moralistic evaluation is attached—the pleasure principle and the act of procreation were torn apart from one another. This becomes the naked compulsion of reality, which therefore has no true being.

All dialectical thinkers of mediation have a sympathetic attitude towards heterosexuality. Aristotle, who posited *morphe* [form] as *eide* [Ideas, the word for 'forms' in the Platonic sense as well as Aristotelian 'species'] immanent to things, truly wanted to mediate between form and matter, because pure form is merely a derivative abstraction, *deutera ousia* [secondary substance]. Yet this mediation leads to pure identity because Aristotle—who was married four times—holds to domination over women and the related moral values.

The decisive reception of the Platonic *chorismos* takes place with the Pauline reinterpretation of the homosexual Jesus. The flesh is sinful matter which has fallen from God, who is pure identity in his trinity. The act of reproduction is a grim duty. All pleasure is sinful. Plato transferred the pleasure principle into the sphere of identity, of same-sex love, and so it was banished by Paul. Homosexuality is love of God, of Jesus—the Logos become flesh, [and] that means monastic life; pure pleasure is askesis. Through this sexuality directed and channeled into the abstract beyond, everything erotic in Europe becomes neurotic (inhibited homosexuality).

This manifests itself in pleasure-focused epochs. Whereas in Greek Classicism the female body was presented as slender and similar to youths and in Gothicism it was neurotically confined, in the Baroque it was presented in protruding fleshly splendor. Yet the pleasure that the Baroque took in the flesh was an illusion [Schein]. Because this world is *vanitas*, transience. The Baroque slogan of *carpe diem* is one of defiantly seeking pleasure in the consciousness of transience. All flesh is already ruin in comparison to the next world. Sexuality means, itself with the non-identical, letting in the morbid; the act of procreation becomes masochistic pleasure in death, Eros [becomes] allegory.

The Decadent Movement is similar. Baudelaire always felt the love he had for his mulatta woman as something dirtying. The intelligibility of man [Mannes] has passed away, whereupon it converts into sensibility. (The deca-

dent character is the sensible, allegorical manifestation [Erscheinungsform] of the intelligible character.) Only death, identity which has escaped from the life of nature, is pure. (Identity is henceforth death. Decadence knows this and is unable to extract itself from the love for the identical.)

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The Biological Individual

Julius Schaxel

Introduction[1]

Known as the "first Marxist among the biologists, first biologist among the Marxists,"[2] Julius Schaxel, the man who coined "dialectical biology," is a forgotten giant among the rich tradition of Marxist working-scientists. He belongs to the 'first generation' of dialectical biology, a research program that belongs to yet exceeds every Marxist tendency.[3] He is a challenging figure to parse; his difficulty stemming from three sources: his politics, his disciplinary scientific work, and the way he united them. Development, in every sense, defines Schaxel's project and trajectory. On one hand, his disciplinary and philosophy of science work anticipated the field of evolutionary-developmental biology (evo-devo) by almost 60 years.[4] On the other hand, by the end of a life shot through with technocratic tendencies, Schaxel was a doctrinaire Stalinist. This

[1] Introduction by Anatarah Bin AlKaf and translation by James Crane

[2] Stolz Rüdiger, "Geleitwort der Friedrich-Schiller-Universität", in Krauße Erika (ed.), *Julius Schaxel an Ernst Haeckel 1906–1917* (Leipzig, etc., 1987), 9, quoted in Nick Hopwood. "Biology between University and Proletariat: The Making of a Red Professor." *History of Science* 35, no. 4 (1997): 1. https://doi.org/10.1177/007327539703500401

[3] I complicate this "generation" cataloging from Peter J. Taylor, "Biology as Politics: The Direct and Indirect Effects of Lewontin and Levins," *Science as Culture* 19, no. 2 (2010): 241–53, https://doi.org/10.1080/09505431003660246. Taylor classifies the "visible college" of Marxist scientists in 1930s Britain—Bernal, Haldane, Needham, Blackett, and Levy, among others.—as the "first generation" of Marxist scientists. (These same figures participated in the "Theoretical Biology Club"; see Erik L. Peterson, *The Life Organic: The Theoretical Biology Club and the Roots of Epigenetics* (University of Pittsburgh Press, 2017).) The "second generation" of Marxist scientists, according to him, would be Lewontin, Levins, Gould, the Roses, and Commoner, among others. However, this schema overlooks an earlier first generation, which includes Boris Hessen, Julius Schaxel, Lev Vygotsky, Ivan Schmalhausen, Marcel Prenant and others. Making this genealogy explicit allows contemporary eco-Marxism to critically engage its own philosophical and scientific foundations and developments.

[4] Evolutionary-developmental biology (evo-devo), emerging in the 1980s, integrates development—how organismic form changes within an individual lifetime—with evolution, addressing a major lacuna in late 19th and early 20th century biological theory. See Manfred Dietrich Laubichler and Jane Maienschein, eds., *From Embryology to Evo-Devo: A History of Developmental Evolution*, Dibner Institute Studies in the History of Science and Technology (MIT Press, 2007). Evo-devo examines this relationship bi-perspectivally: how development constrains and enables evolution, and how evolution shapes development. This enriched biological theory by introducing *regulatory* concepts that bridge reductionist and holistic, functionalist and structural-

double status as political militant and scientist became the motif animating his turbulent life. He is worth remembering for various reasons, but especially for his attempts to resolve this ambivalence by waging his battle for 'socialist science' not within academic establishments, but among educators, teachers, and workers. It is in this practical dimension—the who and whom of scientific practice—that Schaxel's radicality emerges most clearly.

Born in Augsburg to a middle-class family on May 24, 1887 , Schaxel was enamored with nature from a young age, a love he later attributed to his parents.[5] During his schooling, he excelled academically, graduating top of his class while immersing himself in what he called the "classics of naturalism"[6]—from Oscar Hertwig and Charles Darwin to the *Friedrichshagen* poetry circle. Ambitious, rebellious, and promiscuous, he approached life as a problem of intervention, always thinking about how to act more effectively in his immediate environment.

Upon graduating from high school, Schaxel, dazzled by Ernst Haeckel's *Die Welträtsel* (*The Riddle of the Universe*), wrote to the German Darwinist. Impressed by him, Haeckel invited the young man to study zoology under him at the University of Jena.[7] Schaxel would become Haeckel's last student. By the time Schaxel matriculated in 1906, Haeckel, 72 years old, was more an ideological figure than the trailblazing scientist of his younger years. Nonetheless, Schaxel deemed his university experience "exceptional."[8] While Haeckel was less present as a research advisor, Schaxel would benefit from Haeckel's impressive network for the rest of his career. In this milieu, the experimental embryologist Julius Schaxel was formed.

The field Schaxel entered in 1906 faced the very lacuna he would later attempt to address: the problem of evolutionary development. Ernst Haeckel cast an enormous shadow over both academic zoology and popular culture. In his younger years, Haeckel's program of evolutionary morphology had been genuinely productive, introducing a battery of concepts that remain fundamental to evolutionary theory today: ecology, phylogeny, ontogeny, stem

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ist modes of explanation. See Rose Novick, "Structure and Function," *Elements in the Philosophy of Biology*, (Cambridge University Press, 2023), https://doi.org/10.1017/9781009028745.

[5] Christian Reiß, Susan Springer, Uwe Hoßfeld, Lennart Olsson, and Georgy S. Levit,. "Introduction to the Autobiography of Julius Schaxel," *Theory in Biosciences* 126, no. 4 (2007): 165–75. https://doi.org/10.1007/s12064-007-0015-7.

[6] Reiß et al., "Introduction," 167.

[7] It is worth noting that Ernst Haeckel's *Die Welträtsel* was one of the most successful works of science popularization in German history selling over 650,000 copies influencing what the country thought what Darwinism entailed. See Gabriel Finkelstein, "Haeckel and Du Bois-Reymond: Rival German Darwinists," in "Ernst Haeckel (1834-1919): The German Darwin and His Impact on Modern Biology," ed. Uwe Hoßfeld, Georgy S. Levit, and Ulrich Kutschera, special issue, *Theory in Biosciences* 138: 105–12, https://doi.org/10.1007/s12064-019-00282-6.

[8] Reiß et al., "Introduction," 168.

cells, and so on. But by the time Schaxel arrived in Jena, this research program had transmuted into polemical philosophy; a 'monist' nature-religion meant to overcome Christianity's "dualism" through mechanical materialism.[9] Darwinism, both from the left and the right, was synonymous with materialism.[10] Haeckel claimed the study of organic form (morphology) is "nothing other than the result of a balance of moving forces at a given moment. The science of forms or morphology of natural bodies is thus, in the broadest possible sense, the statics of matter"[11] This theoretical turn had methodological consequences. For morphology, taxonomy, and other allied subfields of biology, where Haeckel and the Jena school had the most influence, a descriptive and comparative method to natural phenomena dominated, primarily inherited from *Naturphilosophie*.[12]

Other subfields of biology— namely physiology, the medical fields and botany— were less influenced by these disciplinary developments, and allied themselves with more robust empirical experimental work, and a burgeoning new philosophy titled neo-Kantianism, which saw itself as a self-correcting tendency away from mechanical/scientific materialism.[13] This new scientific philosophy of neo-Kantianism did not have a particular "party-line" especially against Darwinism, but troubled everything from the status of a proper natural-historical explanation and the potential normative-content of natural selection to the role of consciousness in science and the problem of teleology.[14]

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[9] Nick Hopwood, "Biology between University and Proletariat: The Making of a Red Professor," *History of Science* 35, no. 4 (1997): 372–3, https://doi.org/10.1177/007327539703500401.

[10] It is worth distinguishing that the late 19th century and early 20th century Darwinism is different from what Darwin himself actually thought. See Gregory Priest, "Charles Darwin's Science of History" (Ph.D. thesis, Stanford University, 2025), https://purl.stanford.edu/dt096gc1088. Moreover, the dominant historiographical narrative of the "eclipse of Darwinism," mainly peddled by the neo-Darwanists, is fraught. See Jan Baedke et al., "A Synthesis Without Darwin: Unification Attempts in Early Theoretical Biology," in *Unity and Disunity in Evolutionary Biology*, ed. Richard G. Delisle et al. (Springer International Publishing, 2024), https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-42629-2_12.

[11] Ernst Haeckel, *Generelle Morphologie der Organismen*, vol. 1, *Allgemeine Anatomie der Organismen* (Berlin: Georg Reimer, 1866), 11, quoted in Karl Porges et al., "From Idea to Law: Theory, Concept and Terminological Formation in Ernst Haeckel's Works," *Russian Journal of Developmental Biology* 50, no. 6 (2019): 293, https://doi.org/10.1134/S1062360419060079.

[12] Uwe Hoßfeld and Lennart Olsson, "The Road from Haeckel: The Jena Tradition in Evolutionary Morphology and the Origins of 'Evo-Devo,'" *Biology and Philosophy* 18, no. 2 (2003): 285–307, https://doi.org/10.1023/A:1023988119440.

[13] Frederick C. Beiser, "Encounter with Darwinism," in *The Genesis of Neo-Kantianism, 1796–1880*, ed. Frederick C. Beiser (Oxford University Press, 2014), https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780198722205.003.0012.

[14] Evan Clarke, "Neo-Kantianism, Darwinism, and the Limits of Historical Explanation," *British Journal for the History of Philosophy*, April 30, 2021, https://doi.org/10.1080/09608788.2021.1912707.

This philosophical crisis was inseparable from its institutional context. Key to understanding this scientific culture is grasping the social geography of German research institutions. The German university remained the privileged site where scientific knowledge was certified and careers made, yet it was increasingly stagnant.[15] Serious science has been increasingly done outside of the academy. For example, chemists thrived much more around industrial laboratories, technical colleges were abundant, and new types of institutions, such as the Kaiser Wilhelm Institutes, were burgeoning.[16] In other words, Science depended on networks of formal and informal venues beyond university walls. Within this geography, university scientists, the "mandarins," enjoyed the most prestige, and as a result, they were the most reactionary.

It was into this fractured landscape that Schaxel entered. Like many of Haeckel's students, he quickly drifted away from his advisor to be better acquainted with "modern biology."[17] To this end, using Haeckel's impressive network, Schaxel earned his doctorate, roughly in 1909, under Richard Hertwig lab in Munich supervised by Richard Goldschmidt and interacting with young biologists such as Franz Doflein.[18] He conducted a morphological analysis of oogenesis, thus uniting both his old mentor's commitment to natural-historical morphology (what was called "ontogeny") and the new experimental biology he is becoming adept at. Indeed this problematic of evolutionary development (what Haeckel dubbed "phylogeny") will be the motivating engine for the rest of Schaxel's career as he performed more research on various animal embryos. This immediately put him in the field of *Entwicklungsmechanik* ("developmental mechanics").[19]

Schaxel began cementing himself increasingly in embryology and became reputable in the field. In 1916, he secured an "außerordentliche" professorship of zoology at the University of Jena. And in 1918, he founded the small "Institute of Experimental Biology," where he conducted axolotl research, especially on its developmental and regenerative capabilities. It was at this point during the turbulence of WW1 where Schaxel switched more thoroughly from doing

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15 Hopwood, "Biology between University and Proletariat," 380–7.

16 Hopwood, "Biology between University and Proletariat," 369–71.

17 Reiß et al. "Introduction," 167.

18 Reiß et al. "Introduction," 170–1; Christian Reiß, "No Evolution, No Heredity, Just Development—Julius Schaxel and the End of the Evo–Devo Agenda in Jena, 1906–1933: A Case Study," *Theory in Biosciences* 126, no. 4 (2007): 155–64, `https://doi.org/10.1007/s12064-007-0016-6`.

19 Schaxel's self-described politicization (1906–1909) came through his landlord, communist Emil Höllein (later parliamentary representative), and Russian émigrés in Jena fleeing the 1905 revolution. Schaxel credited Höllein with leading him "away from Haeckel's scientific materialism to Marxism," noting he "had a greater influence on me than any professor." The émigrés introduced him to Kautsky's *Neue Zeit*, leading to his reading of Marx and Engels and joining the SPD in a few years. See Reiß et al. "Introduction," 169.

empirical work to more theoretical and conceptual work. One of his most cited and major works of this period was *Grundzüge der Theoriebildung in der Biologie* ("Foundations of Theory Construction in Biology"), in which Schaxel gave a synoptic and critical overview of the "crisis" state of biological theory. He argued that biology suffered from a profusion of incommensurable theories—Darwinism and phylogeny, *Entwicklungsmechanik*, physiology, and neo-vitalism—each generating a multitude of facts and descriptions, but lacked coherent unifying conceptions to guide empirical research.[20] His method was two-pronged, both philosophical and historical, tracing the tradition of various research programs and the development of their theoretical content through immanent critique. What was needed, he advocated, was a "theoretical biology" (which he had earlier called "Kritische Biologie") that would disentangle, disambiguate, and unify these disparate frameworks.[21]

Schaxel's approach sought a middle ground between competing extremes. On the embryological front, for instance, he positioned himself between Wilhelm Roux's mechanism (*Entwicklungsmechanik*) and Hans Driesch's neo-vitalism. Roux's reductionism offered impressive experimental work but lacked a consistent, philosophically informed biological theory; Driesch provided a stronger philosophical framework, but his deductions—entelechy as an immaterial force—were not sufficiently grounded in empirical work. Theoretical biology, Schaxel argued, was needed precisely in this middle ground, and the task required biologists and philosophers of biology alike. To institutionalize this vision, Schaxel launched the book series *Abhandlungen zur theoretischen Biologie* (Treatise on Theoretical Biology), published from 1919 to 1931, with contributions from Ludwig von Bertalanffy, Paul Weiss, Emil Ungerer, Friedrich Alverdes, and many other young biologists.[22]

By 1923, Schaxel was known as a successful young biologist, but that would change in the next two years. While he was politically active in the German Social Democratic Party (SPD) since 1918, he would take politics much more seriously during this period, becoming professionally involved. After a surprising victory of the left-wing parties in Thuringia, Schaxel was appointed as an employee responsible for educational reform at the universities. The

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[20] Hopwood, "Biology between University and Proletariat," 375–80; Reiß, "No Evolution, No Heredity," 158–61; Baedke et al., "A Synthesis Without Darwin," 345–8.

[21] Reiß, "No Evolution, No Heredity," 159; Baedke et al., "A Synthesis Without Darwin," 344.

[22] Baedke et al., "A Synthesis Without Darwin," 344. Regarding other programs of "theoretical biology" such as Jakob von Uexküll, Schaxel differentiated himself from them by his insistence on philosophically-informed empirical work. It is not that much of a stretch to slot Schaxel with what philosopher of biology Denis Walsh dubbed"methodological vitalism." See Denis M. Walsh, "Objectcy and Agency: Towards a Methodological Vitalism," in *Everything Flows: Towards a Processual Philosophy of Biology*, ed. Daniel J. Nicholson and John Dupré (Oxford University Press, 2018), https://doi.org/10.1093/oso/9780198779636.003.0008.

Mandarins were under threat, and naturally the socialist experiment was crushed by the Berlin military. Schaxel was branded a "red" professor, and instead of running away, he doubled down. Science needed to be saved.

Amidst this maelstrom, between 1924 and 1926, Schaxel headed the science communication magazine, *Urania*. As a socialist cultural product, *Urania* represented a critical development for his ongoing fight for scientific culture. It was here where left-wing scientists, teachers, statisticians, physicians, and worker-functionaries aimed to mediate between science as a culture product and the labor movement.[23] The stakes of this project become clear when one considers the status of science for the German working class at the time. Science was viewed with justified suspicion: the memory and misery of WWI was fresh, "progress" had stalled, and eugenics was on the rise. Yet Urania's record was not without contradiction; the magazine itself contributed to this situation, promoting versions of scientism ranging from "people's eugenics" to outright machismo.[24]

Urania's project was twofold: to critique "bourgeois science" and to establish a new scientific culture that could overcome the working class's justified suspicion of it. Schaxel's own biography became central to this project. He presented himself as a model of the dissident scientist whose expulsion from bourgeois institutions confirmed rather than undermined his credibility. While some in the social-democratic (SPD) and communist (KPD) milieus welcomed a scientific "authority" in their midst, the majority remained skeptical of bourgeois scientists. Science and the figure of the scientist were not givens.

Schaxel deployed the familiar Kautskyite argument: while science is class-determined, not all of it would be discarded by the ascending working class, for the full heritage of science still contained the building-stones from which a future proletarian society could be erected. Excluded from the reactionary educational system, Schaxel himself had been expelled from professional zoology by the racial hygienist Ludwig Plate, which only bolstered his political credibility among workers, he recast dissident university professors, schoolteachers, and their ilk as heroes. These socialist class traitors would serve the working class as "more experienced personnel" charged with "filtering and sifting" the heritage of science to produce "fighting knowledge."[25] *Urania* would be

[23] Notable contributors include the sinologist K. A. Wittfogel, mathematician Emil J. Gumbel, and philosopher Theodor Hartwig, among others.

[24] Hopwood, "Producing a Socialist Popular Science," 117–20. It is also worth mentioning that in the wider network of the Urania Free Educational Institute—at least compared to other socialist circles at the time—there was a sizable female demographic. Here Anna Siemsen is the most notable example. However, with figures such as the sex reformer Max Hodann and some of the target demographics of Urania, it is clear that patriarchal relations were not as thematized and incorporated into the larger mission of the magazine.

[25] Hopwood, "Producing a Socialist Popular Science," 130.

the nexus where this fight for scientific culture was conducted. Science had become a front in the class struggle.[26]

To grasp the full scope of *Urania* magazine, it helps to contrast it with its bourgeois rival, *Kosmos*—Germany's most popular science magazine at the time.[27] *Kosmos* was a monthly publication principally concerned with promoting science in a rigorous yet accessible way, but it maintained a studied separation between science and politics. *Urania* used *Kosmos* as its template and acted as its deliberate politicized counterpoint. Both were considered high-quality publications, but their differences were instructive. Where *Kosmos* presented science as politically neutral, *Urania* sought to communicate it with its political and philosophical dimensions intact, primarily from a Marxist standpoint. In format, too, the magazines diverged: *Urania* favored a modern, slick roman typography that embraced a varied functionalism and included a generous number of photographs, making it far more visually accessible than *Kosmos*, which retained a more traditional gothic print. Even their distribution models reflected different orientations: *Kosmos* followed the standard subscription model, while *Urania* relied on a complex network of word-of-mouth, local party advertisers, and internal promotion.[28]

Within *Urania's* pages, advertisements for other *Urania* activities abounded. The magazine was only one component of a broader program of proletarian science: educational seminars, Marxist sociology classes, "social hiking," lifestyle reform featuring vegetarianism and "natural healing," and more. *Urania's* fate was bound to the collapse of Weimar's left-wing institutions. *Urania* with its whole host of activities continued until 1933 but was abruptly ended when the Nazi forces liquidated the entire operation. Julius Schaxel fled to the Soviet Union that same year. He died there under unknown circumstances in 1943.

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This journal presents a translation of an article from Schaxel's late period: "Das biologische Individuum" (The Biological Individual), published in 1931. This late period is characterized by two developments: first, a deeper engagement with Marx and Engels, both philosophically and politically, than his work of the 1920s demonstrated; and second, a return to the teachings of his original mentor, Ernst Haeckel—but now on dialectical materialist terms

[26] It is worth stressing that readers that sense a petit bourgeois element here are not wrong. This project is closer to a "reform" of scientific relations of productions than a more revolutionary demand of overhauling it all together. There is a real continuity between Schaxel's university reform proposal and his Urania work, despite ostentatious radical rhetoric.

[27] Hopwood, "Producing a Socialist Popular Science," 121.

[28] Hopwood, "Producing a Socialist Popular Science," 125–7.

rather than Haeckel's monist ones. Specifically, Schaxel articulates a left-wing naturalism that avoids three pitfalls: metaphysical speculation, neo-vitalistic or scholastic conceptions of the organism, and empiricist-mechanistic biology. To accomplish this, he introduces "dialectical biology" as his remedy. As Schaxel writes, dialectical biology "strips away all rigidified concepts, above all the concept at the center of any metaphysical biology—that of individuality." It does so by refusing idealistic absolutes and returning them to the natural-historical development of society, underlining their "general relativity" in the course of both life and earth history. It is important to note, for him, this is not merely a scientific claim but a political one: Schaxel links biological dichotomies (individual/collective, organism/environment) to the polarity of labor and capital, making him among the first biologists to theorize this homology explicitly.

Using his legitimacy as a "red" professor, he aimed to overthrow the dominant conception of the organism-environment relationship while tracing its source, bourgeois social relations.[29] In the text, Schaxel demonstrates the "general relativity" of biological individuals—what Haeckel termed "bionts"—against the absolute individual found in romantic conceptions of biology. Drawing on his own experimental work, he aimed to show the porosity of the organism-environment relationship; what he called the "dissolution of form." In a series of parabiosis experiments, he linked the vessels and tissues of two axolotls in early development, creating a cardiovascular system with one heart connecting two morphological individuals. This experimental unit survived for seven years, far longer than Schaxel anticipated. From this result, he concluded that morphological boundaries convey no information for identifying biological individuals or the boundaries between them. The individual, he argued, dissolves both inward into metabolic and cellular processes and outward into larger environments—into what he called the living communities (*Lebensgemeinschaften*) characterized by rich reciprocal relationships. Where liberal biology naturalized competitive individualism, Schaxel's dialectical biology revealed individuality itself as a product of historical processes: both natural-historical (evolution, development) and social-historical (the organization of labor under specific modes of production). The "division of labor" in biological communities was not a neutral descriptive term borrowed from economics but a site where natural and social history interpen-

[29] The *Institut für Sozialforschung* (IfS), with whom Schaxel collaborated also looked for a "middle-way" between vitalism and mechanism; see for example Reiß, "No Evolution, No Heredity," 157. However, due to the Nazi institutional context, this biophilosophy, a part of the materialist dialectic, remained patchy and programmatic. See Kevin S. Amidon, " 'Diesmal Fehlt Die Biologie!' Max Horkheimer, Richard Thurnwald, and the Biological Prehistory of German Sozialforschung," *New German Critique*, no. 104 (2008): 103–37.

etrated. The biological individual, for Schaxel, is neither a fixed essence nor an autonomous unit, but a relative, historically constituted process embedded in larger dynamics.

This intervention must be understood against the background of intense debate over biological individuality in early twentieth-century biology. What constitutes the "unit" of evolutionary mechanisms: the gene, the cell, the organism, or the community? These questions haunted researchers grappling with new embryological discoveries and extensive ecological field studies, with the organism-environment relationship at the center of concern. Schaxel's position emerged from his controversy with Hans Spemann, the most successful experimental embryologist of his generation. Spemann had adopted Driesch's concept of the "harmonious-equipotential system," arguing it could be retained without neo-vitalist conclusions by understanding it as an organic whole that could be "regulated" back to harmony. Schaxel rejected this move as too theory-laden, fearing it introduced teleological conceptions of organismic development.[30] As historian Nick Hopwood has traced, this trepidation led Schaxel to brusquely deny "regulation of development" altogether; a position that now appears scientifically mistaken.[31]

With hindsight, Spemann held the more contemporary and scientifically correct view on evolutionary developmental biology. Yet Schaxel possessed the more robust philosophical instincts, insofar as the justification of theory also constitutes a kind of progress. What we have in "The Biological Individual" is one of the strongest, if most brusque, statements of left-wing naturalism and theoretical biology from the period.[32] Historian of biology Jan Baedke has situated this article within the international intellectual movement of organism-centered biology (OCB), with Schaxel representing its dialectical materialist branch.[33] The individuality article operates on two registers

[30] The teleology of organisms still rages on as an area of hot debate in both the biological sciences and the philosophy of biology. A problem we directly inherit from Kant's mechanism–teleology antimony with immense ramification on issues, such as the agency of organisms, the nature of organismic function, the emergence of evolutionary novelty, and so on. For a dialectical answer to these issues, see Andrea Gambarotto, "Teleology and Mechanism: A Dialectical Approach," *Synthese* 201, no. 5 (2023): 155, `https://doi.org/10.1007/s11229-023-04137-y`.

[31] Hopwood, "Biology between University and Proletariat," 374.

[32] I alternate between naturalism and theoretical biology, despite the latter now referring to a mathematical biology, because traditional theoretical biology had to justify itself both philosophically and empirically. This places theoretical biology closer to my preferred understanding of naturalism, one whose horizon is natural history acting as a critical concept that negates the occult, magic, and the supernatural in order to return us to understanding nature as *dynamic* second nature, namely, society.

[33] Jan Baedke, "O Organism, Where Art Thou? Old and New Challenges for Organism-Centered Biology," *Journal of the History of Biology* 52, no. 2 (2019): 293–324, `https://doi.org/10.1007/s10739-018-9549-4`. The three theoretical strands of the OCB are organicism,

simultaneously: as political propaganda for socialist science and as scientific exposition for the working class. This double character reflects Schaxel's conviction that the question of biological individuality is inseparable from broader questions of method, philosophy, and politics.

Similarly, Schaxel's understanding of ontogeny and phylogeny, while trailblazing at the time, is quite outdated by today's standards. His view of evolutionary history, despite its impressive integration without subordination of one domain to another, remained too Haeckelian. Phylogenetic relationships have proven far more complicated than the regular "tree of life" structure Schaxel assumed, particularly with discoveries like horizontal gene transfer. Moreover, both blood-relations and sexual-relations exhibit far greater environmental variability than Schaxel acknowledged. Nature proves too promiscuous to exclude the social mediation of how we understand natural history.[34]

Why return to Schaxel today? Contemporary biology possesses theoretical sophistication Schaxel could scarcely have imagined. Sophisticated enough, indeed, that his absence from the field seems almost justified. We have molecular genetics, systems biology, epigenetics, evo-devo frameworks that have incorporated much of what he struggled toward. Yet this very sophistication obscures what Schaxel understood: that dialectical materialism is a philosophy of nature insofar as it focuses on the lived, day-to-day pragmatics of philosophy of science, which in the last analysis is political philosophy. The dialectician reaps "a rich harvest" when this fact is ignored, and it is systematically ignored in contemporary scientific culture.

Consider the political work performed by seemingly neutral biological categories today. Microbiome research, for instance, operates with ever-greater technical precision while unwittingly reifying race as a biological category; the morphological boundaries Schaxel dissolved through parabiosis return as genomic sequence mapped onto the social field.[35] Climate science generates increasingly accurate models while remaining largely divorced from the political economy driving climate change, treating atmospheric CO_2 as a technical problem rather than a symptom of capital accumulation. These are not incidental failures but structural ones, rooted in the same severing of scientific practice from political consciousness that Schaxel fought against.

German holistic biology ("Ganzheitsbiologie"), and dialectical materialism. While the three theoretical strands have their commonalities, it is only the last tradition that was explicitly political in its philosophy of science and nature.

[34] For a classic study of this mediation, see Donna J. Haraway, *Primate Visions: Gender, Race, and Nature in the World of Modern Science* (Routledge, 2013), `https://doi.org/10.4324/9780203421918`.

[35] Abigail Nieves Delgado and Jan Baedke, "How to Eliminate Race from Human Microbiome Research," *Argumenta* 10, no. 2 (2025): 497–510.

The battle for scientific culture that animated Schaxel's proletarian science seminars appears, from our vantage, a lost fight. This absence is not accidental but the result of systematic depoliticization, Cold War purges, developments in the political economy of science, deskilling in education, and so on. The few scientists today who maintain dialectical commitments often do so privately, their Marxism cordoned off from their research as if the two inhabited separate worlds.

Recovering Schaxel means recovering the possibility that scientific practice can be a site of political struggle. Not applied politics, not science communication, but the research itself as intervention. This is not nostalgia for the Weimar Republic's proletarian science seminars but recognition that the questions Schaxel posed remain unanswered: what is the biological individual in an age of microbiomes and holobionts? How do we understand organism-environment relations when the environment is being destroyed by capital? Who does science and for whom? These are not questions that more data will answer; they require the philosophical and political work Schaxel modeled. In this sense, he didn't miss his chance to show up—we're still living in the crisis he tried to address, only now with less awareness that it is a crisis at all. That is precisely why his voice, awkward and brusque as it can be, needs to be heard again. The harvest awaits those willing to reap it.

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Because Schaxel's synthetic project is difficult, his language is difficult too. We have translated Schaxel's text and found that he uses multiple synonyms for certain key concepts in developmental biology, especially for the concepts of *process*, *form/ation*, and *whole/ness* or *structure*. Sometimes, Schaxel seems to use different words interchangeably for these concepts. In some passages, however, a slight difference in connotation or denotation between two different words for *form/ation*, for instance, will become significant for Schaxel's argument. Often, the difference in meaning between two terms for a given concept—such as the difference between *Ganzheit*, translated below as "wholeness," and *Gesamtheit*, translated below as "totality"—relates to a difference, whether real or potential, in (1) levels of scientific explanation, (2) theoretical vocabulary (e.g., Schaxel occasionally uses the language of Gestalt-psychology, an influential idiom for the description of "holistic" phenomena across numerous scientific disciplines in Weimar-era Germany), or (3) scale of the phenomena in question (as in the difference between *Vorgänge*, more discrete processes or sub-processes, and *Prozessen*, understood as more comprehensive.) We have attempted to standardize our translation of quasi-synonymous terms and mark out potentially significant differences in Schaxel's language by including the German term in brackets. Ultimately, we believe that Schaxel's conceptual

presentation on its own terms is often significant for distinguishing between the various possible meanings in the variety of terms he uses for "process," "form," and "whole/ness" or "structure." The linguistic slippage in Schaxel's writing was, in part, intentional and even unavoidable: Schaxel was attempting to develop a unified theoretical vocabulary for developmental biology, bridging multiple extant and nascent paradigms, that did not preexist his interventions. Therefore, some of the differences between respective "processes" of development suggested by Schaxel's language would, eventually, become more distinct with advances in theoretical and experimental biology, particularly in the consolidation of more comprehensive and synthetic paradigms like "evo-devo." Finally, we endeavored to highlight these idiosyncratic usages of biological terms by Schaxel by writing them as translator's notes peppered throughout the essay. We hope the readers can appreciate the systematicity and inventiveness of Schaxel's description of organic development and the generalized relativity of the ontogenetic processes.

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The Biological Individual (1930)[36]

Introduction

Rather than attempting to trace the concept of the individual through the history of philosophy, or even to investigate the vacillating representations of the individual that have recently circulated in biological theory, in what follows, my aim is solely to anticipate a portion of the empirical material from a forthcoming, comprehensive presentation in which modern natural science will be illuminated from the standpoint of dialectical materialism. In light of this, and because this method will assert itself under pressure of fact with greater force than has heretofore been recognized or even admitted, even outside the broad social strata through whose movement the method enters into consciousness, some indication in this direction can be given through two formulations by the initiators, Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels. In a letter of May 30th, 1873, Engels wrote to Marx:

> The subject-matter of natural science—matter in motion, bodies. Bodies cannot be separated from motion, their forms and kinds can only be known in motion; one cannot say anything about bodies without motion, without relation to other bodies. Only in motion does a body reveal what it is. Natural science therefore knows bodies by examining them in their relation to one another, and in motion. To understand the different forms of motion is equivalent to understanding bodies. The investigation of these different forms of motion is therefore the chief subject of natural science.[37]

What is significant for us is the fact that the chemist Carl Schorlemmer, upon reading this epistolary sketch, left the marginal note: "Very good, my own view precisely!" Sometime later, Engels notes:

> Dialectics, so-called objective dialectics, prevails throughout nature, and so-called subjective dialectics, dialectical thought, is only the reflection of the motion through opposites which asserts itself everywhere in nature, and which by the continual conflict of the opposites and their final passage into one another, or into higher forms, determines the life of nature.[38]

In short, what follows comes down to the consideration of biological facts in a rather general context and deriving various lawful regularities from them.

For several years now, I have repeatedly addressed such matters in prole-

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[36] Julius Schaxel, "Das biologische Individuum." *Erkenntnis (1930-1938)*, 1930/1931, Vol. 1 (1930/1931), 467–492.

[37] Friedrich Engels to Karl Marx, May 30, 1873, in Karl Marx and Frederick Engels, *Selected Correspondence*, trans. I. Lasker, ed. S. Ryazanskaya (Moscow: Progress Publishers, 1975), 281, `https://archive.org/details/selectedcorrespondencemarxengels`.

[38] Friedrich Engels, *Dialectics of Nature*. Translated by Clemens Dutt. *Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels. Collected Works, Volume 25* (Lawrence & Wishart [E-Book], 2010), 492.

tarian training courses and academic lectures alike. Recently, I have also had occasion to deliver a presentation on the object of this essay in connection with the demonstrations at the Berlin branch of the *Internationalen Gesellschaft für empirische Philosophie* on February 25th, 1930.

Before science ever deals with the concept of the individual, the society that produces this science is already familiar with the notion. It is one of those representations that characterizes relationships among members of such a society. The community emphasizes the individual individually. It is precisely those distinct, "exceptional," "historical" individuals who need the foundation of the mass that carries them, and of which they are supposed to be the exponent. That is, empirically, individuality—in its spatial, temporal, and causal self-sufficiency—always remains relative. The absolute individual—the indivisible, the isolated, the *ἄτομον* (atom)—is a concoction of metaphysical speculation.

Individual self-reflection, "inner sense," "I-feeling," intuition, and introspection—all of these employ the full range of means of social understanding. Not only is the "You" older than the "I," but both presuppose the community of the "It." Individuation is, among other things, the index of a determinate stage of socio-historical development, one accompanied by linguistic expression, form in thought, and ultimately the concept.

Individuality proper, which is supposed to—and seeks to—signify 'personality,' arrives on the scene even later. [Individuality] is connected with the desire for universal freedom among all those who are super- and sub-ordinate to one another in society, a demand for a state of affairs in which each is their own master, a part of the declaration of human rights in the bourgeois-liberal era. The problem of individuality is therefore by right a problem of the bourgeois society of the present—as it appears problematic to itself. Thus, the problem is ever "posed" and never "solved." The elevation of individuality into totality, of its individual character into wholeness [*Ganzheit*], simultaneously displaces the individual, which therefore remains a riddle, into the imaginary realm of the in-itself. A social strata, forced into the defensive, erects an ideological dictatorship that aims to prohibit empirical access to offensive *empirie*. The validity of any such prohibition is a question of power.

1. The General Relativity of Bionts[39]

The empirical biologist who collects experience of the living through observation and experiment never encounters anything like a closed, rigid, categorical 'individuality.' The facts of living nature show themselves otherwise.

The living can only be cognized in their general contexts and connections, reciprocal relations of dependency, in their development and their movement. The living phenomenon, in its substance and its form, only ever presents itself to the observer in process and sequence, never as standing still, for-itself, isolated, abstract. There is no "life-in-itself." Although determinate living beings always concretely exemplify "life," they do not do so in an isolated or self-contained way, but as forms in motion, through their behaviors, in their relationships, and in the manifold connections between these movements.

Living beings are phenomena in a state of perpetual reorganization, subject to metabolism, ending in their death. Life continuously changes its material composition through the same metabolic process that constitutes the course of life itself. In close relationship to metabolism, the form of living beings is not a permanently ordered manifold, but in constant transformation in the formative sequences of development. This occurs in processes which operate at different speeds, and which are distinguishable from one another according to the kind of events which fulfill them.

The closer we occupy ourselves with the contents of the biosphere—which is integrated to a circumscribed extent with the hydrosphere, atmosphere, and geosphere of the planet—with the living beings that inhabit the earth's crust—the clearer their interconnection with the totality [*Gesamtheit*] becomes.

Not all living beings are the same. Nor do they all undergo the same transformations, such that what we find would simply be various stages of life existing at the same time. And yet, we cannot say that beings are completely different from one another either. What is true of the leaves of a tree—of which, it is said, no two are exactly alike, but which are nevertheless identifiable as leaves of the same kind—applies on a larger scale for the living world as a totality. There is neither complete likeness, distinctness, nor isolatedness among living beings, but rather a graduated manifold that manifests itself

[39] [Translator's note:] Haeckel coins the term 'biont' to designate the 'onta' of 'ontogenesis.' Though he used 'biont' interchangeably with 'concrete' or 'physiological individual,' Haeckel relativized the concept of the individual in his work into six levels of individuality, from the single cell (whether unicellular individual or nested within a multicellular organism) up to colonial organisms, in light of then recent developments in biological theories of individuation as a process unfolding simultaneously across different scales and at different rates. For Haeckel's development of the term 'biont,' see: "From Idea to Law: Theory, Concept, and Terminology in Ernst Haeckel's Works," by Karl Porges, Ian G. Stewart, Uwe Hoßfeld, and Georgy S. Levit. *Russian Journal of Developmental Biology*, 2019, Vol. 50, No. 6 (2019), 290-302.

as historical kinship. All that is living is connected through two kinds of kinship: the blood-relationship of descent from ancestors to descendants, and the sex-relationship of pairs who sexually reproduce offspring.

Aristotle first conceived life in the concept of the organism in a natural manner, having considered all living beings his equals, and himself in natural connection with them. It was only the thousand-year interpretation of the Christian Middle Ages that refashioned 'the organism' into a scholastic concept, one whose essential being was neither of this world nor, therefore, knowable in such context: the organism as an instrument of the "soul," which intervenes in physical events from the transcendent beyond of the realm of metaphysics. To this day, idealistic philosophers still discuss "ideas," entelechies, and psychoids, and, so long as any of them remain, will continue to do so indefinitely.

When the geocentric and heliocentric standpoints of the natural sciences had long been overcome, in the midst of the powerful development of mechanics in the modern natural sciences, natural researchers nevertheless continued to run up against the wall of the scholastic-metaphysical category of the organism for nearly four centuries. No qualitatively new formation [*Neubildung*] in time, and so no organic history, was considered to be possible. As Linnaeus formulated the dogma: *tot sunt species quot in principio creatae,* inflicting the violence of preformationist evolution on the history of life.

Only in 1859 did Charles Darwin demonstrate, under the most exacting demand of burden of proof, that the present stock of organic products of nature, humans included, is itself the product of a long process of development that began from a few primordial germs. For the first time in the history of life upon the earth, the natural connection of all living things, and with non-living nature, was recognized.

During his search for an explanation for the fact that plants and animals populate the earth in such a multiform and graduated manifold, Darwin decomposed the organism as the totality of characteristics used as markers of identification for the purposes of classification. Once the organism was decomposed into the aggregate of properties that came about and came together in the course of time as the result of individual effects, the individual in the true sense of the word has ceased to exist. August Weismann arrives at an explicit dissolution of the individual with his view that the givenness of the organism is, in the last instance, the result of the determination-complex of its germ-plasm: in [this complex], independent series of events, without any causal connection to one another, are accumulated and, if they prove themselves, preserved. [These determinations] are contingent in origin; in their present operation, however, they belong together—brought together by the history of life.

As Ernst Haeckel sought to furnish Darwinian Transformism with a genuine theoretical foundation, beyond mere empiricism, for the first time, he devoted several chapters of his "General Morphology" to the topic of organic individuality, concluding therein that the concept of the individual "has no absolute, but only relative, meaning."[40] In summarizing the introduction to his distinctions, Haeckel states: "The oft-asked question of the absolute individuality of organisms is to be answered as follows: it does not exist…"[41] In the course of his presentation, Haeckel finds himself compelled to introduce a new concept in order to do justice to the mobility of life-processes: "The physiological individual (*Bion*) is a single, organic unit of space, which, as a centralized living unity, possesses the capacity for self-preservation and is, at the same time, divisible, and which, moreover, due to the movements associated with these functions, can only be recognized as variable across different moments in time."[42]

In the proceeding, we will continue to refer to "bionts" in order to avoid the contradiction of the "divisible individual." After Darwin and Haeckel, the metaphysical individual and the scholastic organism have been banished from natural science; these ideologies divorced from actuality have dissipated like so many wisps of fog, opening up a view of the spatio-temporal process of life directly accessible to empirical praxis.

"Bionts" are processes of living connections, appearing solely in their movements and relationships, never as self-enclosed categories. Their having-become [*Gewordensein*] can be historically explained. In so doing, it is necessary not just to demonstrate the broad historical trends of their development, but also to demonstrate the descent and modes of action [of bionts] in detail. Bionts become objects of experimentation. [In the experimental process,] they repeatedly point beyond immediate conditions to connections operative on a variety of levels. Here, the points of transition between biology and sociology are of particular interest to us.

2. The Special Relativity of Bionts

Human thinking has never truly left nature behind, except in its imagination. Every such retreat from actuality has resulted in the erection of various kinds of barriers to human knowledge. The concept of the categorical individual, so inhibiting to biological insight, stems from the social being of a certain epoch.

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[40] Ernst Haeckel, *Prinzipien der generellen Morphologie der Organismen. Wörtlicher Abdruck eines Teiles der 1866 erschienen Generellen Morphologie (allgemeine Grundzüge der organischen Formen-Wissenschaft, mechanisch begründet durch die von Charles Darwin reformierte Deszendenz-Theorie)* (Berlin: Druck Und Verlag Von Georg Reimer, 1906), 103.

[41] Haeckel, *Generellen Morphologie* 108.

[42] Haeckel, *Generellen Morphologie*, 135.

As the epoch comes to an end, facts begin to break through the artificial barrier. The general relativity of bionts is now widely acknowledged. Across individual fields of research, the confirmation [of this general relativity] is on the rise. Without claiming to be exhaustive, in what follows we present a few examples whose individual significance lies in the fact that, in their interconnection and in their connections to others still, they attest to the general dissolution of individuality.

a) The Historical Dissolution

Life on Earth presupposes conditions which only arose in the course of the Earth's history. Life therefore began in geological time. Through abiogenesis, the tree of life is rooted in non-living nature. Over many millennia, countless living organisms have evolved from one another. The historical connection between interrelated groups is expressed in the graduated diversity of phenomena. It is reasonable to assume that the similarity of forms in a given group can be explained by descent from a common ancestral form [*gemeinsamen Urform*]. This approach is further strengthened in the event that the derivation obtained through the comparison of forms is corroborated by remnants of the history of forms, or in the event that the transitional form between one group and another is documented.

Already in 1863, Ernst Haeckel[43] concluded from the foundations laid by Darwin: "None of the various animals and plants alive today, nor indeed all of those organisms that have ever lived, … were created independently, whether in-themselves or as a species, but in fact, despite their extraordinary diversity and variety, have gradually, over the course of millennia, evolved from a few, or perhaps even one single ancestral form." The diligent phylogenetic research in the four decades leading up to the turn of the century has generated a wealth of evidence that no individual being, plant or animal, can be considered "individually" in-itself or as a species. Phylogenetic explanation has become a matter of course. The work of recent decades presupposed transformism; it endeavored to penetrate into sub-processes, trace the operations of effective forces, and, admittedly somewhat late and without general success, conduct a careful review of its own concepts. The organism as historical formation, which points beyond itself towards its coming-to-be, is presupposition of the research initiated by Darwinism. Without the process of phylogeny, there would be no genetics, no developmental physiology, no ecology.

Individual beings are no longer regarded in imagined isolation. There was nothing that could be said about the absolute individual or the constant

[43] Ernst Haeckel, "Über die Entwicklungstheorie Darwins," in *Gemeinverständliche Vorträge und Abhandlungen aus dem Gebiete der Entwickelungslehre* (Bonn: Emil Straus, 1902)

species except that all things of that nature exist without context, in complete disconnection. Only the knowledge of their having-become makes arriving at an understanding of their coming-to-be and passing-away, the process of nature, possible.

Organisms are products of historical accumulation. They change through independent increases or decreases of diversity. They are constructed through the assimilation of new parts or dismantled by the removal of others. This succession of events accumulates into something that endures. We speak of 'accumulation' in order to express the fact that the result in each case is not completely determined by real-time spatial boundaries, because the change in diversity is brought about through addition or subtraction in time. The individual events in this sequence, in their causal connection, constitute sums or aggregates. The establishment of historical accumulation not only abolishes the abstract conception of the individual and the species, but at the same time excludes any kind of teleological evolution whatsoever.

The historical dissolution of individuality places life-processes within the nexus of natural process. Now, it is necessary to determine the bonds of this interconnection, of organic formation, behavior, and its constitutive relationships. This endeavor has been most successful in terms of the bonds between ancestors and descendants—namely, in terms of heredity.

b) The Genetic Dissolution

Science has only begun to move on from the more-or-less anecdotal presentation of heredity-relations since 1900, when, building off of the rediscovery of Gregor Mendel's findings in hybridization, scientists began conducting their own investigations in the analysis of cross-breeding.

Artificial selection and cross-breeding deal only with the facts of direct kinship, both the blood-relationship of descent and the sex-relationship of fertile couplings.

Thirty years of research have generated a series of important findings in three stages.

First, artificial hybridization of observable traits reveals the regularities with which the traits under observation arise in the succession of generations. Then, the collected statistical data is recorded under formulas of heritability and, at the same time, the "laws of inheritance" are derived from statistical clusters. Thereby, what endures in the flux of phenomena is separated out from what is randomly conditioned, the effect of inheritance from the effect of external conditions under which the process occurs, from the life-situation—in other words, that is, thereby the genotype is separated from the phenotype.

Second, in the treatment of the genotype, fictions about hereditary factors,

or 'genes,' are introduced. The similarity of genealogically related persons, among whom the compared traits coincide in qualitative and quantitative terms, as well as in the spatial and temporal order of their occurrence, is accordingly explained by inheritance when evidence of the same genes in ancestors, descendants, or siblings is taken to be sufficiently well-established. For our purposes, what is significant is the renewed disintegration of the organism into an aggregate—previously of traits or properties, now of genes—already mentioned in the historical dissolution of individuality. Furthermore, with the progressive collection of experiences, there follows the realization that what seems to be an unsurveyably large number of varietal and breed distinctions within a species are in fact always based on different combinations and re-combinations of a relatively small number of genes. A particularly distinguished researcher of heredity, the botanist E. Bauer,[44] explains: "Once a species has been sufficiently analyzed, one can, just like a chemist, produce certain desired combinations of properties, i.e., new breeds, in a synthetic and goal-oriented manner."

If genes were to remain mere symbols, genetics would only profess a mechanism without mechanics, and inheritance as a preserving principle through the fluctuation of organic processes would only consist in a mere persistence stripped of such process. The third step in the direction of insight into actuality is therefore the uncovering of those processes [*Vorgänge*] which have been provisionally described through the fiction of 'genes.' In any case, they must be processes, for we know that life is nothing but a process of processes [*Ablauf der Prozessen*]. Any return to the older corpuscular theories of inheritance is simply impossible.

In 1917, R. Goldschmidt began working in this direction, starting from heredity and the determination of sex. Already by 1920,[45] he entertained "that it is more probable that the definitive explanation of the essence and necessity of sexuality requires use of concepts of the order of reaction-product, catalysis, hydrogen-ion-concentration, and colloid rather than concepts of the order of rejuvenescence, amphimixis, and germinal selection." These words harbor a rejection of the metaphysical-romantic biology that I have drawn attention to elsewhere.[46] Further, under the weight of the facts, Goldschmidt is compelled to become a dialectical materialist, though he was likely not conscious of this—a fate shared by many a natural researcher who posits nothing artificial into

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[44] Erwin Bauer, *Einführung in die experimentelle Vererbungslehre*, 3rd and 4th ed. (Berlin: Gebrüder Borntraeger, 1919). [Translator's note:] Schaxel does not provide an exact page number for this citation

[45] Richard Goldschmidt, *Mechanismus und Physiologie der Geschlechtsbestimmung* (Berlin: Verlag von Gebrüder Borntraeger, 1920), 21.

[46] Julius Schaxel, *Grundzüge der Theorienbildung in der Biologie*, 2nd ed. (Jena: Gustav Fischer, 1922), 103.

nature but derives results from it instead. He summarizes his physiological theory of heredity as follows:

> The gene is a substance-particle to which not only a specific quality belongs, which is self-evident, but which is also already provided at the starting-point of development in a typical quantity—typical, but different for different genes or gene-groups. The chromosomal-mechanism, which ensures the right amount of the different genes at the starting-point of development, must also possess the necessary means to ensure the provision of the typical quantities of each. Each of these genes is material, which, beginning with an activation in fertilization (or parthenogenesis), participates in a reaction or chain of reactions, the specific quality of which is conditioned by the quality of the gene and its substrate (i.e., in the main, the egg-plasma), the speed of which, however, is proportional to the quantity of the gene. If one wishes to associate a more concrete representation with 'the substance of the gene,' it might best be classified as an 'autocatalyst.' With this, the preceding proposition can be expressed more concretely as well: the gene catalyzes a reaction with a speed proportional to its quantity. The development of an organism with independent differentiation can be dissolved into a series of parallel-running processes [*eine Reihe nebeneinandergehender Abläufe*] which tend towards a chemical situation which at specific, but different, points in time can in general be described as the emergence of formative material, determination-substances, or, according to our more specific assumption, hormones of definitive configuration [*Gestaltung*] in effective quantities. The correct course of normal differentiation demands that these determination-points appear in precisely the correct sequential order, and that the determining substances arise localized, in precisely the right location. A system of precisely dosed gene quantities, and thus the reaction-process of proportionally coordinated speeds they catalyze, enables the result of the reaction, the determination-points, to appear in a typical sequential order and in the correct intervals. Each subsequent reaction-point confronts a different general physico-chemical situation on the grounds of the preceding, and so faster, processes; above all, each is met with an increasingly limited sphere of action due to the determinations that have already been completed, and which restrict and localize the scope of its effect. The assumption of parallel-running, coordinated rates of reaction for the process of determination explains the sequence and localization of differentiation; in connection with the causative role of precisely dosed gene quantities, the former representation becomes a theory of heredity, one which constitutes a decisive advance on the factor-theory.[47]

In the genetic process, the effect-qualities are conditioned by precisely dosed gene-quantities, and thus the processes which pass through the generations, and which constitute the mosaic of the species-image at any one point in time, are incorporated into a lawful regularity that may be derived from all spheres of living processes—namely, the dialectical law of the transformation of quantity into quality. I will return to this point to provide a more thorough elaboration in the comprehensive presentation announced in the introduction

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[47] Richard Goldschmidt, *Physiologische Theorie der Vererbung* (Berlin: Julius Springer, 1927), 40.

above. Here, it is sufficient for us to establish the genetic dissolution of individuality into a series of parallel-running processes, the resultant effect of which is, at any one point in time, nothing but what we call the individual, and which, accordingly, we conceive of as a state of a natural process, as a cut-out from connection and context, as a complex of relations, but by no means do we imagine this as a permanent structure, nor, for that matter, as an absolute individual that, though unrepresentable, we are still somehow supposed to address.

c) The Formal Dissolution

That living beings have forms is one of their most obvious properties. Organic forms are never fixed and unchanging, but in a state of constant change. Not only does the material change in its form, but the form itself changes with the material.

The composition of parts referred to as 'form' is typical-specific, i.e., each respective, determinate, ordered composition (specific) arises through multiple events in ordered coordination (typical). Despite the singular diversity in number, arrangement, relationships, and alternation of their parts, there are always simultaneously many individual beings that display the same order of composition that repeats in the same sequence. The graduated diversity of the kinship-relations of living beings, the historical coming-to-be of which we are familiar, is evident herein.

The formative process is bound to material parts, each of which occupies a spatially determinate position at any one point in time. Accordingly, experiment—which consists in the translocation, disconnection, excision, insertion, and substitution of parts—focuses on these material parts.

In the formative states [*Formzuständen*] of single-celled and tissue-forming living beings, form finds its simplest expression in the fact that different materials are separated from one another spatially within the cell, distributed in specific proportions, and relate to one another in specific ways. Therefore, we speak of the compositionality, the constitution of the cell. In tissue-formation, cellular structures and their reciprocal positional relations are formally operative in cell-constitutions. Material form that arises from distinguishable parts is everywhere present. There are no states or structures that are identical in every respect but in which the composition of parts cannot be recognized.

Cells and cellular structures cannot be viewed as self-contained individuals, for it is precisely in view of form that life proceeds through the continuous sublation [*Aufhebung*] of these individualities. Any other approach to the cell as an illusory semblance of individuality or as an imagined totality contradicts the facts and, for that reason, creates an insoluble problem.

Cells with anabolism increase their material stock and then divide themselves. Quality transforms into quantity. The preservation and proliferation of cells, the living process, is only possible through the continuous negation of cellular individuals through division.

The difficulties this presents to holding onto the concept of the individual are already evident in Ernst Haeckel (1866). The reproduction of living beings is derived from growth.

> As the individual grows beyond its individual measure, the surplus growth-product becomes detached from it in the form of a new part, which is soon restored into a complete individual through its own growth. The newly generated fetal organism (*partus*) is therefore a detached part of the paternal organism (*parens*). This detachment can be complete or incomplete. In the former case, the newly generated morphological individual, through the act of detachment, acquires the self-sufficiency of the physiological individual (*bion*). In the latter case, the fetal morphological individual remains more or less bound to the parental and forms in conjunction with it a complex or colony; the physiological individual becomes a member of a higher morphological order than either of the two components [viz., *partus* and *parens*]. [48]

The indivisible maintains itself through division, within the framework of an indivisible measure, the boundaries of which are, however, not fixed but movable in varying degrees. This contradictory formulation only demonstrates that the processes of life cannot be comprehended by rigid, individual concepts. They spring loose from the fetters of conceptual violence. The dialectician Friedrich Engels,[49] student of Hegel, was spared such scholastic confusions, despite the fact he was no biologist. He saw reproduction as an example of the dialectical law of the negation of the negation, as he explained on numerous occasions. In light of the mixed and mis-representations still in circulation today, if no more than certainly no less than in 1878, it is well worth returning to his example of the humble barleycorn. Engels says:

> Let us take a grain of barley. Billions of such grains of barley are milled, boiled and brewed and then consumed. But if such a grain of barley meets with conditions which are normal for it, if it falls on suitable soil, then under the influence of heat and moisture it undergoes a specific change, it germinates; the grain as such ceases to exist, it is negated, and in its place appears the plant which has arisen from it, the negation of the grain. But what is the normal life-process of this plant? It grows, flowers, is fertilised and finally once more produces grains of barley, and as soon as these have ripened the stalk dies, is in its turn negated. As a result of this negation of the negation we have once again the original grain of barley, but not as a single unit, but ten-, twenty- or thirtyfold. Species of grain change extremely slowly, and so the barley of today

[48] Ernst Haeckel, Generellen Morphologie, 180.

[49] Friedrich Engels, *Anti-Dühring*, trans. Emile Burns, in Karl Marx and Frederick Engels, *Collected Works*, vol. 25 (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 2010)

> is almost the same as it was a century ago. But if we take a plastic ornamental plant, for example a dahlia or an orchid, and treat the seed and the plant which grows from it according to the gardener's art, we get as a result of this negation of the negation not only more seeds, but also qualitatively improved seeds, which produce more beautiful flowers, and each repetition of this process, each fresh negation of the negation, enhances this process of perfection. —With most insects, this process follows the same lines as in the case of the grain of barley. Butterflies, for example, spring from the egg by a negation of the egg, pass through certain transformations until they reach sexual maturity, pair and are in turn negated, dying as soon as the pairing process has been completed and the female has laid its numerous eggs. We are not concerned at the moment with the fact that with other plants and animals the process does not take such a simple form, that before they die they produce seeds, eggs or offspring not once but many times; our purpose here is only to show that the negation of the negation really does take place in both kingdoms of the organic world.[50]

Through the continuous negation of the individual, the stream of life flows through the generations.

Prior discoveries about the preservation and proliferation of forms need to be deepened by determination of the content of events, the determination of development, on the basis of which further evidence for the dissolution of individuality emerges.

Development occurs in states that are distinguishable through changes in speed of the process and the kind of events which fill them. For example, in tissue-forming animals, development occurs as predevelopment (maternal egg and paternal semen), unification of the germ-cells (fertilization), triggering the development of the fertilized egg, construction of the body prior to cleavage (division of the egg), the forming of basic components and the separation of tissues, the structuration [*Ausgestaltung*] of the organs through their activity, operational processes, including any substitute-formations, and, in the end, senescence. Development extends from cell-formation to natural death. The cell is a finite member of a comparatively infinite sequence.

The determination of formations happens in a step-by-step progression. All subsequent states are necessary, since the change of any one individual state necessarily conditions the determination of all that follow. Determination can therefore also be characterized as an increasing restriction of possibilities through the restriction of opportunities for formation [*Bildungsermöglichung*] to a narrower and narrower sphere. Spinoza's axiom applies here too: *omnis determinatio est negatio*.

'Determination in successive acts' excludes two misleading assumptions: predestination, which rigidly fixes the course of development from the outset, and the finalist conception, which supposes that teleologically directed forces

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[50] Friedrich Engels, *Anti-Dühring*, trans. Emile Burns, in Karl Marx and Frederick Engels, *Collected Works*, vol. 25 (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 2010), 126.

strive towards a stage considered to be essential. What is 'typical' is only the typical outcome achieved along typical paths. The redirection of development along atypical paths always results in atypical progression. Nothing stands in the way of the artificial institution of modes of development that have yet to be realized in nature, even if this has largely been unsuccessful until now because our insight into the interaction of the parts is still too poor and the technical difficulty involved is still too great. The so-called "regulation of development" must only be spoken of with extreme caution, or else teleological speculation will replace derivation from facts. Here, the danger posed by fictive individuality and totality is particularly acute.

In 1922, summarizing more than a decade of research into the formation of animal form [*Formbildung*], I wrote:

> There is a determinable boundary of the typical-specific form, one which cannot be overstepped without consequences that endanger the persistence of what is typical. Analytic experiment is of service in the determination of this boundary, which, in turn, provides a causal demarcation of the typical-specific form—after its descriptive presentation through comparison of formative modes [*Bildungsweisen*]. If we overstep this boundary—that is, if that which has form [*Formhabende*] is changed—and so change will inevitably continue to have an effect. The atypical form-process [*Formvorgang*] proves itself to be just as persistent as the typical. From this, it follows that the type is not absolute, possessing neither spatial fixity nor non-spatial persistence. The material bondage of the formed [*Formhaften*] also restricts atypical paths of development within a determinable scope. Overstepping this boundary results in the destruction of the organic form; decay takes the place of ordered interaction.[51]

Several further examples of early embryo development, regeneration, and transplantation may be appropriate for purposes of illustration. The first developmental step in tissue-forming animals is cleavage, which consists in the division of the egg. The typically-constituted egg is gradually replaced by a typically-ordered aggregate of cells through a series of cellular divisions. This has been experimentally substantiated and replicated. The change in constitution of the egg results in a change in the modus of the cleavage and, thus, in outcome (Figs. 1 and 2). This results in—

[51] Julius Schaxel, "Über die Natur der Formvorgänge in der tierischen Entwicklung," *Archiv für Entwicklungsmechanik der Organismen* 50 (1922): 523–24.

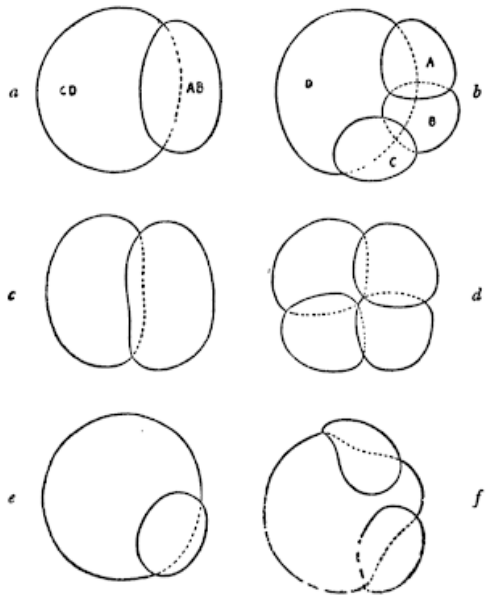


Abb. 1

Teilung des Eies des Borstenwurms *Aricia*. *a* und *b*: 2- und 4-Zellenstadium bei typischer Eikonstitution; es ergibt sich ein bestimmtes Größen- und Lagenverhältnis der Zellen *AB* und *CD* und dann *A*, *B*, *C*, *D*. Bei *c* und *d* ist experimentell eine atypische Eikonstitution hergestellt, die Aufteilung in nahezu gleichgroße Zellen bedingt; während die experimentelle Abänderung bei *e* und *f* zur Abknospung sehr kleiner Zellen von dem großen Ei führt

Figure 1: Division of the egg of the *Aricia* bristle-worm. *a* and *b*: 2- and 4-cellular stages with typical egg-constitution; this results in a specific ratio of size and position of the cells *AB* and *CD*, then of *A*, *B*, *C*, *D*. In *c* and *d*, an atypical egg-constitution has been experimentally induced, which conditions the division into two cells of nearly equal size; the experimental modification of *e* and *f* results in the budding of very small cells from the larger egg.

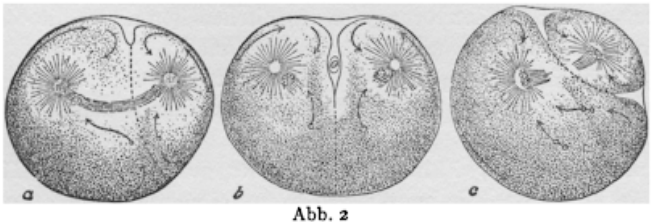


Abb. 2

Veranschaulichung der Bewegung des Eiinhaltes bei den Teilungsvorgängen und zwar bei *a* im Falle von Abb. 1 a, bei *b* im Falle von Abb. 1 c und bei *c* im Falle von Abb. 1 e

Figure 2: Illustration of the movement of the contents of the egg during the process of division—in particular: *a*, in the case of Fig. 1a; *b*, in the case of Fig. 1c; and *c*, in the case of Fig. 1e.

—the constitution of each blastomere, and thus its determination for subsequent developmental events, which is conditioned, on the one hand, by the material composition inherited from the egg and its locationality and, on the other, by the preceding cleavage-process. What becomes of the blastomere that is experimentally removed from its germinal cluster (in isolation) depends on its constitution. Failure to take this circumstance into consideration has led to disastrous speculations about regulation, totality, individuality.

There are species whose *modus* of cleavage preserves the egg-constitution into the first blastomere-generations, e.g., the so-called radial-*modus*, with totally equal and then adequate cleavage, in many sea urchins and starfish, and also in species in which blastomere-constitution is still distinct from egg-constitution after the first, but always unequal, division (e.g., the spiral-*modus* of snails and many species of worm). Isolated blastomeres of the second group develop, if they develop at all, into one or another sort of *atypia* from partial-mass. They have never been seduced by "holistic representations" [*"Ganzheitsvorstellungen"*]. It is different for the first group.

For species whose blastomeres retain the external form and arrangement of contents after isolation from the cellular cluster they first arose in, the isolated blastomeres develop into partial-structures from partial-mass (e.g., the comb jellies or ctenophores in Fischel's experiments). In sea urchins, however, the earliest experimenters encountered the initially baffling result: structured wholes [*Ganzgebilde*] obtained from isolated blastomeres, i.e., from partial-masses. Lacking requisite insight into the relevant context, these experimenters soon began to employ terms like non-spatio-temporal factors, elementary "soul," the category of individuality—assumptions and representations whose socio-historical presuppositions have already been indicated in the above introduction. The careful reexamination of their experiments does

not, in fact, result in similar constructions, but instead the derivation of much simpler lawful regularities from the facts.

Things stand as follows: the cleavage-*modi* of spherical eggs, whose blastomeres retain the egg-constitution and, after their isolation from the spherical-sector-form (half-, quarter-, and eighth-spherical contents), round into spheres once more—all of this enables the decomposition of the egg-whole into smaller eggs of typical constitution. The products of their cleavage are whole structures of partial-mass. In the case of the *Asterias glacialis* starfish (Fig. 3), I have produced detailed reports and drawn conclusions from them.[52] What is certain is that there is no basis for whispers about non-spatio-temporal totality or the configuration of *entelechia*; there is, however, reason to suspect the paradox of divisible individuality, and to conclude that perhaps individuality is not the appropriate concept for designating the facts as we confront them.

[52] Julius Schaxel, *Die Leistungen der Zellen bei der Entwicklung der Metazoen* (Jena: Gustav Fischer, 1915), 153ff.

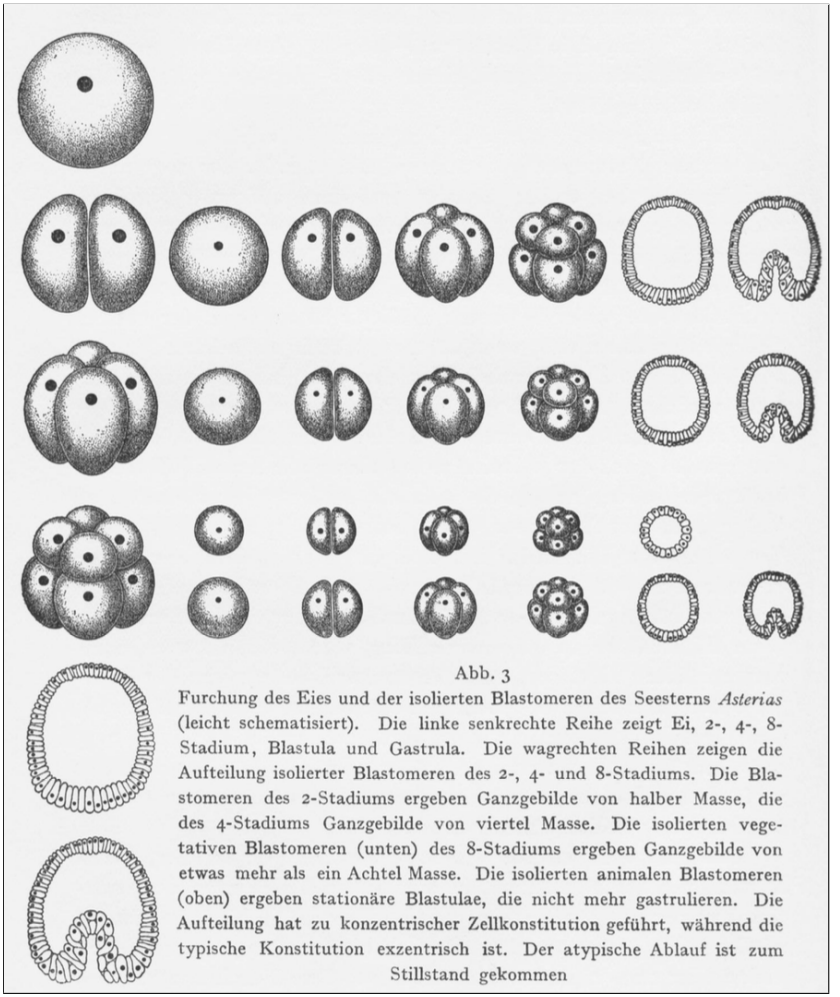
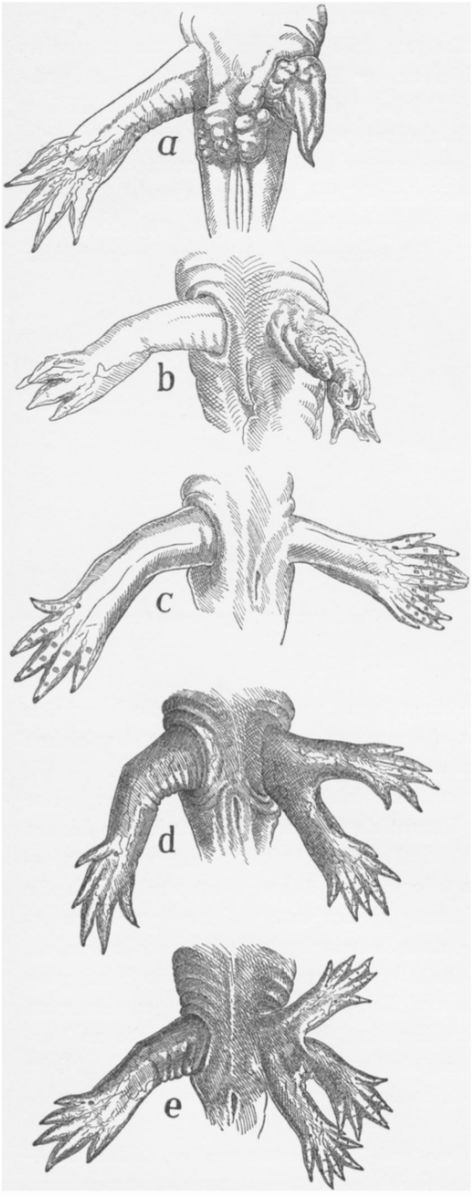


Figure 3: Cleavage of the egg and of isolated blastomeres of the starfish *Asterias* (slightly schematized). The left-vertical row depicts the egg, 2nd-, 4th-, 8th-stage, blastula and gastrula. The horizontal rows depict the division of isolated blastomeres, 2nd-, 4th-, 8th-stage. The 2nd-stage blastomeres generate whole structures at half-mass, while the 4th-stage produce whole structures at quarter-mass. The 8th-stage isolated vegetative blastomeres (below) generate whole structures of slightly more than eighth-mass. The isolated animal blastomeres (above) generate stationary blastulae, which no longer gastrulate. The division has led to a concentric cell-constitution, whereas the typical constitution is eccentric. The atypical process has already reached a standstill.

Regeneration, understood as the regeneration of lost parts, has given rise to the erroneous conception that what is regenerated is "in each case precisely that which was missing." This then becomes a question of maintaining the whole over and against external disturbances. Standard natural-scientific procedure does not seek the cause of present events in what is absent; a glance at the facts is enough to reveal their true face. As a rule, it is not that something missing is mysteriously regenerated, not even for supposedly exceptional species; rather, in the progression of organic formation, new formations arise in accordance with what is present.



Die Regeneration als Wiedererzeugung verloren gegangener Teile hat zu der irrigen Auffassung Anlaß gegeben, es werde „jedesmal genau das, was fehlt", wieder gebildet. Dann wird von Ganzheitserhaltung gegenüber äußeren Störungen gehandelt. Ist es schon eine sonst in den Naturwissenschaften nicht übliche Betrachtungsweise, im Nichtvorhandenen die Ursache für das Geschehen im Vorhandenen zu suchen, so zeigt ein Blick auf die Tatsachen ihr wahres Gesicht.

Nicht was fehlt, wird allgemein oder bei dadurch ausgezeichneten Arten auf geheimnisvolle Weise wieder gebildet, sondern im Fortgang organischer Bildungen kommt es jeweils nach Maßgabe des Vorhandenen zu Neubildungen. Jede Entfernung eines Teils

Abb. 4
Sub- und Superregenate nach Exartikulation der linken Hinterextremität des Axolotls: atypische Ersatzgebilde. Ansichten von der Bauchseite

Figure 4: Sub- and super-regnates after the disarticulation of the left hind-limb of the axolotl: atypical replacement structures. Views from the ventral side

Every excision of a part in the course of ongoing development creates a discongruence in the correlations of the remaining parts and, thus, an atypical end-structure. Absence of formation, scarring, budding, regenerative new formation, reconfiguration following removal—all of these are atypical phenomena; these are not, however, final approximates, but rather vary according to the specific cause of the wound and the tissue that remains.[53] However much one might resist surrendering their belief in an imaginary preservation of wholeness, it cannot be maintained that a motionless stump is nevertheless a limb, or that a tissue-complex completely unsuitable as a photoreceptor is nevertheless an eye. Rather, the inevitable conclusion they must draw is that there is no such thing at all (Fig. 4).

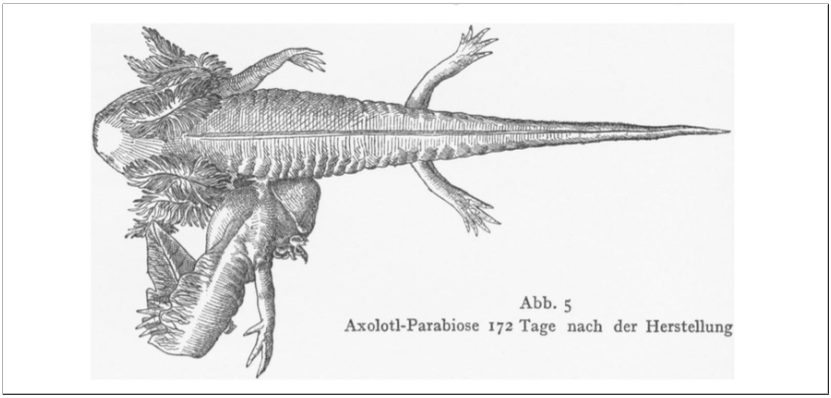


Figure 5: Axolotl parabiosis 172 days after creation.

Finally, transplantation offers still another way by which one can go beyond the individual, who is by no means formally self-enclosed or complete. In the axolotl, astonishing multi-faceted structures have been created and cultivated over the course of many years through the grafting of body parts onto animals of the same or slightly older age as the donor, and through the creation of vascular- and tissue-connection between two nearly intact specimens. All manner of transitions have been demonstrated: from the grafting of surplus organ-parts to the insertion of foreign body-sections, and even the duplication of structures, in a manner reminiscent of conjoined twins, to the effect of creating a shared circulatory system that flows through a single heart (Figs. 5 and 6). Not infrequently, processes have arisen in which the correlations

[53] Julius Schaxel, "Regenerations- und Transplantationsstudien, I: Zum Determinationsproblem," *Zoologischer Anzeiger* 78 (1928): 153–57.

of tissue-complexes appear to break down, resulting in extensive tumor-growth.[54]

The stream of life pulses in organic forms, flowing not through a mesh of more or less distinct tubes, but in a broad and wide-branching riverbed, whose branches separate and rejoin one another, now and then branching off in new directions and perhaps even drying up. The individual is only a state, often just an arbitrarily circumscribed cutout, of the formative process.

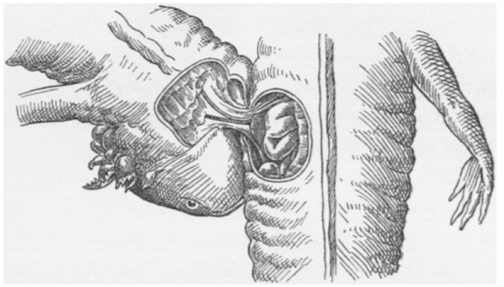


Abb. 6
Dieselbe Axolotl-Parabiose wie in Abb. 5 sieben Jahre nach Herstellung verstorben. Körperwand an der Verwachsungsstelle geöffnet. Man sieht die von der linken Kiemengegend des kleineren Tieres, das keinen eigenen Kreislauf hat, zur Milz des größeren Tieres verlaufende Arterie (hell) und Vene (dunkel)

Figure 6: The same axolotl-parabiosis as in Fig. 5; deceased seven years after creation. Wall of the body cavity opened at the site of grafting. The artery (light) and vein (dark) can be seen running from the left-gill area of the smaller animal, which has no circulation of its own, into the spleen of the larger animal.

d) The Social Dissolution

The metabolism of life is a sub-process of the metabolism of the Earth. Under the influence of solar energy, autotrophic green plants form organic mass out of simple compounds, which are diluted in water and dispersed in air. Microbes break down the organic matter to the point of complete disintegration. Together, autotrophy and heterotrophy constitute an internal bond between all living beings. Alongside phylogeny and kinship, life-preserving relations find expression in the relativity of bionts.

The *Lebensraum* ("living space") of the Earth, wherein the conditions for life

[54] Regarding the transplantations conducted in my Institute, these are regularly reported on in the relevant specialist literature.

(nourishment, water, salts, warmth, space)[55] are present, consists of numerous interlocking spheres of bionts, which are demarcated even less clearly from one another than the bionts themselves. The history of the distribution of life over the Earth occurs as adaptation in the *Lebensräume*, each of which fulfills the totality of conditions of life in a determinate state.[56]

The interlocking of the *Lebensräume*, the relational complex of the preservation of life, has led to the concept of biocoenoses, which, however, become living communities in the true sense of the word only through the progress of repeated success in phylogenetic history.[57] The biocoenosis encompasses the totality of the plants and animals in a location that furnishes all conditions for their development and maintenance. The members of a given biocoenosis exist in relationships of perpetual interaction with one another, whether indirectly or directly, *via* local conditions.

The interactive relationships between bionts are of two kinds. *Either*: coexistence is limited to the simultaneous exploitation of the chances for survival in a given locality. This ends in the competition between competitors, through which their strength is tested. *Or*: relations of one-sided or reciprocal

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[55] Julius Schaxel, *Das Leben auf der Erde* (Jena: Urania-Verlagsgesellschaft, 1928), 13ff.

[56] [Translator's note:] "Lebensraum" is a biogeographical concept coined by Friedrich Ratzel in a 1901 essay which reconceptualized the Darwinian "struggle for existence" as a "struggle for space." See Friedrich Ratzel, "Lebensraum: A Biogeographical Study" [1901], trans. Tul'si (Tuesday) Bhambry, *Journal of Historical Geography* 61 (2018): 59–80. In the essay, Ratzel comments not only on the distribution of life on earth but also on imperialist colonization and the geographical distribution of human races. Despite Ratzel's denunciation of proponents of racial purity in the context of 19th-century biopolitics, he does make use of the racist scientific terminology of his time in the "Lebensraum" essay itself, including a distinction between 'stable' and 'mixed' or 'transitional' racial groups. In this sense, there is an unavoidable slippage between the biogeographical and geopolitical uses of "Lebensraum." Schaxel consciously takes up the word in the context of ongoing debates about the meaning and use of the concept without thinking that the question of its political significance can simply be bracketed. For a contemporary application of the term, see Jevgeniy Bluwstein, Connor Cavanagh, and Robert Fletcher, "Securing Conservation Lebensraum? The Geo-, Bio-, and Ontopolitics of Global Conservation Futures," *Geoforum* 153 (2024): 103752, `https://doi.org/10.1016/j.geoforum.2023.103752`.

[57] [Translator's note:] Schaxel's "biocoenoses" [*Biozönosen*] invokes what was, in his day, a heavily theorized term in German ecology. Coined by Karl Möbius in 1877 for oyster-bed communities, *Biozönose* was taken up by figures like Thienemann and Friederichs as an organismic concept, which is to say a special type of 'whole' that is a harmonious self-regulating unity. For more information on this concept, see Kurt Jax, " 'Organismic' Positions in Early German-Speaking Ecology and Its (Almost) Forgotten Dissidents," *History and Philosophy of the Life Sciences* 42, no. 4 (2020): 44, `https://doi.org/10.1007/s40656-020-00328-9`. Indeed, the contemporary concept of "ecosystem" arose to neutralize the holistic baggage found in biocoenosis favoring descriptions of matter and energy flow/dynamics, so the two terms are not simply interchangeable. Moreover, Schaxel own mobilization of the concept is in itself idiosyncratic; he adds an evolutionary criterion ("living community in the true sense" only through "repeated success in phylogenetic history") largely absent from Möbius's or Friederichs's accounts, anticipating present-day interest in ecological units defined by coevolutionary history.

dependency form. The shared way of life brings with it a more or less internal bond between cooperants. A community of the living in the true sense of the word emerges.

With his notion of the "struggle for life," Darwin emphasized competition, the struggle for existence by all against all. This resonated with the prevailing mode of thinking in his society, its markedly individualistic features. Since then, as a consequence of the further development of human society, the significance of cooperation has received increased recognition. The struggle between competitors of the same kind for space, nourishment, and light is won by the stronger displacing, overgrowing, or crushing the weaker. This competition intensifies as it progresses. The natural filtration process of a forest shows, for example, that only one in 2,000 ten-year-old beech trees succeeds in fully developing into a hundred-year-old specimen. The competition between species is all the more violent the more their life-requirements and patterns of seasonal development coincide. The more diverse the inhabitants of a locality, the greater the sum of life that can be realized in the same spatial coordinates. The task of ecology is to empirically determine the comparative competitiveness of the species that populate it. Every none-too-minor slice of nature furnishes further examples: forest, meadow, oyster bed, coral reef, etc.

In each, the bonds of interdependent cooperation have overcome competition within their own sphere. Together, they enter into the struggle for existence as closed formations. One-sided relations of dependency are characteristic of parasites, which extract the raw living substance or draw ready-made flows of nutrients from their hosts. They have all manner of transitional forms, from those which suck their nutrients from the host to those for which the innards of the host serve as a *Lebensraum* all its own. In the reciprocal relations of dependency in symbiosis, the *Lebensräume* of the partners interpenetrate, as they reciprocally secure their chances for survival. The competitiveness obtained through this reciprocity is demonstrated by the example of lichens—the nutritive cooperative of autotrophic algae and heterotrophic fungi. Lichens are true cosmopolitans, spreading from sea coasts to high mountains.

The one-sided-parasitic and reciprocal-symbiont relations, even when they occur on a massive scale, have no true, or only the very beginnings of, social value. It is only the preservation of the members by the whole, the integration of interdependent and interreliant comrades, that guarantees mutual support, the social division of labor, and community. Whenever the masses form such a community, a new form of life emerges. Quantity has transformed into quality. In social progression, individuals are sublated into the collective. In natural history, this path has walked many times and to varying degrees. We

will address this elsewhere in greater depth and detail.[58]

The swarms and the herds of so many vertebrates, particularly fish, birds, and mammals, are assemblages of common activity of shorter or longer duration for specific periods of life, extending all the way to lifelong herd-formation. Beyond the naturally-occurring division of labor between the sexes, the organization of the social structure evolves in a domain in which humans, though still far from perfect, are already master. Among invertebrates, a number of sessile, aquatic creatures that reproduce asexually (through fission or budding) form nutritive cooperatives. Sponges, colonies of polyps, and corals display interwoven tissues and communication between gastric cavities, such that the actions of the parts affect the whole. Homomorphic colonies are the foundation on which hetero- and poly-morphic forms of society develop. In the polymorphic colonies of the siphonophores, there are no independently viable bionts to be found, because the division of labor has created a deep-rooted relation of dependency between all members of the colony alike. Even among socialized insects such as bumblebees, wasps, bees, ants, termites, bionts lose the capacity for independent survival. Procreation, brood-care, and nutrition—in short, all of the functions of reproduction—are socialized through the division of labor. Phylogenetically, ecologically, and physiologically—here, we see the dialectical intensification of mass-association and, along with it, social progression.

The earliest signs of human society are found in the horde of early humans, and they, in turn, brought this kind of association along with them from out of their animality. An animal as defenceless as the developing human being could only survive in isolation or small numbers on occasion. In order to complete the process of becoming-human, it was vital that the meager defensive capabilities of the individual were replaced by the unified strength and cooperation of the horde. Men and women of all stages of life (the elderly, adults, children) are unified in this horde and act together for the preservation of the whole. They use only naturally-occurring food sources (wild-growing plants, edible animals) and provision only for their more immediate needs. The conditions of life are the same for all members of the horde alike, which has yet to undergo any real differentiation. The subsequent social-historical structure does not lead to polymorphic reproductive communities as in the case of insects; rather, the performance of labor becomes the fundamental condition of human life. It is with labor that humanity's domination over nature begins. Through it, humans are separated from animals and set on the path towards economy. The community of equals is pierced through by a streak of inequality, one which will leave its mark on the structure of human social development

[58] Julius Schaxel, *Vergesellschaftung in der Natur* (Jena: Urania-Verlagsgesellschaft, 1931).

from that point on. Agriculture, animal husbandry, handicrafts, industry, and trade are all activities and achievements of a class-stratified society, as the greater part of human beings have no ownership over the means of production, which have since become the property of the rulers. Class society, constantly racked and rattled by struggles, wars, and crises, points beyond itself, towards the community of humanity [*Menschheitsgemeinschaft*]. In the producing collective, individuality is socially sublated.

The present-day content of the Earth's biosphere is a historical product, and the preservation of this content binds its participants to one another. The degree of consolidation is variable. Socialization [*Vergesellschaftung*] always proves itself superior to isolation [*Vereinzelung*]. The most advanced reproductive communities of insects possess a phenomenal capacity for propagation. Human society, with its division of labor in production, proves itself incomparably more powerful, ready for further advances, and heightened organization. Already, it stands at a turning-point where the individual is no longer its goal and concept; rather, the community of the masses relegates all such boundaries into the past.

3. Individuality and Dialectic

In 1885, Friedrich Engels wrote:

> It is however precisely the polar antagonisms put forward as irreconcilable and insoluble, the forcibly fixed lines of demarcation and class distinctions, which have given modern theoretical natural science its restricted, metaphysical character. The recognition that these antagonisms and distinctions, though to be found in nature, are only of relative validity, and that on the other hand their imagined rigidity and absolute validity have been introduced into nature only by our reflective minds—this recognition is the kernel of the dialectical conception of nature. It is possible to arrive at this recognition because the accumulating facts of natural science compel us to do so; but one arrives at it more easily if one approaches the dialectical character of these facts equipped with an understanding of the laws of dialectical thought. In any case natural science has now advanced so far that it can no longer escape dialectical generalisation.[59]

When he wrote this forty-five years ago, Engels was under the influence of thermodynamics and organic evolutionary history. Today, the accumulation of facts in all fields of natural science compels us to adopt a dialectical conception of nature. Because researchers and thinkers, given their social being, by no means necessarily confront the facts with consciousness of dialectical laws, heterogeneous eclecticism takes the place of general agreement, a chaos in which neither empiricists nor metaphysicians, but only dialecticians, can find

[59] Engels, *Anti-Dühring*, trans. Burns, 14.

their way. Only those who can recognize the ripeness of the fruit before them will reap the riches of harvest.

Dialectical biology strips away all rigidified concepts, above all the concept at the center of any metaphysical biology—that of individuality. The constant species has condemned mechanics to inactivity in the face of the living. Idealistic morphology exhausted itself in the transcendent *Bauplan* (blueprint, or structural plan).[60] Even transformism did not overcome the dichotomy between basic form [*Grundform*] and transformation of form [*Formenwandlung*]. Developmental mechanics is repeatedly obstructed by the totality of its objects. The result has always been the recoil into vitalism, the renunciation of natural explanation of life.

The natural individual has been dissolved: historically, genetically, formally, and, for the most natural-historically advanced species, even socially. Composed of its parts, the natural individual is itself only part of a larger context. We encounter it only as relative, never absolute.

In every respect, the individual is a transient state of the life-process, no more mysterious than nature as such, which we understand because we ourselves are part of it. Dialectical thinking only reflects the objective dialectic of nature.

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[60] [Translator's note] "*Bauplan*" is a reference to Goethe's theory of morphology. See John H. Zammito: "In Goethe's approach to life science two crucial notions converged: form or structure (*Bau*) and design or telos (*Plan*). The paradigm that Goethe propounded to his age, morphology, was the empirical science of reconstructing—from observations and integration through and beyond observations—the *Bauplan*, the principle behind the development in actual organic life-forms. The essential point about life-forms, for Goethe, was their developmental directionality. This was lawful, but it was concrete. Each instantiation was unique yet utterly expressive of its type. Moreover, the developmental plan could itself change, altering the course of the whole sequence. In this, biological regularities showed a decisive divergence from inorganic, physical regularities. Life changed its expressions; physical matter simply reiterated its manifestations with ceaseless uniformity." *The Gestation of German Biology: Philosophy and Physiology from Stahl to Schelling* (University of Chicago Press, 2018), 294.

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Fragments of a Dialectical Logic (1938-1949)

Max Horkheimer and Theodor Adorno

Introduction[1]

1. Prospectus for "A Dialectical Logic."

In 1938, Max Horkheimer wrote a short prospectus for "A Dialectical Logic," the first in a series of book-length projects proposed as part of a report on the activities of the Institute for Social Research (ISR). Although the report was written to fulfill requirements for receiving institutional support from Columbia University, it was also supposed to serve as a pitch to prospective sources of external funding for future ISR research. The report as a whole is strikingly high-concept, an early product of the desperate but ambitious grant writing practice Horkheimer and Adorno would refer to in their 1940s correspondence as "artistic begging." [2] Horkheimer describes the dialectical logic as follows:

> The guiding concern of the work is not a formalist epistemology, but a material doctrine of categories. In scientific and political discussions about social problems, there are certain categories which are used constantly, but which nevertheless give rise to differences of opinion as soon as a more precise definition is called for. Such categories include concepts like causality, tendency, progress, law, necessity, freedom, class, culture, value, ideology, dialectic, and so forth. […] These categories can only be preserved on the condition they are not embalmed but are instead kept alive through the continuous effort of relating them back to reality. […] Every determination of philosophical concepts involves the presentation of human society in its socially given condition.[3]

Though consistent with Horkheimer's earlier descriptions of the project,[4] it is extremely unlikely that the kind of book outlined in the prospectus aligns

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[1] Introduction by James Crane. Translated and Edited by James Crane and J. E. Morain.

[2] Eva-Maria Ziege, *Antisemitismus und Gesellschaftstheorie* (Suhrkamp, 2009), 154. Author's translation.

[3] "[Idee, Aktivität und Programm des Instituts…]" (1938), *Max Horkheimer, Gesammelte Schriften. Band 12: Nachgelassene Schriften 1931-1949*. Ed. Alfred Schmidt and Gunzelin Schmid Noerr (Fischer Taschenbuch Verlag, 1985), 156-157. For the English translation commissioned by the ISR in 1938, see "An Institute for Social Research: Idea, Activity, and Program (1938)." *Substudies* (blog), 9 June 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/i/165428535/i-an-institute-for-social-research-idea-activity-and-program-1938`

[4] Cf. Max Horkheimer to Karl Landauer, 3/18/1935: "The intention is simply to develop

with what readers—in his time or ours—would expect from a philosophical logic. In fact, the project seems to be defined primarily by its conscious break with the tradition of logic in Western philosophy, from Aristotle's *Organon* to Kant's "Canon," and its explicit opposition to contemporary efforts to break out of that same tradition, from Husserl's *Logical Investigations* to Carnap's *Logical Syntax of Language*. In a discussion with Adorno in late 1946, when the pair revisit their earlier plans for a dialectical logic, Horkheimer concludes that they can neither ignore classical investigations in the field of logic nor dispute them, as "[t]he former does not quite match our method" and "the latter requires an extremely time-consuming reexamination of the relevant authors—above all: Plato, Aristotle, and, among the more recent, Mill, Trendelenburg, Stigwart, Brentano, Husserl, Prantl."[5] In what sense, then, was the dialectical logic supposed to be a logic at all? In each version of the prospectus, Horkheimer does refer to a specific model: Hegel's *Encyclopedia*, and especially the *Logic*. Yet, when Horkheimer describes *how* he plans to write the dialectical logic "on the model of Hegel's great work," his formulations are not only indicative of his rather idiosyncratic reception of Hegel but are also almost entirely negative in character.[6] In a 1939 letter about the dialectical logic, Horkheimer writes that Hegel's "attempt to free philosophy from the dictates of formal logic [...] deserves recognition" even if, from the perspective of the critical materialist, it "went hand in hand with an extremely dubious metaphysics" that had to be contested.[7]

Unsurprisingly, perhaps, Horkheimer's reference to Hegel's *Logic* as a model has done less to disambiguate the original idea of the dialectical logic than to reinforce the suspicion among interpreters that the dialectical logic was impossible from the beginning. Given that *Dialectic of Enlightenment: Philosophical Fragments* (1947) originated, in part, from Horkheimer and Adorno's discussions on dialectical logic, the question of whether the project

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what are in our view the most important categories, such as 'Thinking,' 'Science,' 'Actuality,' 'Cause,' 'Society,' 'Economy,' 'Religion,' 'Art,' 'Culture,' 'Family,' 'Authority,' 'History,' and so on, within a continuous nexus of thought, determining each according to the level of present-day knowledge." *Substudies* (blog), 8 December 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/i/181013997/letterhorkheimer-re-idea-for-a-dialectical-logic`

[5] For the author's translation of these discussion minutes, see Horkheimer and Adorno, "Rescue of the Enlightenment (October 1946)." *Substudies* (blog), 11 August 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/horkheimer-and-adornorettung-der`

[6] On Horkheimer's idiosyncratic reception of Hegel, see the author's translation of Horkheimer's "Hegel and the Problem of Metaphysics" (1932). *Substudies* (blog), 9 May 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/i/162852001/hegel-and-the-problem-of-metaphysics-1932`

[7] See the author's translation of Max Horkheimer to Paul L. Landsberg, 12/23/1939. *Substudies* (blog), 18 March 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/i/158566797/letterhorkheimer-re-logic-in-the-tunnel`

was even possible has significant ramifications for understanding 1940s critical theory as a whole. Rolf Wiggershaus, for instance, draws an analogy between the unexplained relationship between the *Science of Logic* and the so-called *Realphilosophie*—the philosophies of nature and spirit, volumes II and III of the *Encyclopedia*—within Hegel's system and the undeveloped connection between the speculative philosophy of history in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* and the empirical social research conducted by the ISR for their studies in anti-Semitism and prejudice.[8] For Wiggershaus, Horkheimer and Adorno's claims to the contrary amounted to little more than *post hoc* over-integration of abstract speculation and concrete empirical work in theory to compensate for under-integration of the two sides in practice. The fact the dialectical logic remained unwritten is accordingly interpreted as a sign of the collapse of early critical theory as a unified research program.

Whereas Wiggershaus refers back to the original idea of the dialectical logic to question the coherence of the research program of 1940s critical theory, Gunzelin Schmid Noerr identifies a theoretical incoherence internal to the idea itself: "without intending to, yet by surrendering themselves to the course of their own investigations, [Horkheimer and Adorno] gradually drifted further and further from the Hegelian-Marxist idea of an agreement between logic and history."[9] For Noerr, the problem with the dialectical logic is one of second-order mediation: the conceptual mediation of logical concept and actual history. Referring to the 1938 prospectus, Noerr distinguishes between two levels in the original idea of the project. The first, a logical-methodological level that would devote itself to "developing the philosophical foundations of historical materialism," i.e., the logic of the historical mediation of intellectual and cultural products, both in their dependency on and their relative autonomy from economic social processes. The second, a content-exemplary level that would provide a concrete demonstration of the logic established on the first level through its application to a contemporary social problem.[10] Noerr argues that the treatment of anti-Semitism as the "crystallization-point" of *Dialectic of Enlightenment* simultaneously presupposed a certain logic of historical mediation and evaded the task of its concrete demonstration. Instead, the central theoretical problem of "regressive reason" was identified with the social pathology of anti-Semitism on a civilizational scale.[11] According to Noerr,

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[8] Rolf Wiggershaus, *The Frankfurt School: Its History, Theories, and Political Significance.* Translated by Michael Robertson (Polity, 1994), 319-321; 356-357.

[9] Gunzelin Schmid Noerr, "Zum werk- und zeitgeschichtlichen Hintergrund der Dialektik der Aufklärung." *Aufklärungs-kritik und aufklärungs-mythen: Horkheimer und adorno in philosophiehistorischer perspektive.* Ed. S. Lavaert & W. Schröder (Walter de Gruyter GmbH, 2018), 36.

[10] Noerr (2018), 33-35.

[11] This is the guiding thesis of the recent collection of essays on *Dialectic of Enlightenment*

a second-level "concrete demonstration" of a first-level logic of historical mediation would have required Horkheimer and Adorno to ground their theory of social pathology in contemporary empirical social-scientific research, and especially in political economy. Without this grounding, the relationship between the logic of historical mediation and its object, real social history, remained necessarily unmediated. Despite the appeals to an implicit historical logic made throughout the text, the re-orientation of *Dialectic of Enlightenment* around the task of sketching a "philosophical prehistory of anti-Semitism" could even be said to have *displaced* the task of the dialectical logic, the possibility of which the authors seem to have taken for granted. This seems to be confirmed by the 1944 preface, where the authors conclude with a list of the preliminary studies cut from the final manuscript: "Of the German preliminary studies to the whole work, which include the fragments themselves, we left out the pieces on logic, among others."[12]

Like Wiggershaus,[13] Noerr justifies the critical assessment of *Dialectic of Enlightenment* as a failed execution of the dialectical logic by referring to a letter from Horkheimer to Felix Weil from March 1942. In the letter, Horkheimer attempted to stimulate Weil's interest in a long-term collaboration on a comprehensive theory of "the present phase of society" with a working group specifically organized for that purpose, a group that would include Horkheimer himself, Adorno, and Friedrich Pollock: "It is nonsense [to think] that I, even in collaboration with Teddie [Adorno], could lend the work the necessary precision and concreteness. It must be positively bursting with historical and economic material, or else it will come across as mere *raisonnement*."[14] Read in conjunction with Horkheimer's subsequent, thwarted plans for an interdisciplinary ISR yearbook on "Racket Theory,"[15] Noerr considers the letter as a damning admission: "in the end, *Dialectic of Enlightenment* would therefore remain without the economic foundation which had in fact been considered indispensable for it."[16] For Noerr, the fact that these planned interdisciplinary collaborations never came to fruition

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edited by Noerr and Eva-Maria Ziege: *Zur Kritik der regressiven Vernunft. Beiträge zur „Dialektik der Aufklärung"* (Springer VS, 2019), 25.

[12] Theodor W. Adorno and Max Horkheimer, *Dialectic of Enlightenment: Philosophical Fragments.* Edited by Gunzelin Schmid Noerr, translated by Edmund Jephcott (Stanford University Press, 2002 [1987]), 255.

[13] Wiggershaus (1994), 314-319.

[14] Max Horkheimer to Felix Weil, 10 March 1942. *Max Horkheimer, Gesammelte Schriften. Band 17* (Fischer Taschenbuch Verlag, 1996), 275. Author's translation.

[15] For an alternative account of the distinction between the "racket theory" yearbook and the planned book on dialectics, see: James Crane and J. E. Morain, "Introducing Racket Theory" on the *CTWG blog* (blog), 24 June 2025. `https://ctwgwebsite.github.io/blog/2025/RacketIntro/`

[16] Noerr (2018), 35. See also Wiggershaus (1994), 316-318.

was not simply a consequence of the interpersonal conflicts or institutional barriers to their realization; rather, these obstacles themselves are interpreted as signs of some deeper, even fundamental, incoherence in the original idea of the dialectical logic. The failure to collaborate across disciplines in practice was conditioned by a failure to mediate between levels in theory. The real legacy of the dialectical logic is the abstract speculative character of *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, which inherited and dramatized the problems inherent to the original idea without fulfilling either the task of concrete demonstration the project demanded or, for that matter, a substantive engagement with logic. The primary function of the plans for a dialectical logic in secondary literature to date has been to serve as an entry-point for a nested stack of allegories for the failure of early critical theory as a whole. The story that begins with the 1938 prospectus unfolds with an almost fateful necessity. There is even something tragic about it.

And yet, as late as 1946, Horkheimer still planned to begin working on the dialectical logic in earnest, even going as far as identifying the project with the planned "second part" of *Dialectic of Enlightenment*.[17] This has posed a genuine problem for interpreters. In response to the challenge of reconciling Horkheimer's 1946 plans with Horkheimer and Adorno's polemic against the idea of "a logic of history" in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, Noerr introduces two qualifications: "A logic of history, which, as stated in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, one can and should 'scorn' under specific conditions, 'if it is against humanity,' is merely a metaphorical logic."[18] In a first gesture, Noerr turns "if it is against humanity" into a condition for specifying targets of the polemic, thereby saving the idea of a logic of history in the abstract; in a second, Noerr renders the idea of a logic of history in the abstract so harmless, "merely a metaphorical logic," that it becomes hard to understand why Horkheimer and Adorno bothered to write the polemic in the first place. The polemic, in short, would only apply to the very kind of logic of history that, on Noerr's account, neither of the authors believed was tenable anymore anyway. Noerr reconciles the *Dialectic of Enlightenment*'s polemic against a logic of history with Horkheimer's 1946 plans for the dialectical logic at the cost of eliminating the reasons for both. The problem remains: on what grounds was Horkheimer so confident that a "materialist logic" of history could still be written *after* the majority of *Dialectic of Enlightenment* already had been?

Ultimately, for both Wiggershaus and Noerr, the discrepancy between Horkheimer's 1946 plans and the polemic in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* can best be explained as the symptom of a lag between long-term motive and

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17 Horkheimer to Pollock, 3/27/1946. *MHGS*, Bd. 17 (1996), 714-715. Author's translation.
18 Noerr (2018), 36.

hard-won insight, a sign of the lingering but waning influence of a dogmatic "Hegelian-Marxism" on critical theory, one Horkheimer had already effectively broken away from even if he hadn't realized it yet.[19] On this reading, what, at the time, appeared to Horkheimer as developments in his idea for the dialectical logic can now, in retrospect, be understood as degenerations of the idea or departures from it. The narrative arc of the project from the early 1930s through late 1940s takes the form of a vicious cycle between an initial, unreflective assumption of its possibility and a gradual, reflective awareness of its impossibility. The 1938 prospectus is interpreted backwards: *from* the fact the book remained unwritten *to* its inherent unwritability. Horkheimer's enduring confidence in the possibility of a dialectical logic is not explained but explained away. This teleological interpretive approach to early critical theory has enabled interpreters to identify what Noerr calls "preconditions of [the] discontinuities" in its development.[20] However, it has also reinforced what Eva-Maria Ziege calls the "strong perspectival distortion" that overdetermines narrative accounts of the so-called Frankfurt School in advance: the ISR's published texts are first abstracted from the working process that produced them and then made into the sole standard for evaluating that process as a whole, whereas "an abundance of failed or never-realized projects and designs were developed in the research process that Horkheimer and Adorno may well have considered their true goals in the mid-1940s."[21] The purpose of this introduction is to correct for this perspectival distortion by situating the fragmentary sketches on topics in dialectical logic Horkheimer *did* write in relation to the basic idea of the unwritten dialectical logic itself.

Contrary to Wiggershaus and Noerr, I argue that the problem of mediating logic and history was not an implicit one lurking in the original idea of the dialectical logic but rather Horkheimer and Adorno's explicit point of departure. The "open breach," as Wiggershaus calls it, did not make the project of the dialectical logic *impossible* but *possible*. Noerr is right to stress that, throughout the 1940s, Horkheimer and Adorno became increasingly outspoken in their opposition to theories that presupposed a tacit agreement between logic and history. However, the "drift" away from theories that assumed an agreement between logic and history began with the suspension of any assumed identity of logic and history Horkheimer and Adorno found in the works of Hegel and Marx themselves. From the earliest references to

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[19] Noerr (2018), 37.

[20] Noerr, "Editor's Afterword," in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (2002 [1987]), 219.

[21] Eva-Maria Ziege: *Antisemitismus und Gesellschaftstheorie* (Suhrkamp, 2009), 160-161. For more on the problem of "perspectival distortion" in the reception of the Frankfurt School's early critical theory, see "On Reading Critical Theory I: Perspectival Distortions," *Substudies* (blog), 9 May 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/on-reading-critical-theory-i-perspectival`

plans for the project in Horkheimer's correspondence, the idea of a dialectical logic is premised on the non-identity of logic and history for the thoroughgoing historical materialist—it is also the primary contention the materialist critic holds against the metaphysician and the positivist alike.[22] *Dialectic of Enlightenment* raises this contention into the criterion of conceptual thought: the concept can and should become an index of its own distance from its object.[23] Hence, Adorno's formulation of the aporetic character of the critical concept: going beyond the concept by means of the concept.[24]

For Horkheimer and Adorno, following Marx, the central categories of the modern historical and social sciences are always given twice, "in the head as well as in reality," as belated expressions of forms of social being or partial expressions of individual aspects of social life.[25] In their preface to *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, the authors warn readers that the concept of enlightenment at hazard is not to be understood merely in terms of intellectual history, but also in the sense that "enlightenment expresses the real movement of bourgeois society as a whole from the perspective of the idea embodied in its personalities and institutions."[26] Concepts are retroactive attempts to grasp in thought what practice has wrought in the interregnum. Concepts are less reflections than "refractions," expressive of social being through its distortion.[27] Concepts are a register of the unfulfilled needs of human beings *as they are* and the unrealized powers of human beings *as they could be*. Understood accordingly, the power of the concept is a weak one; it belongs less to the concept already embodied in practice than to what in the concept

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[22] See Max Horkheimer to Erich Fromm, 7/29/1934. *Substudies* (blog), 8 December 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/horkheimer-early-sketch-for-a-dialectical`

[23] Adorno and Horkheimer: "But while enlightenment is right in opposing any hypostatization of utopia and in dispassionately denouncing power as division, the split between subject and object, which it will not allow to be bridged, becomes the index of the untruth both of itself and of truth. [...] For not only does the concept, as science, distance human beings from nature, but, as the self-reflection of thought—which, in the form of science, remains fettered to the blind economic tendency—it enables the distance which perpetuates injustice to be measured." *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (2002), 31-32.

[24] Theodor W. Adorno, *Negative Dialectics*, Translated by E.B. Ashton (Routledge, 2004 [1966]), 15. Cf. Horkheimer: "The dialectic is a method by which one can develop one category from another, and thereby all categories. However, I would like to have a main theme in mind: e.g., what can theory do in the present situation? What is its place? Or: how can one overcome the abstractness of the concept by means of the concept itself?" "Rescue of the Enlightenment (October 1946)," *Substudies* (blog), 11 August 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/horkheimer-and-adornorettung-der`

[25] Karl Marx, *Grundrisse: Foundations of the Critique of Political Economy (Rough Draft)*, translated by Martin Nicolaus (Penguin Books & New Left Review, 1973), 106.

[26] Theodor W. Adorno and Max Horkheimer, in *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (2002), xvi.

[27] Horkheimer, *Eclipse of Reason* (1974), viii.

remains to be. The non-identity between concept and reality is reproduced in each of our conceptual achievements. We do catch up to ourselves; in our success, however, we narrowly give ourselves the slip. And so, in an early draft of the first chapter of *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, Horkheimer and Adorno describe the method and the hope of the book as follows:

> [I]n drawing its own boundary, reason—as the social critique of reason—goes beyond itself. It fulfills the construction of the concept Hegel determined in Kant's transcendental dialectic: by virtue of the contradiction inherent to circumscribing a narrow, contradiction-free region of experience for reason, it becomes the means of breaking out of the very region it circumscribes. The hopelessness of the fascist era is the despair and dissolution of hope as poor semblance in the face of the immediate possibility of its realization, to which hope weakly clings.[28]

Read under the aspect of non-identity, the fragments for a dialectical logic acquire a consistency of their own, anti-systematic in that they "make a claim at least as far-reaching as that of the system itself, and thereby demonstrate its obsolescence."[29] Each fragment rearticulates the problematic relation between certain logical forms and their real social contents, which the forms are supposed to subsume, grasp, or render valid, transparent, tractable. Refusing to invent a meta-logic or meta-language of their own, Horkheimer and Adorno instead set out to make the history of philosophical logic a problem for itself. The task of the dialectical logic, in the infamously misological words of *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, is to induce logical thought itself "to scorn logic, if it is against humanity."[30] The problematic of the dialectical logic *is* the project.

In the following second section, I outline an alternative reconstruction of the basic idea of the dialectical logic and its development on these grounds. Rather than treating the dialectical logic as an abortive preliminary exercise for *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, the project is reconsidered in light of three constituent elements neglected by previous interpretations: (1) the tripartite schema for a "material doctrine of categories": reconstruction, application, anticipation; (2) the role of praxis as the historically mediating factor between logical forms and their real social content; (3) the progressive reformulation of the idea of the dialectical logic in terms of the philosophy and history of language.

In the third and final section, I offer my own thesis for how the fragments in the collection hang together as a whole. First, I present a case for the

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[28] For the author's reconstruction and translation of the archival material, see "Sketches in Myth and Enlightenment (Winter 1942/43)." *Substudies* (blog), 14 February 2026. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/sketches-in-myth-and-enlightenment`

[29] Horkheimer to Walter Benjamin, 2/23/1939. *MHGS Bd. 16* (1995), 564-568. Author's translation.

[30] Adorno and Horkheimer, *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (2002), 180.

consistency of the fragments in terms of topics, literary form and style, and the basic methodological orientation of critical theory in the Marxian critique of political economy. In the process, I argue that the core of the project remains consistent from the early 1930s through the late 1940s, and that Horkheimer develops his early conception of the dialectical logic as a "material doctrine of categories" rather than abandoning it along the way. Finally, after suggesting a narrative arc to account for how the fragments fit together chronologically, I conclude with a short list of recommended "checks" to perform while reading the fragments which are meant to help readers get the most out of the collection.

2. Elements of a Dialectical Logic

In the 1938 prospectus quoted at the beginning of this introduction, Horkheimer highlights two moments of the dialectical logic: first, *reconstruction* of the historical genesis and transformation of certain categories of social thought; second, *application* of these categories to present-day society. These moments roughly correspond to the two levels of Noerr's schema: *reconstruction* would consist in the articulation of a general logic of historical mediation of cultural-intellectual products by fundamental social-economic processes; *application* would consist in "a concrete use of the categories through an historical study" in the "analysis of contemporary society."[31] In the prospectus, Horkheimer takes up the category of freedom:

> Whatever freedom, value, or culture might mean today can only be presented if a critical position is taken towards the existing state of things, demonstrating the extent to which what exists today is freedom in the proper sense and to what extent, contrary to the ruling ideology, what exists is rather compulsion, insecurity, fear, and powerlessness.

In *Eclipse of Reason* (1947), Horkheimer reformulates the process application as the "double-edged" procedure of negation: the evaluation of certain categories in their application to present-day society requires the evaluation of society according to whether it lives up to these categories as ideals.[32] The reality-testing of concepts is simultaneously a conceptual test of reality. In execution, the respective tasks of reconstruction and application are incomplete without the other. Returning to the category of freedom in *Eclipse*, Horkheimer writes:

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[31] "International Institute of Social Research: A Report on its History, Aims and Activities 1933-1938" [1939], *MHA Na 656*, 371. When citing Horkheimer's Nachlass, we have used the format MHA (Max Horkheimer Archive) Na 1 (Nachlass) [digital container number], [page number(s)].

[32] Max Horkheimer, *Eclipse of Reason* (Continuum, 1974 [1947]), 129.

> If it is true that we must know what freedom is in order to determine which parties in history have fought for it, it is no less true that we must know the character of these parties in order to determine what freedom is. [...] The definition of freedom is the theory of history, and vice versa.[33]

Crucial for our purposes is the fact Horkheimer included a third moment in a subsequent revision of the text of the 1938 prospectus, which was repurposed later that year to serve as an abstract for a stand-alone project titled "The Philosophy of Western Society." The abstract concludes:

> Finally, the concepts and their concrete application will lead to a picture of the immanent tendencies in our society. The third part of the work, therefore, will contain a prospectus of the real potentialities for the future development of human existence. It will lay the basis for critical decisions which must be made not in the domain of "pure" science but in the field of praxis.[34]

This pivot to the future and to praxis follows directly from Horkheimer's treatment of the category of freedom in the 1938 prospectus. The past-oriented reconstruction of the changing historical significance of a given category of social thought and the present-oriented application of the category to given society, taken together, generate a structure of anticipation both open-ended and determinate. Whether future society will be legible in terms of categories like freedom depends on the practical intervention of those for whom they play an essential role in a theory of the present—that is, on whether "theory also becomes a material force."[35] In the less coded language of an ISR internal seminar from 1936,

> The idea of socialism is not 'imposed' on us by the available empirical material. [...] The socialist theoretician constructs a model of a possible event which can only be actualized by the will of those involved. [...] Regarding the question of the 'downfall of capitalism': It cannot be determined in advance which stage capitalism is in. This is a consequence of the unique role human activity plays in the sciences of society. The task of the "practitioner," in this case, is to experimentally determine whether this phase of capitalism is truly 'the last and highest phase' or not.[36]

With all three moments of the idea of the dialectical logic in hand, the problem of mediating between abstract logical forms and concrete experiential contents takes on a different character. The question becomes one of historical

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[33] Horkheimer., *Eclipse*, 119.

[34] Max Horkheimer, "The Philosophy of Western Society" [1938], *MHA Na 657*, 297.

[35] Karl Marx, "Contribution to Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Law. Introduction," *Marx & Engels Collected Works Volume 3: Karl Marx March 1843-August 1844*, translated by J. Cohen, C. Dutt, et al. (Lawrence & Wishart [E-Book], 2010), 182.

[36] Excerpt from the minutes of Discussion No. 5 (5/27/1936) in the ISR's Internal Seminar, "The Marxian Method and its Applicability to an Analysis of the Present Crisis." (1936) *MHGS, Bd. 15* (1995), 408-409. Author's translation.

social practice, and the answer, in each case, concerns the changing historical relationship between theory and its practitioners. This is where the dialectical logic acquires its potential practical significance: the unity of theory and practice requires their difference not be forgotten.[37]

One form of historical social practice becomes increasingly important for Horkheimer's approach to the dialectical logic: spoken and written language. In a 1939 discussion of "Copula and Subsumption," one of Horkheimer's earliest fragments for the dialectical logic, Adorno objects to what he considers Horkheimer's overly one-sided, negative assessment of the role of universality in logical operations of identification—namely, given the violence with which the universal is inflicted on particulars and individuals in the process, both logical and social, of judgment. Adorno criticizes Horkheimer for failing to do justice to the latent, utopian dimension in the universality of the copula: "It could always be that this kind of thinking, under the form 'it is,' contains within itself the only possibility of going beyond that which merely is. I cannot imagine a critique that would not also really be this sort of identification." Almost two years later, Horkheimer returns to the topic—only this time, from the utopian side. In a letter to Adorno from 1941, Horkheimer advances his own speculative theory about a performative contradiction inherent to any language that serves particularist domination, shrouding it in universality: "Addressing another in speech essentially means recognizing them as a possible member of a future association of free human beings. [...] The speech of the concentration camp overseer itself is an utter absurdity, regardless of its content, except insofar as it condemns the speaker himself." Adorno responds enthusiastically, recognizing his own earlier objection to "Copula and Subsumption" in Horkheimer's speculations: "I wanted to put in a good word, so to speak, for language. And your latest reflections on language seem to point precisely to this motif."[38] In the course of his conversations with Horkheimer in the late 30s and early 40s about the prospects for a dialectical logic, Adorno arrived at the following formulation for the distinction between critical theory, as heir to speculative philosophy, from the new logical discourses of its

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[37] Cf. Horkheimer, "On the Problem of Truth" (1935): "[T]he knowledge of the falling fighter, insofar as it reflects the structure of the present epoch and the basic possibility of a better one, is not dishonored because humanity succumbs to bombs and poison gasses. [...] The truth is a moment of correct practice. But whoever identifies it directly with success passes over history and makes himself an apologist for the reality dominant at any given time. Misunderstanding the irremovable difference between concept and reality, he reverts to idealism, spiritualism, and mysticism." Max Horkheimer, *Between Philosophy and Social Science: Selected Early Writings*, translated by G.F. Hunter, M.S. Kramer, and J. Torpey (MIT Press, 1993), 199-200.

[38] See "Horkheimer & Adorno—On the Critique of Language (Sept. 1941)." *Substudies* (blog), 8 November 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/horkheimer-and-adornoon-the-critique`

contemporaries: "[if] philosophy as scientific semantics desire[s] to translate speech into logic, then it is left to it as speculative philosophy to bring logic to speech."[39] This goal, the restoration of philosophical logic to historical *logos*, accounts for the trajectory of Horkheimer and Adorno's sporadic engagements with the various projects of philosophical logic—formal or pragmatic, empiricist or phenomenological, special-scientific or ordinary-linguistic—in the early 20th century.

Throughout the 1940s, Horkheimer's fragmentary sketches on topics in dialectical logic would increasingly take their point of departure in language, understood as medium and record of the historical conflict between abstract logical forms and concrete social contents. In *Eclipse of Reason*, Horkheimer even defines the task of critical theory as a kind of critical philology, uncovering traces of the historical experience of class struggle, the perspectives of oppressors and oppressed, preserved and forgotten in our language today.[40] By adopting the standpoint of language as a form of historical social practice, Horkheimer is able to pursue Adorno's suggestion and develop not just the repressive side of abstract logical universality but its utopian side as well. Whereas in "Copula and Subsumption" (1939), Horkheimer protests against the violence of abstract universality imposed on particulars and individuals through the copula, "Trust and History" (1946) ends in a defense, albeit deeply ambivalent, of the identification of human beings with "human" as an abstract universal. It is precisely this abstraction, Horkheimer argues, that contains some memory of the struggle for human community as a concrete universal, which, to be realized, would require recognition of the humanity of non-human nature in a "community of suffering" as well. This is what Hermann Schweppenhäuser calls the utopia of human communication, which is "brought to life through the historical sense that writing preserves in terms such as *communio*, *the Commune*, and *communism as the kingdom of freedom*."[41] Horkheimer's linguistic reformulation of the project of the dialectical logic is consistent with Horkheimer and Adorno's principled reaffirmation of the universal project of revolutionary socialist internationalism in their

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[39] Theodor W. Adorno, *Against Epistemology: A Metacritique. Studies in Husserl and the Phenomenological Antinomies.* Translated by Willis Domingo (Polity, 2013 [Basil Blackwell, 1982]), 39-40.

[40] Horkheimer: "Philosophy must become more sensitive to the muted testimonies of language and plumb the layers of experience preserved in it. Each language carries a meaning embodying the thought forms and belief patterns rooted in the evolution of the people who speak it. It is the repository of the variegated perspectives of prince and pauper, poet and peasant." *Eclipse of Reason* (1974), 117-118.

[41] Hermann Schweppenhäuser, "The concept of language and linguistic presentation in Horkheimer and Adorno" [1986] translated by James Crane, *Critical Theory Working Group Blog* (blog), 22 April 2024. `https://ctwgwebsite.github.io/blog/2024/language/`

unpublished political writings through the end of the 1940s.[42] In *Dialectic of Enlightenment* itself, the utopian universality of the authors' linguistic theory of logic and the revolutionary universalism of the authors' critical socialism meet in the idea of communist free association as "the utopia contained in the concept of reason," the living abolition of the inseparable nexus of class domination and domination of nature, the consummate expression of self-enlightening enlightenment.[43]

3. Reading the Fragments

Though the dialectical logic appears to change drastically between Horkheimer's earliest plans for the project in the 1930s and the last sketches he writes in the late 1940s, the underlying conception remains remarkably consistent despite its amorphousness.[44] Over the course of nearly fifteen years, the project develops in a string of successive variations on a limited but interconnected set of dialectical *topoi.* These topics include, among others: the copula, or the problem of identification and identity; the relationship between universality, particularity, and individuality; the relations between logic and grammar, concept and word, concept and thing, conceptual and non-conceptual; the problem of characterizing dialectics as a "method"; the opposition and identity of realism and nominalism. In each case, "[t]he real life process of society is not something sociologically smuggled into philosophy [...]. It is rather the core of the contents of logic itself."[45] When read

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[42] See "Two Unpublished Fragments by Horkheimer and Adorno" [1946], translated by James Crane, *Critical Theory Working Group Blog* (blog), 30 September 2025. `https://ctwgwebsite.github.io/blog/2025/HA_Fragments_1946/`

[43] Cf. Adorno and Horkheimer's discussion of communism as "the utopia contained in the concept of reason" in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*: "[W]ith the revolutionary avant-garde, the utopia which proclaimed the reconciliation between nature and the self emerge from its hiding place in German philosophy as something at once irrational and reasonable, as the idea of the community of free individuals—and brought down on itself the full fury of reason. [...] The instrument by means of which the bourgeoisie had come to power, the unfettering of forces, universal freedom, self-determination—in short, enlightenment—turned against the bourgeoisie as soon as that class, as a system of rule, was forced to suppress those it ruled. By virtue of its principle, enlightenment does not stop short at the minimum of belief without which the bourgeois world could not exist. It does not render to power the reliable services which had always been performed for it by the old ideologies. Its anti-authoritarian tendency, which communicates, if only subterraneously, with the utopia contained in the concept of reason, finally made it as inimical to the established bourgeoisie as to the aristocracy, with which, indeed, it lost no time in forming alliances." *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (2002), 71-73.

[44] This is already prefigured in the fact that the Institute would immediately repurpose the prospectus for two further project proposals, one titled "The Philosophy of Western Society" (1938) and the other "The Philosophy of Social Science" (1939).

[45] Adorno, *Against Epistemology* (2013), 26.

in an approximately chronological order, the fragments do attest to a gradual evolution of the original conception of the dialectical logic: the project becomes increasingly self-reflexive. In the earlier fragments, Horkheimer reflects primarily on logical operations and operators, especially the copula. In the later fragments, Horkheimer's focus shifts to questions of method, the relationship between language and forms of judgment, and the status of "the concept" as such—in short, to the media of the dialectical logic itself.

The project is also consistent in terms of literary form and style. All of the texts remain fragments that vary in length from a three-sentence sketch to a ten-page essay. The dialectical arguments proceed by way of extremes, chaining together bold declarations and illustrating the abysses between word and thing, thought and act, in the linguistic equivalent of expressionist grotesques. In a 1949 conversation with Kracauer, Adorno defends the difficult style of presentation he developed with Horkheimer by characterizing their technique as follows: "The fault lines the fragments form together are the script that discloses their meaning."[46] Nearly a decade after the publication of *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, Adorno introduces Heinz Krüger's study of the aphorism as a philosophical form with a revealing turn of phrase: aphoristic thinking is "thinking in breaks."[47]

Horkheimer and Adorno's conscious decision to adopt aphoristic form and style at the height of their theoretical collaboration in the 1940s was motivated by, and motivated in turn, a shared conception of critical theory on the model of the critique of political economy. In a 1939 letter, Horkheimer defends their common methodological orientation to a critic of Adorno's recent work, explaining that whenever they struggled to find the relevant material or social-economic mediations that shape a given cultural or intellectual product, they preferred to leave a blank space instead of filling in the gaps with false solutions to the problem:

> We are very conscious of the demand for economic mediation; just as we are of the immense difficulties that stand in the way of this. To replace it, however, with an intellectual-historical [mediation] of the kind you propose would mean falling behind the essay's approach to the subject matter and adopting psychological-historical explanations wherever political economy fails to deliver. We prefer to leave the gaps in mediation like blank spots on a map, and to present the problem as an objective, social one.[48]

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[46] Theodor W. Adorno, "Tagebuch der großen Reise, Oktober 1949 Aufzeichnungen bei der Rückkehr aus dem Exil." In *Frankfurter Adorno Blätter*, No. VIII, 2003, 99. Author's translation.

[47] Theodor W. Adorno, "Introduction to Heinz Krüger's Studies On the Aphorism as Philosophical Form (1956)." *Substudies* (blog), 22 February 2026. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/tw-adornothinking-in-breaks-1956`

[48] Max Horkheimer to Hans Mayer, 3/23/1939. *Substudies* (blog), 6 March 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/i/158485476/13-marxism-and-method`

In 1943, Horkheimer reaffirms that the distinction between critical theory and the prevailing "pluralism" in the human and social sciences is "the critique of political economy, which established dialectical relations between the totality of the social sciences" in a way antithetical to the practice of contemporary "academic groups, a kind of dealing between the different rackets which confirm to one another that they are indispensable."[49] Critical theory is neither pluralist nor monist.[50] It refuses both as complementary pseudo-solutions to the conflict of the faculties, itself an expression of "society as an antagonistic totality."[51] Though most of the fragments revolve around topics from the history of philosophy, the fragments are also reflective of (or at least aspire to be) an approach that could be characterized as non-synthetic multi-disciplinarity. The fragments suddenly shift between a variety of theoretical and scientific discourses but nevertheless seem to lack any unified meta-theoretical perspective. In an unpublished memo on the ISR's empirical social research, Adorno distinguishes the ISR's approach from prevailing customs in "pluralistic" interdisciplinary research, such as the introduction of "factors" from various disciplines (e.g., sociological, psychological, economic factors) that remain external to the research process. Critical theory, to the contrary, treats each object of investigation as "a unifold phenomenon inseparably bound up with the structure of society as a whole" and the different approaches, e.g., sociological or psychological or economic, are kept "as far apart as possible in order to attain ultimate theoretical unity. [...] There is no "synthesis" but only the tilting over of a radical pursuit of a thesis into another field of explanation."[52] Already in his 1928/29 review of Lenin's *Materialism and Empirio-Criticism*, Horkheimer describes the methodological orientation as a kind of "critical seriousness" *in* philosophy that "begins with the barbaric border crossing" *from* philosophy "into economics and politics."[53]

Horkheimer argues for the necessity of this crossing given Lenin's own four-part definition of dialectical logic: first, objects of inquiry must be examined in all of their "mediacies," and according to the criterion of "comprehensiveness" as "a safeguard against mistakes and rigidity"; second, objects of inquiry

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[49] Max Horkheimer to Friedrich Pollock, 10 February 1943, in *MHGS*, Bd. 17 (1996), 423-424. English in original.

[50] See "The Method of Concept-formation in Critical Theory (1941)," *Substudies* (blog), 28 June 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/the-method-of-concept-formation-in`

[51] Adorno to Horkheimer, 12/23/1949. *Theodor W. Adorno, Max Horkheimer. Briefwechsel 1927-1969. Band III: 1945-1969* (2005, Suhrkamp), 395-396.

[52] Theodor W. Adorno, " 'Mammoth Motives,' Notizen zum Verhältnis von Soziologie und Psychologie des Antisemitismus" [1944], *MHA Na 655*, 176-178.

[53] Horkheimer, "On Lenin's *Materialism and Empirio-criticism*" (1928/29). *Substudies* (blog), 24 October 2025. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/max-horkheimeron-lenins-materialism`

must be "taken in [their] development, change, in [their] "self-movement" (as Hegel sometimes puts it)"; third, a full "definition" of an object of inquiry must involve the whole of human praxis, which serves as both a criterion of truth and an index of its practical wants; fourth, "dialectical logic holds that 'truth is always concrete, never abstract.' "[54] Horkheimer's conception of dialectical logic as "a material doctrine of categories" in the 1938 prospectus applies these four demands to the categories of social theory and science, including Marxism itself.[55] In unpublished materials for a draft of the preface to the late-1960s republication of *Dialectic of Enlightenment*, Adorno would characterize the book as an attempt to do just that.[56]

As mentioned in passing above, when read chronologically, the fragments seem to suggest their own pattern of interpretation. The thematic focus shifts from the history of logical forms (of judgment), as in "Copula and Subsumption" (1939), to the relationship between logical forms and language, as in "Original Sin and Copula" and "Haupt- und Nebensatz" (1942/44), and finally to questions concerning the dialectical method and the fundamental categories of dialectical thinking, up to "the concept" as such, as in nearly all of the fragments written post-1944. These three thematic foci converge in "Trust in History" (1946). Since the other fragments either anticipate the essay or continue to inhabit its conceptual milieu, "Trust in History" is a virtual center of gravity for the collection as a whole and can therefore serve as an interpretive key. Consulting "Trust in History" whenever the other shorter fragments break off, often very abruptly, is strongly recommended. In lieu of a conclusion, I wanted to offer readers a list of "checks" they might find useful to perform while reading the fragments, an exercise I've come to rely on in my own work. First, check whether and how the three essential moments of the original conception of the dialectical logic (reconstruction, application, anticipation) play a role in the fragment. Second, check whether and how historical forms of social practice, including language itself, mediate between abstract logical forms and concrete social contents. Third, check whether and how "universality" or "the universal" undergoes inversions in value as its

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[54] "Once Again on the Trade Unions: The Current Situation and the Mistakes of Trotsky and Bukharin" (1921), V.I. Lenin, *Collected Works*, Vol. 32. (Moscow : Progress Publishers, 1973), 94.

[55] Despite the close parallels between Lenin's fourfold definition of dialectical logic in "Once Again on the Trade Unions" (1921), the text Horkheimer cites in both his notes for the 1928/29 review and the review itself, and Horkheimer's 1938 prospectus, the connection has not been sufficiently acknowledged in previous secondary literature. For Horkheimer's previously unpublished notes for the essay, see: "Horkheimer: Notes on Lenin and Method (1928/29)," translated by James Crane, in *Substudies* (blog), 20 March 2026. `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/horkheimer-notes-on-lenin-and-method`

[56] Theodor W. Adorno, "Aus einem Entwurf »Zur Neuausgabe« der Dialektik der Aufklärung Frankfurt a.M., Februar 1969," *Frankfurter Adorno Blätter VIII* (edition text + kritik, 2003), 7-8.

double-sided character, both repressive and utopian, is progressively developed.

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Program: 'A Dialectical Logic' (1938)[57]

The guiding concern of the work is not a formalist epistemology, but a material doctrine of categories. In scientific and political discussions about social problems, there are certain categories which are used constantly, but which nevertheless give rise to differences of opinion as soon as a more precise definition is called for. Such categories include concepts like causality, tendency, progress, law, necessity, freedom, class, culture, value, ideology, dialectic, and so forth. The equivocal and vague use of such concepts has resulted in the fact that whenever they seem to have been given an unambiguous definition in philosophy or psychology, the definition is in fact merely abstract—so abstract that no further meaning can be attributed to them. One influential philosophical school of the present, so-called logical empiricism, accordingly declares all such concepts utterly meaningless. True, these words have been terribly abused; at times, even misused for dogmatic and narrow-minded metaphysics. However, the prevailing fashion of simply discarding them can only reinforce the reigning confusion and helplessness of the intellect. In truth, all of these concepts have a correct meaning, though never one that can be defined once and for all with the very same words. Concepts cannot be treated the same way the Egyptians once did their corpses, as if by means of the technique of definition they could be embalmed and preserved intact for millennia. The desire for such security can never be fulfilled in the realm of spirit. The content of the foundational categories of the philosophy of history can only be determined by their exact relationship to the historical course of the present. These categories can only be preserved on the condition that they are not embalmed but are instead kept alive through the continuous effort of relating them back to reality. Whatever freedom, value, or culture might mean today can only be presented if a critical position is taken towards the existing state of things, demonstrating the extent to which what exists today is freedom in the proper sense and to what extent, contrary to the ruling ideology, what exists is rather compulsion, insecurity, fear, and powerlessness. Every determination of philosophical concepts involves the presentation of human society in its socially given condition. In this respect, the planned book will approach logic in a similar way to Hegel's great work—namely, not a mere enumeration of abstract forms of thought, but rather a determination of the

[57] Max Horkheimer, "Idee, Aktivität und Programm des Instituts für Sozialforschung" [1938], in *Gesammelte Schriften* (hereafter cited as *MHGS*), ed. Gunzelin Schmid Noerr, vol. 12, *Nachgelassene Schriften 1931–1949* (Fischer Taschenbuch Verlag, 1985), 156–57. Cf. the Institute's original 1938 English-language typescript, "An Institute for Social Research: Idea, Activity, and Program," transcribed and ed. James Crane, in "Collection: The Idea of an Institute for Social Research: Reports 1938–1944," *Substudies* (blog), June 9, 2025, `https://jamescrane.substack.com/p/collection-the-idea-of-an-institute`.

most decisive, content-laden categories of the most progressive consciousness of the present.

I. Copula and Subsumption (1939).

Copula and Subsumption (1939)[58]

Discursive logic is completely focused on the opposition of universal and particular. According to it, language has to raise temporal events to atemporal concepts, multiplicity to unity; the business of language *par excellence* is subsumption. Science follows, formulating the invariants that recur in such events. Propositions that express invariants are called laws. Thus, discursive logic returns to a historyless actuality, however much the universal may subsequently be differentiated in relation to new special cases. The idea of a fixed order of kinds, the secret presupposition that, fundamentally, nothing changes, is inseparable from discursive logic. Language makes the new appear as old; it proves that all is given in the framework of that which has always been. Language stamps.

What this function has to signify, to what extent it's objectively grounded—the truth of language has been up for debate since philosophy first began. According to the realistic conception, the universal, and indeed only the universal, exists. The first philosophers taught: there is but one great thing: Water, Fire, Air. Language makes the senses—according to which what is given is not the one but the many—see reason. It says: the tree is water, the house is water, the heavens are water, the only thing that exists is water. What the "is" signifies, the specific Being of the *arché*, is not discussed. Particular modes of existence cannot be thought. The distinction between the first Being and individual things *is* not, because individual things, taken for themselves, *are* not; because they *are* merely the first Being itself. All speech, however diverse it may sound, is fundamentally the same gesture of pointing to the individual with the one expression: Water—Water; Air—Air; and so on.

When later instead of just the one *arché* several were adopted, the affair became more complicated without, however, changing in principle. The individual thing was no longer the universal substance, but a mixture of substances. Take, for example, the concepts of 'having' and 'properties.' A thing has several properties; it is a mixture of several elements. Contradiction enters—without, however, becoming explicit. The same logical function is sufficient for relating all individual things to a single *arché*. If, however, this individual thing "is" fire in the same exact way it "is" water, the distinction of principles is negated. They have no being apart from being in the individual,

[58] Horkheimer, "Kopula und Subsumtion" [1939], in *MHGS* 12:69–74.

which, for itself, is not. But the inherence is formulated through the copula, and discursive logic knows only the one. Language, in its Being, drives to monism and identity philosophy.

The successors of the nature-philosophers de-substantialized the substances; the relation of the one *Weltding* to the many individuals was transposed into that of the universal to the particular. Beyond the universal is not. As soon as one speaks, a particular is designated as a universal. Apart from this, one cannot speak, except, at most, to give names. In the traditional sense, cognition always refers back to an unchanging, timeless Being—even if the contrary is asserted. If the claim is abandoned that every proposition must adapt itself to the schema of subsumption, the subsumption of a particular subject by means of the copula under a preformed predicate-concept, then formal logic ceases to be universal. It is especially committed to the postulate that verbal statements must be capable of translation into substantive ones. Every event "is" a special case of its genus. The proposition *"he hates"* reduces the occurrence to abstract hate, which does not itself hate, but "is," in the sublimated mode of being of the universal "is," understood according to the thingly Being of the *arché.* According to formal logic, there is only one activity: *"to be,"* and "to be" is no real activity, no spontaneity, but rather the timeless duration of the genus derived from sheer thingly insistence, an eternal sameness.

Were the verbal statements not regarded as equivalent to the predicative propositions into which they are translatable, there would be as many logics as there are verbs. The logical relation of words would no longer be restricted to relationships such as encompassing and encompassed, universal and particular, substance and accident. There would be as many logical relationships as constellations in reality. Aristotle and Hegel are not distinguished with respect to the tendency to identify logic and metaphysics, but are distinguished in that the former encloses the world in simple and fixed boundaries and restricts it to the rigid hierarchy of a world that his logical laws reflect. Hegel, however, sought to raise differentiated, historical reality to speech through logic; but, of course, in the end, he sank it back down into the Eleatic night. Hegel's logic too serves the philosophy of identity.

Nominalism believes itself far removed from these difficulties. According to nominalism, the copula has only the subjective function of memory. "He is an executioner" means he's displayed certain traits here and there. The "is" says nothing about him nor about his victim, but describes the relation between my present impression and my memory. I am only ever thinking, only ever speaking about the relation between my impressions and my ordering-system, but never really about other human beings themselves. According to realism, language points to some spectral reality behind time, whereas in nominalism

the copula fulfills the function of affixing signs or markers to appearances that bring the event into connection not with reality but to our system of signs or markers as a whole. Language no longer signifies anything outside itself; the reference to the fixed order of kinds, which both schools retain in their conception, has no meaning outside this very kind of referral. In speech, especially in science, nothing is truly meant and expressed, but merely "operated." According to nominalism, language is mute. There is no specific relationship of word and thing in the sense of expression, significance, meaning, and so forth. One can—according to the older nominalism—investigate the psychological relations of value-representations and other phenomena of consciousness; one can—according to the newer nominalism—establish the physical relations of words, brain processes, facial movements, and other things, each of which is the concern of a different specialization. The distinction, however, between an object and something that would not be an object at all is meaningless. What follows from nominalism is the omnipotence of positive science and, indeed, the impossibility of putting it into question. Kant's attempt to simultaneously recognize and delimit physics and nominalism went far beyond nominalism. His assertion of the autonomy of the person is burdened with all the problems of realism. It returns the transient reality of the empirical human being to the level of eternal Being.

The nominalists would rather not pose the question of the truth of language in language. Instead, they would much rather describe what takes place in science or popular judgments. They replace philosophy, the critique of specialist knowledge, with apology. They are without bias and adapt their representations of logic to whatever use the professors make of it; they pick up their examples of cognition from the latter. If the scientific community were to conduct itself differently, no doubt these philosophers would find it to be just as good. On the basis of such experience, they subsume thinking under the concept of "operating," which is perfectly suited for precisely such linguistic commerce. The so-called 'rules of the game' of thinking, which nominalism touts as laws, the axioms of formal logic, depict something crucial about actual language as much as the physical law of inertia depicts something crucial about an actual revolution.

The dispute over universals has nothing whatsoever to do with the universality of discursive logic. With few exceptions, both parties have taken it for granted that the reduction of the new to the familiar is the function of language. In language so understood, all of the concepts one might need to grasp anything are already available. Even the *ars inveniendi* is bound to the *mathesis universalis*, just as the forces of production are bound to the form of existing society. The defense of language against barbarians transforms into enmity against spontaneity. The "is" in the proposition about the executioner

means, at bottom, that his property is grounded in the nature of the thing, that it cannot be otherwise. In the sense of the Platonic myth, he chose the character of the executioner for himself before he was born and now leads the life of the executioner by necessity. The addition of a temporal index that limits the quality to a moment or to a year or to a decade or etc., leaves the function of the "is" wholly unaffected. In this case, the inescapable refers to the given span. He cannot change; for it is not his *changing* but his *being* that functions as copula. At best, the propositions that 'A' is an executioner at point [I.] and 'A' is a minister at point [II.] can both be correct. The identity of 'A' cannot be maintained in a strict sense; because, according to discursive logic, 'A' must equal 'A' ("if two quantities are equal to a third, then they are equal amongst themselves"), it would have to follow that ministers are executioners. Contradictions are far removed from such logic; it eliminates the identity of the person and stands by the immutability of the system. The concepts remain separated, whatever might occur in reality. The "is" in the language of discursive logic stems from the Being of a spectral nature.

Today, human relationships correspond to the use of language. The question—which, according to Schopenhauer, outstrips all others in importance—is asked: *what one is.* One has conversations whose only meaning is finding this out, and the state apparatus has the tendency to adapt this logic. One is a Red, a Jew, a Fascist, a Coward, a Trotskyist, a Foreigner—and one's happiness and unhappiness hang in the balance of such a verdict. One is to be subsumed, seized, classified, imprisoned, and killed accordingly. Discursive logic celebrates its triumphs: the determination and classification, the "statement," the provable statement really counts for something. And what could be easier to prove than what costs someone their head. What could save them—tends to be insight into other orders.

Discussion (with Adorno) of Max Horkheimer's Manuscript for "Copula and Subsumption" (October 2nd, 1939).[59]

Adorno: The entire way of posing the question presupposes the ontological dignity of the copula. The decisive thing would be an analysis of the copula with the aim of determining whether there is such an ontological dignity of the copula and how it relates to the claim of the positivists that the copula has absolutely no content.

Horkheimer: In the history of logic and of German idealism, [the idea is that] the copula would really lead to the essence of the concept of the subject.

[59] Horkheimer, "Diskussion anschließend an das Manuskript von Max [Horkheimer] über Kopula and Subsumtion (1939)", *MHGS* 12:494-498.

Example: This is a human being. The concept of the genus functions as the essence, and the copula has the function of placing the individual under the essence and [at the same time] conferring reality to the essence. The subsumption of the individual under the essence amounts to the annihilation of the individual. "[The] real is simply the essence." The individual is canceled out in speech. That is how it is in Hegel: that which is no longer subsumable is worthless existence.

Adorno: The grounding though is that the meaning of being principally presents a determinate relation of the kind that every time one says "it is," it is asserted that "it" falls under something that was already there.

Horkheimer: It's about the interpretation of being, namely with the attempt [to understand] what really happens when one says of something, "it is."

Adorno: The moment of identity is, at base, already hidden in being as the subsumption of the particular under the essence. That which here and now 'is,' 'is' self-same. The concept of being is thereby entirely reduced to the function of identity.

Horkheimer: Objection: if I say, "that [fellow] is an irate man," I am only bringing something to the attention of others. By intention, I am not subsuming, but rather only indicating the new under the form of what was already there.

Adorno: Your theory is a monstrous attack on language. Is what lies at hand in language not dialectical? If I name something, is that always merely an analytical function? Does the copula always mean the self-same in all possible cases?

Horkheimer: If it doesn't always do that, then we arrive at a kind of pluralism: sometimes the copula has that function, and sometimes it does not, so what I call uniform logic is broken apart. How should the other relationship be? I honor language very highly; I take it very seriously.

Adorno: In Hegel there is also the motif: everything is what it is, and, for that very reason, not what it is.

Horkheimer: That is, however, at base only an everlasting process of rectification, an ever more concrete and differentiated identification. The whole system still comes down to the subsumption of everything that is, and

thus to being. In Hegel, "is" can only really be predicated of being itself. Even now, I still have the notion—which I really ought to get rid of—that language claims to designate that which is.

Adorno: It could always be that this kind of thinking, under the form "it is," contains within itself the only possibility of going beyond that which merely is. I cannot imagine a critique that would not also really be this sort of identification. The logic in which we live is a kind of wall before reality. We are so enclosed within it that any escape from it other than one which would, at the same time, remain inside it is impossible. Your text awakens the feeling that we would really need to have a different language.

Horkheimer: I think that is only one side of the matter, but it is extremely difficult to describe the other. The nominalist exit is bad, a bad regress into the infinite.

Adorno: The manuscript differentiates between ontology and nominalism. I would say that if this analysis of the copula applies, then the difference between ontology and nominalism itself would be inapplicable. They both involve recognizing, subsuming.

Horkheimer: That's how it is in my work.

Adorno: But this would also mean that we cannot differentiate between ontology and nominalism at all.

Horkheimer: They both accept the structure.

Adorno: Then what does it mean to speak of ontology and of a metaphysical concept of being, if being is nothing other than the function of identity? How can we ascribe substantiality to the concept of being?

Horkheimer: Language reduces itself to pointing.

Adorno: Can we really give ontological weight to the concept of being, as you are urging, if being is only a subsuming under that which was already there?

Horkheimer: It seems to me, however, that there is still something else tucked away into this being, namely the reference to the thing, the natural thing. If one were to speak of the being of the genus, of the known or of the

old, then this would involve the permanence of eternal nature, in which—in a certain sense—everything should remain old.

Adorno: The logician can still resolve that by labeling this element of being as mere fetishization of the function of identity and excluding it.

Horkheimer: The order is, however, the reverse: there is not first of all the function of identity, which is then fetishized; rather the belief in eternal or substantial being is first, and then, only insofar as this is taken as the ground of the matter, can the function of identity be constituted at all. The gods were not invented on the basis of what was actual, rather they had to be presupposed in order for the concept of a univocal reality to be upheld at all. I do not mythologize identical being, but I can only attribute a meaning to identical being if I go back to such processes.

Adorno: Constellation of logic and myth: logic is mythical. Logical thinking is pre-logical thinking. The compulsion of logic as system is the moment of compulsion in nature, to which we have succumbed. There are, therefore, effectively two possible interpretations of logic:

1. The copula means nothing: positivists, blank space.

2. Language is given over to blind nature through becoming fixed. As I wrest this one thing away from nature and single it out as a being-for-itself, I thereby push it back into nature, as in this I say nothing other than: this is the very nature under which I subsume it.

Horkheimer: It seems to me that, in this world, language always relates everything to an order just as bad as that which the world itself presents. A better language only seems possible in a better world—in which it would, however, no longer be necessary. You can always argue that language as a whole does indeed convey something that goes beyond this.

Adorno: Hegel says that being as the function of identity is actually nothing at all, just as in positivism. He concludes from this that being is at the same time nothing. Isn't it precisely because being is nothing but this subsuming, precisely because it 'is not,' that the thorn is thereby added to it, to the principle of subsumption posited in itself, which makes it otherwise?

Horkheimer: In saying "that is that," it is really negated once again. It becomes—but no more—*it is*. The dialectic of being, nothing, and becoming occupies, in a certain sense, a unique place in the Hegelian dialectic as

a whole. Hegel says: when we subsume something, this is only possible because the genus is a kind of intersection. The positing of being and its identification with nothing is, however, much more abstract than everything that comes later.

Adorno: The beginning of Hegel's logic means: being, simple being without any further determination. No proposition. He sets up the copula in its abstractness, without relating it to a *tode ti* ['a this']. I don't believe Hegel began with being by accident. The meaning rests on the withdrawnness of the being of the *tode ti*.

Horkheimer: The secret, the highest category for him and for the entirety of discursive logic is being; the copula must be subsumed under itself.

Adorno: Either nothing or nature is hypostatized. You have said it is a miracle that we can say or think anything at all that isn't technical-administrative. I would say that the complete nothingness of this "is" is the fact that being is nothing other than subordination under something determinate, such that it has, in a certain way, turned against the operation that is thereby performed. Also implicit in logic is that this subsumption is nothing. This non-being of subsumption means that every individual identity is afflicted by an illness. Hegel recognized that this concept of being, having no content, is completely void, that every finite subsumption is false or inadequate.

Horkheimer: But in Hegel, there are continuous corrections. Every isolated proposition is false. Language, however, reinstates its rights once more, it makes up for it in the end. For if it did not, propositions would lose their sense.

Adorno: Hegel was very clever not to put the existential claim at the beginning of the logic. In actuality he was doing phenomenology! When he talks about being at the beginning, this is precisely an attempt to not predicate being of being itself. In a certain sense, we cannot get out of discursive logic, but in another we can nevertheless go beyond it.

Horkheimer: The aversion to speaking is linked to the aversion to predicative thinking.

II. Concepts for the *Philosophical Fragments (1944)*

Original Sin and Copula (1942/44)[60]

The crux of the problem of language is hidden in the copula. At bottom, language is incomprehensible because the copula is incomprehensible.

One side of the copula is relating everything new to the fixed hierarchy of kinds, the silencing of history. There is something akin to reconciliation in this: the fear of the totally foreign and isolated is dispelled. It is brought under the protection of what lasts.

It is this reflection that first grants the logical categories their meaning. Positivism removes the poison from questions like *"What is truth? What is universal and particular? What is thinking?"*—here too, the answer lies in definition, as all judgments are merely analytic. Such evasion can only be countered by pointing to the fact that there is a relationship to power at stake in these questions. The questions really do demand an answer to whether and to what extent categories participate in the highest good. It is not for nothing that the theory of the neoplatonists, that concepts are emanations of God, was held in high respect by the sharpest minds for centuries. It betrays an abyssal insight into the relation between logic and theology.

Being and Power are indissoluble; even the Stoics and Spinoza knew this. No great European philosopher has been able to dissolve this relationship. Kant's synthetic judgments *a priori* are an attempt to rescue truth without anchoring it in power. He paid for this with the metaphysical obscurity of his concept of pure original apperception and the absence of any principles for the discovery of the categories, the two greatest weaknesses of his theoretical philosophy.

However, an abyss has opened between Being and Power in history, and so truth exists only in negation. This insight is the heart of Hegel's philosophy—so far as it does not, like Baron von Münchhausen, pull itself out of the water by its own pigtails and, with the deification of determinate negation, with its assumption into the absolute, return to neoplatonism. Transcendental logic did not ignore the doctrine of original sin and, despite its ontological method, became the critique of ontology. Conversely, dialectical logic wanted to be ontology, whereas its method was the clearest expression of breaking with it. In restoring history, in good Christian fashion, into the guaranteed vehicle of truth and redemption, it reinstated the copula in all its injustice.

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[60] Horkheimer, "Erbsünde und Kopula (1942)," *MHGS*, 12: 277–278.

Haupt- und Nebensatz (1942/44).[61] [62]

Dependent clauses belong to the juristic, argumentative phase of thinking. Primitives and totalitarians talk in independent clauses. "The Jew will be burnt." In differentiated social systems one at least says, "the Jew, if he does not convert…" "the slave, who has stolen…" or "a murderer, whosoever he be…" There is a connection between humaneness [*Humanität*] and dependent clauses. As dubious social practice left its mark on all areas of spirit, the concept of the universality of law, as it was mediated in such dependent clauses, pointed out ideology, and so pointed beyond it. When dependent clauses fall, the idea of universality that exists in their mediation falls with them.

Even so, philosophy cannot exempt itself from the tendency towards the independent clause; it is able to reverse this development as little as any other byproducts of decline. Its adherence to outdated linguistic custom lends philosophy a character of harmlessness and the existing order a sheen of humaneness. Argument, restraint, and artful construction lose their weight. The style of theory becomes simpler, though because in doing so it denounces the very simplicity it consciously adopts by mirroring the barbaric process. The style approximates the rackets with the force of hatred and thus becomes their opposite. Its logic becomes as summary as their justice, as crude as their lies, as conscienceless as their agents—and, in this opposition to barbarism, becomes specific, exact, and scrupulous. The distinctionless designation of the essential being of society as the embodiment of rackets is infinitely differentiated, since it summarily denounces the distinctionless brutality against powerlessness. The generalization and simplification of philosophy, which, in the eradication of even one innocent, forgets that the millions who allowed this to happen survive it, displays no lack of subtlety. In omission of the dependent clause that relativizes the mutilation of humanity, it attributes

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[61] Horkheimer, "Haupt- und Nebensatz" (1942/44), *MHGS*, 12: 279–281.

[62] [Translators Note:] This piece turns on a distinction in German grammar which does not have an exact analogue in English. The German word *Satz* refers to both 'sentences' and 'clauses.' The latter are divided into two types: *Hauptsatz* and *Nebensatz*. With regard to their function in sentence structure, they are basically analogous to independent and dependent clauses in English, but they are differentiated by different word orders in a way distinct from English. In a *Hauptsatz*, the 'first' verb (i.e. either the sole 'main' verb or the 'first' modal or auxiliary verb) always occupies the 'second position,' with the subject and object(s) able to occupy any other 'position' (except for the 'final' one, which will be occupied by the other verbs—in a particular order, of course—if there are any other verbs, and then finally the detachable prefix of the 'first' verb, if there is one). In a *Nebensatz*, on the other hand, the 'first' verb always comes last, immediately following the other verbs if there are any, and with its detachable prefix still attached, while the subject and object(s) can again be in any position except the 'final' one. This grammatical feature makes *Nebensätze* markedly distinct from the *Hauptsätze* to which they are attached.

absoluteness to the horror that emanates from this. The subtlest shade of pleasure is sacred to philosophy. In the lack of any in-depth description of the apparatus, in the absence of syntactic conjunction for the *why* and *because* and *when* of the night in which one victim is like the other becomes eloquent in philosophy. Reformism reaches for statistics; for cognition, one concentration camp is enough.

Any description of the concentration camp that draws fine distinctions between different categories of inmate and the respective kinds of abuse to which they will be subject, any description that follows closely the official motives and statistics in the reports from those institutions of hell, as if they were just one more object of study for political science—already participates in its apology, like the Catholic clerks who propagated the legality and ecclesiastical order of the Inquisition. Since the war began, the atrocities 'over there' have been handled summarily, even when with caution. But they aren't the reason that war broke out. Domination declared war because it was threatened, not because the dominated were murdered. The atrocities were not the impetus, not by any means; it was rather the unworkable demands made on capital. Just think of how much more convenient it would have been if they could come to an agreement with *reasonable* hangmen, with the hangmen they already have at home. They forget that fascist practice only condescends to specification in the face of actual power, not when confronted with the unarmed competition. Before weakness, domination becomes totalitarian. Powerlessness can be subsumed so easily. The worthy competitor is only fought openly where no understanding between well-matched forces is possible. In himself, he is entitled to a dependent clause.

Reversal of the Idealist Dialectic (1944)[63]

On close inspection, Hegel's doctrine that the concept is *the "inner side" of the thing itself*, performed as the idealist dialectic, transforms into the materialist of its own accord. It's like certain optical illusions: if you stare at them long enough, they reverse into another figure, just as much the image you see before you as the one you were just looking at. Turning Hegel right side up, from head to foot, was only so compelling because he was already standing.

[63] Horkheimer, "Umschlag der idealistischen Dialektik" (1944), *MHGS* 12:286.

III. Miscellaneous Fragments on Dialectical Logic (1945)

Principle of the Individual (ca. 1945)[64]

The individual is not a natural but a spiritual being. It necessarily involves reflection on itself as a principle separate from others, possessing a special connection to itself as distinct from life in general. Without the "I," there is no individual.

Leibniz was intimately familiar with this relation. Indeed, he made his monads the elements of the universe, which they reflect. But insofar as naked monads, unconscious of themselves, from which dead things are composed, merely exhibit a negative, suffering, they are only monads in possibility, individuals in-themselves, in contradiction to their own essential being, pure activity as mere suffering. With this contradiction, the biological and historical process of development is set into motion that ultimately brings them to consciousness. Knowledge alone overcomes the contradiction and makes the living substance into what it originally is—individual.

The real, which Leibniz called "monad," Hegel called "concept." The concept becomes aware of itself as the individual acts and learns, through its participation in the universal process of development, what it is. Through the subjectivity of individuals, the substantial is actualized. Yet this historical process perpetuates itself in the death of individuals. Substance endures not as individual but as genus. Hegel turns the ephemerality of the individual into the ground of its own relative worthlessness. The principle by which the contradiction finally reveals itself is not the substantial form of the individual, but rather the totality per se. Insofar as the individual thinks the truth, it remains something abstract, not simply because of the social coinage of his thoughts, but because of the boundedness of his factual existence.

The difference between the Leibnizian and Hegelian systems is the difference between pantheism and theology. The question is: whether the progression of the dialectic beyond the individual to the genus, from the individual to the course of history as a whole, from the particular life to the closed totality, is not, in fact, the same as stepping back from the good into the bad infinity, from the essential into sheer quantity. (Which must, for Hegel, add up!)

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[64] Horkheimer, "Prinzip des Individuums" [undated; editors assign 'probable' date of 1942], *MGHS* 12:318–319. Because the dating of the fragment in MHA Na 803, 'NY Notizen [I],' is '1945,' in the absence of any indication of an earlier date of composition, the date '1945' has been retained.

The Golden Mean (1945)[65]

The dialectical method could easily be understood as one of 'the golden mean.' Some proposition—for example, 'true thinking is that of madness'—is spoken. This provokes a counter-thesis, which cancels [*zurücknimmt*] the concept of 'madness' and determines what kind of 'madness' or what features of 'madness' were meant. One could just as well have asserted the reverse, that healthy common sense is true, such that common sense would then be cancelled, to the point it no longer bore any resemblance to English philosophy. Accordingly, the much-vaunted sublation of opposites would in reality be the sanding-off of extremes, steering towards some *juste milieu*.

This view is not as entirely incorrect as we dialecticians would like to imagine. The description strips the method down to a minimum—which, of course, decides everything. What guides the dialectician in cancellation or negation is neither aversion to extremes nor inclination to plausibility, but is rather the fact that he never comes to terms with the existence of hopelessness and horror. This generates the scope and direction of the negation. The determination of truth-as-madness is incorrect because madness is as much in harmony with what exists as is healthy common sense. Madness, therefore, is not negated insofar as it is extreme, but insofar as it is identical with its opposite—that is, insofar as it is not extreme at all.

The same can be shown for all dialectical theorems. That the dialectical method, which is one of extremes, approaches the golden mean when stripped down to a minimum, has its counterparts in other areas, for example, in the aesthetic and the political.

The Dialectical Concept (1945)[66]

The quickest way to determine the difference between dialectical and undialectical thinking is as follows: in undialectical thinking, concepts are established by definitions, and any new cognition results in the expansion of their real scope; in dialectical thinking, however, new cognition constitutes an attack on the significance of the concept itself. Concepts need not, therefore, be tossed out as old scrap.

Of course, the distinction only becomes intelligible if it is made clear that in dialectical thinking each concept stands for the truth. The dialectical progression only ever comes about through negation of the absolute claim of concepts and judgments; thus, concepts and judgments which make no such claim are, in logical terms, sheer nonsense. At bottom, undialectical thinking

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65 Horkheimer, "Goldener Mittelweg," *MHGS* 12:297.

66 Horkheimer, "Der dialektische Begriff," *MHGS* 12: 299–301.

has the same intention, only, in its resignation, it has given up and forgotten. In ceasing to reflect on the movement through which thinking is actually constituted, in relegating such concern to psychology, which, in absence of such reflection, is just as nonsensical, the integrative development, i.e., spirit, is driven out of concepts, which are transformed from thoughts into mere containers, things—not even signs, since a sign is only a sign at all by virtue of the intellectual intention it awakens. (Susanne Langer overlooks what's decisive.)[67]

What is becoming more manifest in social reality with each passing day was latent within bourgeois thinking from the beginning: the liquidation of development. One need only consider the concept of truth. Once defined, for example, as *adaequatio intellectus et rei*, there is nothing more to be learned about or beyond this highest idea at which all intellectual interest aims. In relation to this idea, the sole task left to thinking is the mechanical testing of whether a given proposition does or does not correspond to it; the conditions for this procedure are compiled in so-called logic. Opposed to this stands the assumption that we cannot yet know what the truth is, because cognition [*Erkenntnis*] is not finished. According to the latter view, the intellectual process consists not in the mere augmentation or correction of individual truths, one in which the purely formal concept of truth would itself remain untouched; rather, the material progression of the process affects the formal category, i.e., the distinction between formal and material is continuously sublated.

What holds for the concept of truth does for other concepts as well. Both are intimately connected. Apart from their essential identity with truth, fulfilled in each case through intellectual mediation, the relation between each concept and its object is governed by the concept of truth as well. If, however, this is not conclusively [*abschlußhaft*] fixed through definition, the relation between each individual concept and its object can no longer, therefore, be fixed through conclusive formal-logical propositions. The structure of logic is swept up in the course of objective cognition, just as, conversely, each step of objective cognition bears the problematic of the scope and significance of its advance with respect to conceptual relations of the highest order.

Not only does this reinforce the weight of the empirical, on which the ultimate questions now depend, but also reins it in, since these questions, with all of their demands and concerns, are henceforth implied in each act of empirical

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[67] [*MHGS* 12, Ed. Note:] Cf. Susanne Langer, *Philosophy in a New Key* (1942), especially chapters 2 and 3; in her critique of utilitarian theories of language, Langer distinguishes between (symptomatic) signs and (representative) symbols. [Translator's Note:] In a letter to Pollock dated 3/21/1944, Horkheimer requests a copy of Langer's *Philosophy in a New Key*, MHA Na 581, 287r .

cognition. It should not be imagined that so-called empirical research is abandoned in dialectical logic. If what is called empirical research today is nothing more than the barren product of abstraction as represented in the bad separation of formal logic and material experience, and which tends, particularly in the social sciences, towards empty activity, then concrete thinking first comes into its own in the liquefaction of that opposition. Whereas in "research," the subject matter is supposedly viewed without prejudice, but is actually viewed according to the schemata established through the economic division of labor, dialectics experiences in each instance the subject matter solely *sub specie* its philosophical interest, and, for that very reason, in relative freedom from the distortions of industrial conceptuality. For dialectics, appearance is always the perception of nature cut off from adequate expression, which dialectics itself would help to remedy.[68] The attempt to understand what is, nevertheless, incapable of expression leads to speculation as a process in which the traditional dualisms are not blurred, but continuously reconfigured in their relations.

Preservation of Naïveté in Dialectics (1945)[69]

The dialectical spirit has a different relation to naïveté than the undialectical. The latter relates to naïveté in simple opposition: always and immediately seeking to discover conditions, causes, components, relationships of a given feeling or thing, and, even before it has discovered these, confronts givens with the anticipatory certitude that they are merely the effect of something else; that everything immediate and particular is merely a sign of the mediated and universal. The latter, that is, prescribes reification, in contrast to the naïve, who remains at the mercy of appearances.

Dialectics, however, distinguishes. It transforms naïveté without annihilating it. Like science, it too 'gets behind' the things, but it also preserves—and, indeed, rescues—the enchantment that emanates from them. Knowledge of relationships, transience, and illusoriness does not become a motive to apathy, as it does for Stoicism. This is the consequence of Hegel's fundamental principle that in each successive mediation the preceding stage, i.e., the more immediate, should be sublated. There is more to this instruction than something 'logical' in the older sense. It implies that in the true enlightenment, that which is identical to philosophy, mythology is not shouted over and drowned out. Rather, its power is appeased, brought to rest.

Dialectics, like reflective behavior in general, resists the worship of the dead,

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[68] [Translator's Note:] Cf. Max Horkheimer, *Eclipse of Reason.* (Continuum, 2004 [1974]; Oxford University Press, 1947), 127.

[69] Horkheimer, "Bewahrung der Naivetät in der Dialektik," *MHGS* 12:301–302.

but is nevertheless no stranger to the foolishness of handling things gently even when they cannot feel anything. In the refusal of blind domination of nature, the dialectical spirit escapes domination by nature, without, however, cutting things off from the possibility of enchanting it. The preservation of naïveté in thinking is what Kant gave the name of intellectual intuition and wanted to reserve for the Godhead alone. His successors sought to recover it for human beings by creating the dialectical method. If therapeutic psychology were what it should be, it would concentrate its efforts on uncovering the moments in individual and historical life through which power (in the figure of the father or the political ruler) made human beings incapable of devotion to things to leave them all the more securely at the mercy of things. In this function, psychology would become an instrument of philosophy once again.

IV. Trust in History (October, 1946)[70]

For the thinking of the enlightenment, society appeared as an association [*Vereinigung*] of human beings for the sake of their self-assertion in nature. "Necessity brings human beings together and associates them," says Montaigne, who is able to appeal to the old empiricists for this. "This accidental association is afterwards transformed through laws... ."[71] According to Voltaire, it was the needs which, along with the passions and reason, led the first beings out of their condition of savagery.[72] Almost as soon as human beings first entered into association with each other, however, the cleverest among them took advantage of the rest, of their desire for well-being and their arrogance.

> Early on, people were divided into two classes: the first, those divine men who sacrifice their self-love for the public good; the second, the miserable ones who loved only themselves: everyone wanted and wants still to belong to the first class, although, at the bottom of their hearts, everyone belongs to the second; and the most cowardly and selfish cried out louder than all the others that everything must be sacrificed at the altar of the commonwealth. The desire to command, a kind of arrogance, as detectable in a schoolyard bully or village mayor as in a Pope or a Caesar, is a powerful spur to human industry, for through it men are brought to heel by others.[73]

The darker drives, the antagonisms between human beings, develop their forces, intensify production, and facilitate civilizational progress. As Machiavelli instructed, the advantages of class struggle between the nobility and the people should not be underestimated.

> They do not consider that in every republic are two diverse humors, that of the people and that of the great, and that all the laws that are made in favor of freedom arise from their disunion [...] For whoever examines their end well will find that they have engendered not any exile or violence unfavorable to the common good but laws and orders in benefit of public freedom.[74]

The idea of the creative violence of oppositions has dominated bourgeois philosophy since Heraclitus. In his *Logic*, Hegel calls it the power of the negative; in his *Philosophy of History*, the cunning of reason. The concept of society, presented here in its first steps, and which these theorists first raised to consciousness—namely, the harmony of social and individual pur-

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[70] Horkheimer, "Vertrauen auf Geschichte" [1946], *MHGS* 12:119–127.

[71] Michel de Montaigne, *Essais*, book 3, chap. 9, ed. Pierre Villey, vol. 3 (Paris: Librairie Félix Alcan, 1931), 346.

[72] Voltaire, *Traité de métaphysique*, in *Œuvres complètes de Voltaire*, ed. Louis Moland, vol. 22 (Paris: Garnier Frères, 1879), 221–22.

[73] Voltaire. *Traité*, 233.

[74] Niccolò Machiavelli, *Discourses on Livy*, trans. H.C. Mansfield & N. Tarcov (University of Chicago Press, 1996), 16.

poses, of the universal and the particular—is actualized through the objective process of history. Marx's theory applies this conception to capitalism. Just as earlier social forms generated the conditions for higher, more organized social forms, more satisfactory social relations for a greater share of humanity, so the present-day social form develops all of the elements needed for the final fulfillment of the concept of the right society and with it the concept of the human being. Working class politics should strengthen these economic tendencies and drive them forward to the point of their reversal. In a discussion of the role of factory legislation as a defensive means for the industrial proletariat, we read the following:

> If the general extension of factory legislation to all trades for the purpose of protecting the working class both in mind and body has become inevitable, on the other hand, as we have already pointed out, that extension hastens on the general conversion of numerous isolated small industries into a few combined industries carried on upon a large scale; it therefore accelerates the concentration of capital and the exclusive predominance of the factory system. It destroys both the ancient and the transitional forms behind which the dominion of capital is still partially hidden, and replaces them with a dominion which is direct and unconcealed. [...] By maturing the material conditions and the social combination of the process of production, it matures the contradictions and antagonisms of the capitalist form of that process, and there by ripens both the elements for forming a new society and the forces tending towards the overthrow of the old one.[75]

Progress is, according to this theory, not unbroken, for just as every revolutionary period is preceded by periods of decline and tyranny, so the socialist one is preceded by a period of the direct, unconcealed domination of capital: fascism. The goal, however, despite all relapses, is just as surely laid out in advance for history as it is in the theories of bourgeois progressives: the rational self-preservation of associated humanity in confrontation with hostile nature.

Trust in history has replaced trust in God. It retains the conceptual realism of the Middle Ages in the sense that man fulfills his own concept through activity adequate to the course of history. While this concept is no longer linked to the concept of a Highest Being in a hierarchy of emanations, it is legitimized today through the authority of self-expanding rational civilization. However consciousless the economic, social, and psychological mechanisms that condition progress might be, the uniform direction in which their effects unfold constitutes an objective norm and bestows a significance to human interests beyond their status as subjective fact. Construction of a better society is just as much a matter of destiny for the revolutionary as integration into

[75] Marx, *Capital: Volume 1*, trans. B. Fowkes (Penguin, in association with New Left Review, 1976), 635.

existing social relations is for the bourgeois. Such a conception, through which the enlightened individual imagined he could outrun the meaninglessness of existence, represents a desperate synthesis. It contains the element of heteronomy: something given, something blind is supposed to guide the human being. And in this, it is akin to the belief in fate, to any myth. Actions are to be ordered according to the course of time: its wisdom is conformism. Its every deed, service to the overpowering, all-conditioning mechanism; its idol, mute facticity. However, by holding history to be the actualization of the human being, its principle is at the same time universal: the fulfillment of a principle which is valid for everyone. It is not just that something factual should be achieved, but something spiritual that should be actualized. Insofar as the trust in history is grounded on the concept of the human being and, therefore, theory is not completely betrayed for practice, it holds open a vision of the right society. No subject can make a concept the ground of its action without at the same time, though it might forfeit its life as a result, making the claim in such a way that every other subject can affirm it as their own. This is the idea of the unity of truth which lies at the foundation of Kantian idealism. The concept negates the false principle of individuality by assuming the oppositions in which domination fixes individuals as untrue. The same judgment that postulates domination as the existing order [*das Bestehende*], as what holds power, by the same token denounces it as bad, for in its conceptuality, in its claim to be valid for all, it points beyond domination. In recognizing the origin of such oppositions from uniform actuality, it holds open the vision of a better one—in which the true might unfold. Wherever a conceptual judgment denies humanity, it contradicts itself. No word can be used to degrade that does not condemn the speaker. An inkling of this survives in the belief in history insofar as it posits the concept of the human being. It is a form of humanism, the last before its passage into barbarism. In it, something of what was pronounced dead by positivism and galvanized by fascism still draws breath: language. By relating actuality to concept, it revealed at the same time the abyss between the figure captured by the word and its redemption.

But language relates to the universal ambivalently. It subsumes under concepts which are the same for all. But this predicated universal—valid as comprehensive, familiar, and fixed—is not adequate to the thing it ought apply to. The predicate seeks to concretize the subject through something abstract, to determine it through something undetermined. The name of the subject is provisional; the predicate would help it find the right one, the name that would unlock its secret. The judgment is an attempt to help beings express what they cannot say in their muteness. This is the meaning of language, that towards which it always intends, despite its weakness. Dialectical negation

holds fast to the idea of truth in the face of the weakness of discursive thinking; it would do justice to the subject of the judgment, the particular, even though the universal essence the judgment equates with the particular always spells the latter's doom. The specific negation, advancing with each specific thesis, negates the copula, because the identity established by the copula involves the logical suppression in the subject of what it cannot unfold in practice. The concept under which the subject is subsumed is adequate to the subject only to the extent the subject is already circumscribed and imprisoned. Hence, Bergson banished the copula from metaphysics; dialectics, however, would convert the insight into the inadequacy of the individual judgment into the vehicle of its completion, instead of denying life such expression altogether. The inadequacy lies in the conclusiveness [*Abgeschlossenheit*] of the predicate. The conceptual universal, the qualities, the physical, biological, psychological forms, are, in each case, the law according to which the particular 'goes to ground' [*zugrunde geht*], they express the finitude of the particular: because the subject is an animal, a human being, a man, it must come to nothing. Judgment apprehends the living as mere nature, even where it conceives of the particular not through physical but social categories, such as 'Nation' or 'State.' Nevertheless, the concept is not external to what it comprehends. What in a single breath the copula posits as opposite and equivalent to the subject as his own essence indirectly betrays something of the secret of his longing, one which nevertheless cannot be named. In the concept, fulfillment and suffering are undivided. Its fixity faithfully mirrors that of the society which serves life only by suppressing it, develops human beings only by mutilating them, and knows no 'homeland' as protection except by repressing the protected. This insight pervades Hegel's *Logic*: it develops the categories of the absolute as so many figures of decline. Its betrayal lies in the peace it makes with the content of such truth. Like Aristotle, it ultimately posits the finite as equivalent to what survives, the good as equivalent to what remains, and the forsaken as equivalent to the same categories through which it is forgotten. The *Logic*, a work which, like no other, is shot through with the injustice of judgment and so too of actuality, reposes into the system of judgments and belies the seriousness of the dialectic through the assumption of nothingness, pain, and death into the divine realm of the Idea. Through the *Logic* as a whole, the individual is supposed to recognize himself within and reconcile himself to the fate laid out before him by totality, no matter the hardship this may entail. By way of spirit, the individual is supposed to become one with the same order that spells his downfall. This is the goal of truth. The contradictions of history represent the opposition of the particular and the universal as it is driven to overcome itself, something Hegel still hoped for through politics until his *Phenomenology*. From the vantage of contemporary history: he let his hope

wane and settled for the relative humanity of the welfare state as the basis for fulfillment. From then on, he located this fulfillment in the thought—on the grounds of what had been historically achieved—of reconciliation in the realm of spirit, in culture.

And so, like all bourgeois philosophy, his became one of resignation, of stoicism. With Schopenhauer and Judaism, he shares the insight into the forsakenness of the individual; with Nietzsche, he says *'Yea'* to it. Modern existential philosophy, Heidegger's courage-to-be before transcendental angst, is yet another version of the same stoicism, the old *amor fati*, the worship of the world. Every individual step of the Hegelian dialectic, so long as it is incomplete, consists in the sublation of inadequate predication. The subject that knows itself only as *thing*, *man*, has, with such judgments, not yet arrived at itself. In the end, however, the knowledge formed through all these negations is supposed to be the absolute judgment: the adequate concept. Divine truth is the insight into the division of its becoming, the totality of its determinations; truth is the last stage, whereupon the penultimate stage and all that came before it are raised to the concept. Accordingly, the truth, despite all objectivity, is merely intellectual. It actualizes itself in the one step history does not take, the step that thinking—in the shape of religion, art, philosophy—must make all on its own. The elevation of thought to perfection itself instead of its determinate negation has always meant the transfiguration of the powers of this world into the innermost being of all that lives. Thought repeats the very injustice that imprisons it. When the concept exhausts the truth, no room is left within the living except for what power encloses it; all is given as conquered through the system, through the concept, and the rest is cast aside as nothing, non-actual, accident. Hegel struck upon the spirit of language like no other: in expressing the determinacy of the finite, it spells pain and annihilation for the finite. The particular pays for its reflection as divine through language: it is thereby identified with the universal, with doom, with the figures of domination in nature and history and, in the end, with war. Whoever says Being must necessarily mean Power and Death as well. And when his judgment is made in earnest, when the particular is viewed as having utterly gone over into Being, he has already sealed its fate as Nothing, as what has justly 'gone to ground' [*zugrunde geht*]. The identification of language with truth is the work of the devil, just as the separation of truth from language is mute despair. This is the highest insight their interpenetration offers. However much the universal is determined in thinking for the sake of justice to the particular, however much every determination strives to give the particular more precise expression, the net of determinations reflects the web of fate.

Only by mediating this insight does language transform from a magical-

mimetic technique into thinking. The concept is then neither, as in realism, a reproduction or reflection of the divine Idea nor, as in nominalism, a mere artifice or device without significance. The universal, object of the concept, becomes a negative for language; what it expresses, denunciation. By subsuming, it specifies suffering. When language names the universal, what binds human beings together is less that the universal by which they are captured in actuality recaptures them in thought, but rather that it says what holds them all in thrall. In such function alone does language shake the walls between human beings, behind which the identical is warped into the equality of the mutilated, the uniformity of the dominated. Skepticism and relativism, with all their knowledge of the conditionality of truth through the psychological individual, have always, through establishing the inadequacy of the concept, reinforced the absoluteness of its claim, albeit against their will. They are the sages of negation. Their summary procedure differs from dialectics in the generality and abstractness of the negation; dialectics relativizes the determinate judgment through the determinate antithesis and seeks, through its own limitation, to redeem the unlimited claim by which it points beyond itself. Fulfilling such a claim in itself—this is the meaning of every work of art. The work of art is, unlike the judgment, a totality: it means to enclose the truth inside itself, to reflect being as a whole. The work of art wants, like the judgment, to express what actuality is. And yet, whenever this is attempted, whenever, for example, the 9th Symphony is translated from musical into spoken language, the poverty of both is revealed. Where aesthetic means cannot reach, logical means fall short as well. Indeed only in this, the discrepancy between intention and fulfillment, is the promise unredeemed revealed. The repetition of the words '*Man*' and '*humanity,*' '*brotherhood*' and '*identity,*' is even more powerless than the duration of the work of art. In the absence of dialectical progression, the concept remains an abstract, harmless utopia. Language has always resisted the attempt to grasp the concept of the human being as something positive, to extract from it a principle beyond its reality; the attempt leads back to Stoicism, and, in the last instance, the idea of self-assertion. The highest point philosophy in such form beholds is a society in which agreement has been reached for the sake of maintaining dominion over all that is non-human all the more securely: the ideal of European philosophy, an exclusionary ideal in all its warmth and friendship. Human language points to no absolute goal. The principle opposite actual fact—which humanism believed it discovered in the concept of *the human being*, and whose fulfillment it ultimately saw in history—cannot be grasped by any concept. Unnamed, it lies at the ground of language and its concepts. The human beings who preserve themselves through society, as prescribed by their concept, practice domination, even if

the councils were to function so perfectly that the state truly withered away and only surrounding nature were to suffer the blindness of human beings. The power human beings wield in becoming equal to their universal concept recoils on the human heart. The universality that faith in history contained as its truth was not the collective, but rather the emancipation of the living from its compulsion. The community of suffering was formulated in the concept. To sight freedom in the concrete thought of unfreedom: this is the reconciling force of determination through negation. Trust in history, however, passes into such negation: into consciousness of the deficiency of language, which only helps the living find expression by making it the concept with which it coincides, just as the justice system need only address someone who once committed a crime as a "criminal" to destroy them once and for all. And this trust is not in progress, whether historical or logical. The progression of determination is no recipe language can always rely on, however much depends on it. The universal concept of the human being contains a memory evaporated in those of "the Jew" or "the German"; the proposition that lingers on determinations so exact heralds less the abolition of suffering than one which dwells on the abstract.

V. Magic of the Concept (1949)[76]

With the advance of enlightenment, ever wider stretches of the world are subject, in extension as much as in intensity, to the fixed concept. The test of the concept is always an increase in power, and not of personal power, belonging to one single person alone, but in the sense of a power at universal disposal. The concept is a tool like any other. The conditions of its production and application correspond to those of other means of production. It is, so to speak, the tool come into its own, the tool *kat exochen*. The tendency, particularly associated with 'the concept' in the sense used by Bergson, to mistake what is preserved in memory, the available store of collected data in one's possession, for the truth itself—today, this tendency appears before enlightenment itself, whose motor it once was, as a remnant of magic. It was once believed that with a lock of his hair, the absent enemy could be held in thrall; now, one imagines that because they hold the thing in thrall through its conceptual formula, that the formula is the thing itself. The *quid pro quo* is evident, and yet the whole question of the vocation of the human being is one and the same as that of an inner relationship between means and ends, practice and truth. However mad the fetishization of the means, the immediate positing-into-one [*Ineinssetzen*] of purpose and instrument, may seem, its antithesis, their radical separation, would necessarily nullify any hope humanity might have of arriving at the truth in any sense; even the greatest of philosophies only brand the identity of concept and being as mythical semblance [*Schein*] to the extent it has not been mediated—that is to say: as unearned, unappropriated, conceptless. Even in these greatest of philosophies, it is taken for granted that civilization will, as a matter of fundamental principle, catch up with the truth. Hegel considered his work as evidence that the Kantian abyss itself was bound to make Kant's own philosophy a farce.

Concept is tool, tool is plan. So long as the plan is not one of humanity, end and means diverge. The entrepreneur of the Victorian style was a planner; he was alienated from the powers of society, the fluctuations of commodity prices, the vicissitudes of economic cycles, wars, and revolutions, because other plans were suddenly ratified at the cost of his own. The market could, therefore, only appear as regulator because none of the individual planners who met there were actually strong enough to prevail, and between classes and nations, the market was something more ephemeral still. The more tightly organized the subject of the plan in itself, the stronger the plan. With the thoroughgoing organization of humanity according to a common plan, alienation ends, for

[76] Horkheimer, "Magie des Begriffs [1949]," *MHGS* 12:323–325.

nothing human is alien to it any longer. The process reaches its completion when the universal plan is no longer forced onto the individual as external violence, as even when the plan is ideologically disguised as one's own. The plan cannot be the administration of one by another, such that the distinction of the one from the other, as presupposition of the whole, eludes the concept. This was Marxist reason, the free association of humanity, free from the unplanned effects of social power. Only then, when each in their conduct becomes a means of the whole, do they also become an end to the whole and to themselves. Once the means is fully recognized as an end, we are freed from the domination of means.

However questionable the construction of classical—as well as proletarian—idealism may be, it is inherent in that first thought that, in the concept with which it sought to master beings, imagined it had touched upon truth, indeed in the first inkling that the expansion of human power is related to "right" living. The question is whether cognition is as fatefully chained to dominant conceptuality as it appears to be to such a logic, a logic which is itself so chained in its consistency. Attempted escapes from this logic—pure mediation, which is nevertheless straitjacketed by categories of domination; nonresistance, which bears the mark of dubious magical practice on its forehead; the humbug of sacred knowledge—none of these are truly tempting. The only rescue for thinking tired of the triumph of the means is to extend it to the point of its reversal. It is not true that enlightenment is at an end.

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